



Elder Wilds

Version 0.1.0

Generated 2026-07-17

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Elder Wilds

Target build: Skyrim Special Edition / Anniversary Edition runtime 1.6.1170 via Steam

Scope notes:

- No paid Anniversary Edition Creation Club content
- Research categories are organized around five pillars: modern graphics, expanded systems, modernized UI, immersive world scale, and third-person-first gameplay. The entire modlist is designed to be completely played in third-person with a gamepad — no interaction should require first-person or keyboard/mouse alone.
- This modlist is also built around Legacy of the Dragonborn as a major collection, museum, and patch-ecosystem pillar rather than treating it as an optional side add-on

Installation

The full setup and installation guide (Steam config, MO2 setup, SKSE, tool registration, operating rules) lives in `[install.md](install.md)`.

Research Workflow

- Work through one category at a time
- For each category, define goals, constraints, candidate mods, compatibility risks, and acceptance criteria
- Do not lock final picks until foundations, graphics baseline, animation framework, and UI framework are validated together
- Prefer mods with active maintenance, clear Steam 1.6.1170 support, strong patch ecosystem, and stable load-order behavior

Reference Docs

- [World Progression Philosophy](modlist-design-philosophy.md) — Design dial connecting leveling, encounter zones, loot distribution, difficulty, XP, and perks. Adopted combination for Elder Wilds: #1 Static with Hard Threat + “Living the World” layer (player home, family, slow questing).

Installation Guide

This document covers everything needed to set up the toolchain and environment for Elder Wilds. The section index and project scope live in modlist.md.

Pre-Installation: Steam, Skyrim, And Creation Kit

Steam & Skyrim Setup

1. Install Steam and Skyrim SE/AE outside Program Files, ideally under a shallow path such as C:\Games\Skyrim Special Edition.
2. Confirm the game is on runtime 1.6.1170. The Anniversary Upgrade is not used.

Configure Steam

- Disable the Steam Overlay: In Steam, go to Steam > Settings > In-Game and uncheck “Enable the Steam overlay while in-game.” Alternatively, disable it per-game: right-click The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition in your library, select Properties, and uncheck “Enable the Steam Overlay while in-game.”
- Update-proof Skyrim: In Steam, right-click The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition > Properties > Updates, set Automatic Updates to “Wait until I launch the game.” Updates will not trigger when launching through MO2 via SKSE. If an update slips through, use the [Skyrim downgrade patcher](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/32698/>) to roll back.

Vanilla Skyrim First Launch

Launch Skyrim Special Edition through Steam to open the default launcher: click Options, select the Ultra preset, set Aspect Ratio and Resolution to your monitor’s optimal values, set Antialiasing to Off (prepares for Community Shaders), ensure Windowed Mode is unchecked, click OK to save, and exit the launcher.

Install The Creation Kit

- Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit (https://store.steampowered.com/app/1946180/Skyrim_Special_Edition_Creation_Kit/): Download and install via Steam. Launch the Creation Kit through Steam to allow the Scripts folder to extract (automatic on first launch). Exit once loaded. Download the pre-made [CreationKitCustom.ini](<https://lexyslotd.com/guide/common-tasks/creation-kit-ini>) and extract it to the Skyrim root folder. This configures the CK to allow multiple masters and load DLC content. If the CK crashes on first launch, add an [outbound firewall rule](<https://docs.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/security/threat-protection/windows-firewall/create-an-outbound-port-rule>) for CreationKit.exe.
- Creation Kit Platform Extended (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/71371>): Download CK Platform Extended 0.6-b550 and extract directly into the main Skyrim Special Edition folder — NOT into a sub-folder.

Create Modding Folders And Install Core Tools

Create a separate modding path with sub-folders (e.g., C:\Modding and C:\Modding\Tools) and install the tools from the toolchain list below into C:\Modding\Tools.

FOMOD Plus Installation

Install FOMOD Plus - A Mod Installation Overhaul for Mod Organizer 2 (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141001>) after MO2 setup: extract the archive contents directly into your MO2 installation folder, merging the plugins folder. Restart MO2 — FOMOD Plus activates automatically, adding a FOMOD column in the left pane and a FOMOD tab on the right pane.

Core Setup Goals

- Build and maintain Elder Wilds through Mod Organizer 2 with clean separators and reproducible generated output
- Keep the setup aligned to Steam runtime 1.6.1170
- Separate source mods, generated outputs, patches, and downloads clearly enough that rebuilds and troubleshooting stay manageable

Recommended Base Toolchain

- [Mod Organizer 2](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/6194>) as the main mod manager and profile system
- [SKSE64](<https://skse.silverlock.org/>) and [Address Library for SKSE Plugins](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/32444>) as the runtime baseline
- [SSEEdit](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/164>) for conflict review, patch inspection, cleaning guidance, and record-level troubleshooting
- [Wrye Bash](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/6837>) for later leveled-list and compatibility review where it still adds value
- [Synthesis](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/140863>) for selective patcher-based automation once the stack is stable enough to justify it
- [Cathedral Assets Optimizer](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/23316>) for asset cleanup and conversion tasks when a mod actually needs it
- [BethINI Pie](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/153026>) for baseline INI management and graphics/settings normalization
- [Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit](https://store.steampowered.com/app/489490/Skyrim_Special_Edition_Creation_Kit/) for resaving LE plugins to SE format; used alongside [Creation Kit Platform Extended](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/71371>) for stability
- [xLODGen](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/10202>), [TexGen](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/68547>), and [DynDOLOD](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/68547>) for terrain/object/tree distant detail workflow
- BodySlide and Outfit Studio and Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus are installed as regular mods — see → [Characters & Creatures](modlist-graphics-characters.md) (BodySlide) and → [Animations](modlist-animations.md) (Pandora). They are still registered as MO2 executables (see tool registration below).

Mod Organizer 2 Setup

- Follow STEP's standalone-folder approach: keep the game under a shallow custom path such as C:\Games\Steam\steamapps\common\Skyrim Special Edition and keep modding tools under a separate path such as C:\Modding\Tools.
- Install Mod Organizer 2 as a standalone application under C:\Modding\Tools\Mod Organizer rather than inside the game folder.
- On first launch, create a global instance, select the Steam Skyrim Special Edition install, and name the instance something obvious like Elder Wilds 1.6.1170.
- If MO2 prompts for profile settings during instance creation, tick every box so the profile keeps its own INI files and game-specific settings.
- Connect MO2 to Nexus during first launch and let MO2 handle nxm links.
- In Settings > Workarounds, tick Enable archives parsing (experimental) so MO2 reports asset conflicts more reliably.
- Create at least one clean working profile before major category testing, and keep separators aligned to this repo's structure in separators.md.
- Keep generated outputs in their own enabled mods, never mixed into source mod folders.

Output Mods To Create In MO2

Before registering tools, create these empty mods in MO2 under the Output separator:

- xEdit Output
- SKSE Scripts
- SKSE Output
- BodySlide Output
- Pandora Output
- Grass Cache Output
- Terrain LOD Output
- TexGen Output
- DynDOLOD Output
- Occlusion Output
- Synthesis Output
- Bashed Patch Output

SKSE64 Installation

- Follow STEP's split install pattern for SKSE64 on Steam runtime 1.6.1170: install the two root files into the Skyrim game folder, but manage the Data portion through MO2 as its own mod.
- Use the current AE 1.6.1170 build of SKSE64, not an older AE build and not a GOG/VR variant.
- Copy skse64_loader.exe and the matching skse64_1_6_1170.dll from the archive into the Skyrim root folder next to SkyrimSE.exe.
- In MO2, create an empty mod named SKSE Scripts, then copy the archive's Data\Scripts folder into that mod so the script portion stays visible and manageable in the left pane.
- If an SKSE\skse.ini is needed later, place it inside the SKSE Scripts mod rather than writing directly into the game folder. Minimal modern baseline:

[General]

ClearInvalidRegistrations=1

[Display]

iTintTextureResolution=2048

- Register skse64_loader.exe in MO2 as the SKSE Skyrim Launcher executable and launch the game through that entry after the vanilla initialization step.
- Community troubleshooting on r/skyrimmods still clusters around the same mistakes: wrong runtime build, root files copied into the wrong folder, scripts not installed as a mod, or launching outside MO2. Guard against those explicitly.

Register Tools In MO2

- Open MO2's executable editor from the gear icon and add each tool with Add from file....
- Tick Use application's icon for desktop shortcuts for each entry so shortcuts remain readable.
- For tools that generate files, tick Create files in mod instead of overwrite and point them at the correct output mod.
- Arrange the executables in a stable order so the dropdown reflects the real workflow instead of becoming random over time.

MO2 Executable Reference

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
BethINI Pie	Bethini.exe	none	none	Run through MO2 so it edits the active profile INIs instead of global game INIs.
LOOT	LOOT.exe	--game="Skyrim Special Edition"	none	If LOOT fails through MO2, use --single-process --game="Skyrim Special Edition".
SKSE Skyrim Launcher	skse64_loader.exe	none	SKSE Output	Use this to launch the game after the root files are in the game folder and the SKSE Scripts mod is enabled.
xEdit	xEdit.exe	-SSE - IKnowWhatImDoing - AllowMasterFilesEdit	xEdit Output	Main conflict review and manual patching entry.
xEditQuickAutoClean	xEditQuickAutoClean.exe	-SSE	xEdit Output	Only use for plugins LOOT explicitly flags for cleaning.
xLODGen	xLODGenx64.exe	-lodgen -SSE - o:"DriveLetter:\Modding\Tools\xLODGen\xLODGen_Output"	Terrain LOD Output	Replace DriveLetter with the actual drive letter used for the modding folder.
TexGen	TexGen64.exe	-SSE	TexGen Output	Keep output isolated and pack it into the dedicated mod immediately after generation.
DynDOLOD	DynDOLODx64.exe	-SSE	DynDOLOD Output	Keep output isolated and enable DynDOLOD.esm /

				DynDOLOD.esp after generation.
Wrye Bash	Wrye Bash.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Register only if the list still needs a Bashed Patch or leveled-list review pass.
Synthesis	Synthesis.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Give it its own output mod once the final patcher set is known.
BodySlide	BodySlide x64.exe	none	dedicated body/output mod	Run through MO2 so mesh output respects the active profile and selected body stack.
Pandora	Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus.exe	none	dedicated behavior/output mod if needed	Run through MO2 so behavior generation sees the real virtualized animation stack.

MO2 Operating Rules

- Launch the game through SKSE, not through Steam or the stock launcher, after the vanilla initialization step is complete.
- Run LOOT before gameplay tests and before any major cleaning or conflict-review pass.
- Use xEditQuickAutoClean only for plugins LOOT explicitly marks as needing cleaning.
- Use xEdit after each major category to review conflicts instead of waiting until the whole list is assembled. The Patching Technique And Strategy section in modlist-foundations.md defines the workflow to follow from the first mod.
- Treat the Overwrite folder as a failure state; if files appear there, either move them into the proper output mod or fix the executable configuration that produced them.
- Rebuild generated outputs after major changes to bodies, animations, grass, LOD, or other systems that produce artifacts.
- Document manual fixes, custom arguments, and tool-specific decisions directly in this repository so the plan stays reproducible.

Foundations and Compatibility

MO2 Separators: Foundations → Foundations - SKSE & Scripts, Foundations - Core Libraries, Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes, Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes

All mods in this section are installed into the appropriate Foundations sub-separators as noted per group.

—

Core Framework Baseline → separator: Foundations (parent)

Install all core libraries and frameworks upfront — they are non-negotiable dependencies for virtually every mod in the list. Bulk-install prevents missing-master errors and lets every subsequent section work against the real framework stack.

SKSE & Scripts → separator: Foundations - SKSE & Scripts

- SKSE64 — Script extender; required by almost every SKSE plugin. [Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/30379>)

Core Libraries → separator: Foundations - Core Libraries

Mod	Purpose
[Address Library for SKSE Plugins](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/32444)	Universal SKSE plugin compatibility layer for 1.6.1170.
[USSEP](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/266)	Foundational record patch. Requires the four free CC masters — no paid AE Upgrade needed.
[SSE Engine Fixes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17230)	Critical engine-level stability and bug fixes.
[SSE Display Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34705)	Mandatory display and frame-pacing control.
[Scrambled Bugs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/43532)	Collection of low-level engine tweaks.
[powerofthree's Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51073)	SKSE plugin tweak framework; hard dependency for many modern mods.
[powerofthree's Papyrus Extender](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22854)	Extended Papyrus scripting functions.
[PapyrusUtil](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/13048)	Papyrus array/map utilities.
[JContainers](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16495)	JSON data storage for Papyrus.
[Keyword Item Distributor (KID)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/55728)	Distributes keywords to items without patching.
[Spell Perk Item Distributor (SPID)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/36869)	Distributes spells/perks to NPCs dynamically.
[Base Object Swapper (BOS)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/60805)	Swaps base objects via rules without direct overrides.
[Crash Logger SSE AE VR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/59818)	Crash dump logging for diagnosing CTDs.
[SkyPatcher](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/106659)	SKSE-based vanilla record patcher; hard requirement for several NPC/AI mods.
[Dual Casting Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/92454)	Required by Blade and Blunt.
[Andrealphus' Papyrus Functions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/85252)	Required by Dragon War.

[ConsoleUtilSSE NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/76649)	Required by Dragon War and several animation behavior mods.
[Kris's Papyrus Extender](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115164)	Required by Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed.
[Animation Queue Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/82395)	Animation-stack stability for heavy OAR/behavior loads.
[Papyrus Tweaks NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/77779)	Script-engine performance optimization; widely adopted baseline.
[Lexicon SKSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/153176)	Required by Actor Value Generator.
[Actor Value Generator](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/84743)	Required by Classic Attributes.
[XEMI Utility](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/159084)	Required by FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions.
[Sonders Keyword Distribution Resources](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/93995)	Keyword distribution framework for item/keyword tagging.
[Skyrim Save System Overhaul 3 (SSSO3)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/122343)	Save-system replacement with Save Shield, rotating caps, and safe timed hardsaves. Requires JContainers SE + NL_MCM.
[Unofficial Skyrim Modder's Patch - USMP SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/49616)	Modder-side patch collection fixing record-level bugs across DLC and CC content. Complements USSEP.
[USMP - Patch Emporium](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/50813)	Centralized patch hub for USMP — third-party compatibility patches for various content mods. Install after USMP base.
[Object Impact Framework (OIF)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/149484)	Physics-based object impact system; prerequisite for several immersion/destruction mods.

SSSO3 Configuration

Vanilla autosaves, quicksaves, and manual saves all write the same .ess format — the instability risk is when they fire (cell transitions, combat, half-evaluated script state), not the format. SSSO3 replaces vanilla triggers with a Save Shield that defers saves during unsafe states.

Installation:

1. Install requirements (already in Core Libraries): JContainers SE, NL_MCM - A Modular MCM Framework, Regional Save Names, SSE Engine Fixes
2. Install the SSSO3 main file and SSSO3 - French (if applicable). Place SSSO3 anywhere in load order.
3. Disable all vanilla autosaves in BethINI Pie: untick Autosaves, Save on Travel, Save on Rest, Save on Wait. SSSO3 force-deactivates them, but BethINI settings prevent the INI values from conflicting.
4. Disable iAutoSaveCount in Skyrim.ini ([SaveGame]) to prevent the engine from reserving autosave slots — SSSO3 manages its own.

In-game setup (required before the rotating system activates):

1. Create your character and exit the starting cell (alternate-start mod or vanilla Helgen sequence).
2. Make one manual save to generate a save file on disk.
3. Open the SSSO3 MCM. Go to Player Setup.

4. Press the Find Player ID button — SSSO3 reads it automatically from the save file. If it fails, use Bypass Check and type your character name exactly.
5. Assign a Quick Save key and a Quick Load key in the MCM.
6. Select a preset profile. For Elder Wilds, start with Vanilla+ — it replicates vanilla autosave behavior with Save Shield protection and timed saves, no hardcore restrictions.
7. From the MCM’s Rotating System page, set your preferred save cap (20-30 is reasonable for a playthrough).

Campfire users: SSSO3 must overwrite Campfire’s files. Use the Campfire patch included with SSSO3 and let SSSO3 win file conflicts in MO2.

SkyPatcher And SkyPatched Mods → separator: Foundations - Core Libraries

SkyPatcher is an SKSE plugin that patches vanilla records at runtime from INI-style configuration files rather than traditional ESP plugins. No winner-loser override chain, no per-pair patches for the records it covers.

A “SkyPatched” variant ships record changes as SkyPatcher configs instead of an ESP. Assets (meshes, textures, scripts) still install in MO2’s left pane, but the plugin slot is replaced by files under SKSE/Plugins/SkyPatcher/.

When to choose SkyPatched:

- Mod only changes vanilla records (book stats, weapon damage, armor ratings, ingredient values), not new records
- Load order is approaching the 254-plugin cap — each SkyPatched variant saves one ESP slot
- Multiple mods edit the same records — runtime application avoids patch debt
- Author explicitly provides a SkyPatched alternative

When to stick with traditional plugin:

- Mod adds new records (CELL, WRDL, QUST, NPC_ with facegen)
- Mod needs explicit load-order priority — Bashed Patch or xEdit patches give control that “all apply” doesn’t
- No SkyPatched variant available

Mods using SkyPatcher in this list:

- Book Covers Skyrim - SkyPatched (→ [Textures & Meshes](modlist-graphics-textures.md))
- Dawnguard Arsenal SSE - SkyPatched (→ [World Content](modlist-world-content.md))
- Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons — uses SkyPatcher for combat-mod compatibility (→ [Enemies & Creatures](modlist-creatures.md))
- Patchifier Synthesis patcher generates SkyPatcher patches (→ [Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration](modlist-performance-patches.md))

Mesh & Texture Fixes → separator: Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes

Mod	Purpose
Particle Patch	Particle shader/LOD corrections, CS-compatible.
Assorted Mesh Fixes	Corrections for common visual mesh errors.
Flickering Meshes Fix	Resolves distant-object mesh flicker in landscape transitions.

—

Official Masters Cleanup → separator: Foundations (parent)

Clean all six-plus vanilla masters before installing any mod. Use xEditQuickAutoClean on each file individually, collect cleaned .esm files into a Cleaned Vanilla Masters MO2 mod, and restore originals from xEdit Backups back into Data\.

Which Masters To Clean

- Skyrim.esm, Update.esm, Dawnguard.esm, HearthFires.esm, Dragonborn.esm
- All Creation Club .esm files shipped with 1.6.1170
- Do not clean _ResourcePack.esl — contains no ITM or UDR records.

Procedure

1. Create empty mod Cleaned Vanilla Masters under Output separator. Leave disabled.
2. Run LOOT, sort, apply, close.
3. For each .esm: select xEditQuickAutoClean from MO2 executables, check ONLY that master, wait for completion, close.
4. Move cleaned masters (recent mod date) from Data\ into Cleaned Vanilla Masters\ mod folder. Keep only .esm files; delete .backup/.bak.
5. Restore originals from xEdit Backups back into Data\.
6. Enable Cleaned Vanilla Masters in MO2. Run LOOT again — no masters flagged.

Risks & Compatibility

- Cleaning Update.esm is standard despite some mod-author cautions; USSEP's records win over cleaned originals.
- Never clean a third-party mod's plugin unless LOOT explicitly flags it — many mods ship ITMs intentionally.
- Cleaned Vanilla Masters must remain enabled for the entire playthrough.

—

Patching Technique And Strategy → separator: Foundations (parent)

Adopt the canonical xEdit mod-by-mod patching workflow: install one mod at a time, run xEdit in -veryquickshowconflicts mode, resolve only new conflicts, use per-pair patches and ModGroups. Reserve Bashed Patch and Synthesis for the categories they genuinely own.

Wrye Bash And The Bashed Patch

The Bashed Patch is an automatically generated plugin merging leveled lists, applying game-setting tweaks, and resolving category-tagged record conflicts. Replaces dozens of per-pair patches for the record types it owns.

Rebuild triggers: adding/removing leveled-list mods, changing .TweakSettings, adding a mod with Bash Tags, form-ID compaction. It is step 2 in the full build order (after SSEEdit, before Synthesis; see → [Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration](modlist-performance-patches.md)).

What the Bashed Patch does not do: resolve arbitrary record conflicts (→ xEdit/Synthesis), merge plugins (→ ESL flags), or iterative/rule-based patching (→ Synthesis).

Mods complementing or requiring Wrye Bash:

- Leveled-list expanders (Immersive Weapons, Immersive Armors, Hunterborn) — need Relev/Delev/Invent.Add tags
- World loot frameworks (Open World Loot, MorrowLoot Ultimate)
- Economy mods (Trade and Barter, Ars Metallica, Honed Metal, Apothecary) — need Stats/Invent.Change
- Lighting/weather (CS Light, True Light, RAID Weathers) — need C.Light/C.Water/C.Climate
- NPC/follower mods (RDO, Nether's, Serana Dialogue) — need Actors.* tags
- Audio overhauls (AOS, ISC, Sounds of Skyrim) — need Sound/C.Acoustic

Exact Bash Tag per plugin, .TweakSettings table, and build-order placement → [Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration](modlist-performance-patches.md).

Cyclic Workflow (per new mod)

1. Install and place. Heuristic: broad world-changers early; narrow/local edits late.
2. Run xEdit with -veryquickshowconflicts. Register xEdit in MO2 with that argument. Right-click → Hide no conflict and empty rows.
3. Try load order first. Move mod up/down if that resolves most conflicts; re-run.
4. Identify bad conflicts. Only conflicts where the loser was supposed to win.
5. Build per-pair patch. Copy as override into... → \<new file>.esp [Template] ESL. Name explicitly (e.g., LoreRim_x_RWT.esp). Drag missing fields from loser into new record. Accept master addition. Run Add Masters... for every referenced mod. Save into Patches separator.
6. Build per-pair ModGroups. One ModGroup per conflicting pair. Move *.ModGroup files from MO2 overwrite into the source mod's own MO2 folder.
7. Re-open xEdit and confirm zero visible conflicts.

Starting State

Clean load order (Skyrim.esm, Update.esm, three DLCs) plus USSEP. USSEP ships a premade ModGroup since xEdit 4.1.7 — keep it.

Cleaning Discipline

Run LOOT after new mod install. If flagged for cleaning, run Quick Auto Clean then Check For Errors. Red errors = reconsider the mod. QAC only removes ITM/UDR records.

ESL-Flagged Patches

Always use \<new file>.esp [Template] ESL for patches. Never manually re-flag ESP↔ESL unless the mod author or xEdit explicitly says to.

Risks & Compatibility

- Keep Bashed Patch and Synthesis scoped — don't let them absorb every decision.
- Date-stamp patches and re-run xEdit after every source-mod update.
- Patches copying from downstream plugins inherit unresolved conflicts — read the master chain.
- xEdit normal mode writes current loaded state — never use it to save. Save only in fast mode.
- Promote tiny per-pair patches into themed region/feature patches when count becomes unmanageable.
- Deliberately test that disabling one upstream source mod cleanly stops its ModGroup and dependent patches.

—

ESP To ESL Conversion → separator: Foundations (parent)

Converting ESP to ESL-flagged ESP frees a regular plugin slot (limit 254) by moving into the 4096 light-plugin address space.

What Makes A Plugin Convertible

- Fewer than 2048 new record forms
- No new CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records
- No QUST/DIAL overrides with hard-coded form ID references
- Trivially convertible: Bodyslide outputs, SKSE plugin dummy ESPs, texture-replacer ESPs

Automated Discovery

1. Built-in script: Find ESP plugins which could be turned into ESL.pas — ships with SSEEdit.
2. Fractal's ESP-ESL Finder v1.1 ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117978>))
3. ESLify ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/42211>)) — batch-convert wrapper. Verify candidates manually first.
4. SSEEdit Script - Header Change to Version 1.71 ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/115056>)) — unlocks full 4095-record range for 1.6.1130+.

Safe Conversion (low risk)

1. Right-click → Compact Form IDs for ESL.
2. Right-click → Set Is-Esl Flag (ESL only, not ESM).
3. Save. Re-sort with LOOT.

Full Conversion (xEdit workflow)

1. Load plugin + dependencies. Apply Hide no conflict and empty rows.
2. Right-click → Compact Form IDs for ESL. If zero, skip to step 4.
3. Check for broken references: Run Check for Errors; for external refs, load full load order → Referenced By → Apply as filter; or use List records referencing specific plugins.pas.
4. Right-click → Set Is-Esl Flag (ESL only).
5. Save. Re-sort.

Red Lines

- Never convert plugins with CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records without verifying every cross-reference.
- Never convert mid-playthrough.
- Never convert a plugin another mod lists as a master without verifying.
- ESL-flagged plugins still count toward the 4096 light-plugin limit.

Recommended Candidates

- Bodyslide outputs, texture-replacer ESPs, SKSE plugin dummies
- Single-weapon/armor/spell mods with <50 new records and no scripts
- Crafting recipe-only ESPs
- Patches created via [Template] ESL

Never Convert

- Major quest mods (LotD, Interesting NPCs, Vigilant)
 - City/settlement overhauls with new CELL or WRLD records
 - Overhauls with new dialogue branches or follower framework quest aliases
 - Any plugin LOOT or SSEEdit flags as not ESL-safe
-

Targeted Bugfix Mods → separator: Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes

Mod	Purpose
[Fuz Ro D-oh - Silent Voice](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/15109)	Subtitle safety for unvoiced dialogue.
[Actor Limit Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/32349)	Crowded scene / facial animation reliability.
[Equip Enchantment Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42839)	Enchantments dropping off while equipped.
[NPC AI Process Position Fix - NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69326)	NPC processing after waiting/fast travel.
[Simple Offence Suppression](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/41764)	Accidental hostility from stray hits.
[Bug Fixes SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/33261)	Crafting-menu, perk-application, and water-behavior fixes.
[Navigator - Navmesh Fixes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/52641)	Follower pathing in complex worldspaces.
[Barter Limit Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/77173)	Merchant gold cap overflow.
[Mum's the Word NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/77409)	Worthless stolen-item tagging.
[Regional Save Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/49698)	Save labeling for testing hygiene.
[Better Jumping SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/18967)	Consistent jumping control.
[LeveledList Crash Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/129136)	Leveled-list crash protection.
[Explosion Collision Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/154076)	Prevents explosion-force spells from launching objects into camera.
[Beard Mask Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80232)	Beards use slot 44 — prevents mask clipping. SKSE plugin.
[Luma Utility](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/177961)	Utility SKSE plugin.
[Description Framework Patch Hub](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139077)	Centralized patch collection for the Description Framework.
[Weapons Armor Clothing and Clutter Fixes (WACCF)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/18994)	Broad record fix for weapon/armor/clothing/clutter records. High compatibility debt — test carefully with the crafting and artifact stack. Optional — skip if conflicts outweigh gains.

Not Installed

- Alt-Tab Stuck Key Fix ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/148466>)) — Prevents stuck modifier keys after alt-tabbing. Optional fix, evaluate if alt-tab issues arise during testing.
- I'm Walkin' Here NG with Pets ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/122516>)) — Ally/pet body-blocking fix.

- Bard Instrumentals Mostly - Sing Rarely ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/10927>)) — Repetitive tavern singing. Not needed — other bard mods cover this. → separator: Audio - SFX & Ambience

Graphics Pipeline

MO2 Separator: Graphics

Overview

This section owns the full graphics rendering pipeline for Elder Wilds: from the post-process shader framework through textures, lighting, weather, water, terrain, characters, and distant detail. Each pillar of the pipeline lives in its own sub-file.

The pipeline is designed to be evaluated in order — each stage depends on the one before it. Do not jump ahead to textures or characters before the Community Shaders framework and its addon modules are locked.

Pipeline Order

Stage	File	Category
1	[Graphics - PGPatcher](modlist-graphics-pgpatcher.md)	PGPatcher — parallax/PBR mesh generation
2	[Graphics - Community Shaders](modlist-graphics-shaders.md)	Community Shaders — post-process framework and addon modules
3	[Graphics - Textures & Meshes](modlist-graphics-textures.md)	Textures & Meshes — all surface-level asset replacement
4	[Graphics - Lighting](modlist-graphics-lighting.md)	Lighting — interior, exterior, and effect lighting
5	[Graphics - Weather & Water](modlist-graphics-weather.md)	Weather & Water — atmospheric and liquid rendering
6	[Graphics - Terrain & Flora](modlist-graphics-terrain.md)	Terrain & Flora — ground surfaces, grass, trees
7	[Graphics - Characters & Creatures] (modlist-graphics-characters.md)	Characters & Creatures — body, skin, hair, creature textures
8	[Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail](modlist-graphics-lod.md)	LOD & Distant Detail — far-field rendering

Key Principles

- PGPatcher runs after the texture and mesh stack is stable → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Community Shaders is the universal post-process baseline; no ENB is used → Graphics - Community Shaders
- All texture and shader choices must be evaluated for third-person readability at 4K
- Performance budgeting for the pipeline is owned by `modlist-performance.md` → Performance
- Visual coherence rules (no mixing low-res and high-res in the same category) are owned by `modlist-curation.md` → Testing & Curation

PGPatcher

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - PGPatcher

All items in this section belong to the Graphics - PGPatcher MO2 separator unless noted.

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PGPatcher Workflow → separator: Graphics - PGPatcher

PGPatcher is a post-installation patcher that generates parallax and PBR-compatible meshes from the installed texture and mesh stack. It must run after the main texture, mesh, parallax, and PBR candidate set is mostly chosen so it works against a stable asset baseline.

Mod	Type	Notes
[PGPatcher](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/120946)	Baseline	Post-installation parallax/PBR mesh generator. Keep output in own MO2 folder.

Workflow Rules

1. Run after installing/changing PBR texture packs, parallax-enabled textures, or major mesh/parallax support mods.
2. Let the generated patch load after the source texture/mesh mods it supports.
3. Re-run whenever a major landscape, architecture, ruins, or clutter texture pack is replaced.
4. Only keep generated output if it produces visible improvement without new artifacts.
5. Hard requirement for mods such as [Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/175453>).

Alternatives

- Skip route: rely on hand-authored parallax meshes from individual texture packs and skip post-processing entirely.

Risks & Compatibility

- Running PGPatcher before the texture stack is stable means regenerating the patch each time a texture mod changes.
- Generated output can conflict with hand-authored parallax meshes — always test before committing the generated patch.

Community Shaders

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Community Shaders

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Community Shaders MO2 separator unless a different one is noted.

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Community Shaders Core Setup → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders

This section owns the graphics-framework decision for the shader-first visual stack. Build modern visuals around Community Shaders, then layer materials, lighting, weather, water, and distant detail on top.

Baseline

- Community Shaders ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/86492>)) — Core framework.
- Validate prerequisites before judging later graphics layers: SKSE64 ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/30379>)), Address Library for SKSE Plugins ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/32444>)), Luma Utility ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/177961>)), and any current page-listed dependencies.
- Record baseline performance before installing add-ons so module decisions are measured against a real control point.

Alternatives

- Non-CS alternatives (ENB) are out of scope unless the project abandons the shader-first direction.

Risks & Compatibility

- Some CS features are much heavier than the core framework.
- Older ecosystem pages may refer to legacy behavior or outdated version requirements.
- A shader-first stack still needs discipline; enabling every feature isn't the same as building a coherent visual direction.

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Community Shaders Add-Ons And Required Features → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders

How aggressive the first CS feature layer should be — improve shadowing, wetness, water response, and material depth without front-loading the full performance cost.

Feature Tiers

Tier	Modules	When To Enable
Conservative	Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Water Effects, Wetness Effects	Start here
Balanced	Conservative + Terrain Shadows	After trees, grass, weather, water, LOD are stable
High-End	Balanced + SSGI, Subsurface Scattering	Luxury, not requirement

Install the CS main download (v1.7+) and enable modules via FOMOD. Install optional plugins separately.

Plugins (separate downloads from core)

- Skylighting — Sky-driven ambient occlusion. Pairs cleanly with the conservative tier. Worth including for authentic grim-dark look.
- Skyrim Upscaler - DLSS FSR2 XeSS ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/80343>)) — Only if real performance testing proves it's needed.
- Embers XD ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37085>)) — The fire-and-ember answer (140K+). Install after lighting overhauls so it inherits their campfire/hearth placements. → separator: Graphics - Lighting

Optional separate plugin downloads: Cloud Shadows, Hair Specular, HDR, SSGI, Skylighting, Terrain Helper, Terrain Blending, Terrain Variation, Upscaling, Wetness Effects.

Related Add-Ons

Mod	Description	Nexus
[Dynamic Wetness](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/158207)	Wetness VFX triggered by swimming, rain, and water contact. SKSE plugin, complements CS Wetness Effects.	

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Graphics Testing Protocol

Recommended Tool Stack

- Performance capture: PresentMon
- Analysis and graphing: CapFrameX
- Record keeping: Markdown table in this repo first, spreadsheet only if comparison volume grows
- Visual comparison: fixed test saves plus matching screenshot captures

Test Scene Rules

- Use the same character save for all graphics testing.

- Same location, camera angle, FOV, and time of day for each comparison pass.
- Keep one indoor test cell and at least two outdoor test cells: forest and open landscape.
- Record weather state for every run.
- Add or remove only one graphics variable at a time.

Suggested Metrics

- Average FPS
- 1% low FPS
- Frame-time consistency notes
- VRAM pressure notes from monitoring tools
- Shader artifacts, flicker, ghosting, water issues, grass mismatch, shadow instability
- Subjective visual verdict: keep, retest, reject

Markdown Table Format

Date	Build	Test Area	Weather/ Time	Mod Change	Avg FPS	1% Low	Visual Notes	Decision
YYYY-MM-DD	Steam 1.6.1170	Falkreath Forest	Overcast / 3 PM	Added Grass Lighting	00	00	Better depth, no flicker	Keep

Risks & Compatibility

- Module stacks that look good in isolation can fight later weather, water, or lighting winners.
- Measuring several shader changes at once makes later decisions impossible to trust.
- Screenshot appeal can hide long-session readability or frame-time problems.

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Parallax Framework Dependencies → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders

Auto Parallax and Complex Parallax Materials form the parallax rendering layer bridging CS parallax support with mesh and texture mods downstream.

Baseline

- Install Auto Parallax ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79473>)) and Complex Parallax Materials ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/95134>)) as infrastructure before adding parallax-enabled textures or meshes. CPM hard-depends on Auto Parallax. Install after the texture stack is mostly chosen but before PGPatcher runs.

Risks & Compatibility

- Without Auto Parallax, Complex Parallax Materials will not function — both must be present.
- Installing too early means regenerating parallax data after texture changes; install after the main texture stack is locked.

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Physically Based Rendering (PBR) Support → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders

PBR is an adoption strategy layered on top of Community Shaders, not a separate renderer choice. The real decision is how selectively to use PBR-ready materials and conversions.

Baseline — Balanced PBR Route

Broad AIO base + targeted terrain and rock overrides.

- Vanilla PBR AIO ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/174091>), 11.5 GB) — Primary base. Covers all architecture, clutter, actors, dungeons with vanilla-faithful art direction.
- Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/125308>), 3.0 GB) — Fills VPBR's terrain gap. Do NOT install Faultier's Skyrim AIO alongside VPBR.
- Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/121336>)) — Modern rock/mountain overhaul. Load after VPBR to override its mountain textures. Install both main files (meshes then textures, choose PBR in FOMOD).
- Tomato's PBR Whiterun ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/135771>)) — Optional Whiterun override. Install 2K (735 MB), skip 4K (2 GB). Optional: Improved Dragon Carvings (beta, 2K) and PBR Talos.
- Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0 ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/135774>)) — Optional farmhouse override. Install Grey 2K (84 MB), skip 4K. Optional: WSU PBR Farmhouse windows patch if Window Shadows Ultimate is in the stack.

Community Shaders ships Dynamic Cubemaps and Image-Based Lighting (IBL) as standard features. Verify the chosen PBR texture set uses both before adding extra reflection/cubemap mods.

Alternatives

- Minimal PBR: Enable support but only use a few showcase conversions.
- Full PBR push: Broad world coverage with higher maintenance and consistency risk.

Priority Coverage

Priority 1 — seen constantly in travel and third person:

- City architecture; farmhouses and rural buildings
- Nordic ruins and dungeon stonework
- High-visibility clutter and props

Priority 2 — fill in after core look settles:

- Select landscape regions with strong material identity
- City sets from settlement overhauls that survive later testing
- Broader regional packs that fill obvious gaps

Defer for now:

- Full-world landscape replacement
- Low-visibility assets adding patching/VRAM cost without changing moment-to-moment feel
- Niche regional conversions before core city/dungeon/farmhouse look is settled

Priority 2 Candidate Mods

- A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/137333>))

- TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/177621>))
- PBR textures for The Great Cities Collection ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/133493>))
- PBR Hub ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139889>)) — Discovery hub for later expansion.

Working Rollout Order

1. Install Vanilla PBR AIO — broad PBR base for architecture, clutter, actors, dungeons.
2. Install Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k — fills VPBR's terrain gap.
3. Install Enhanced Rocks and Mountains after VPBR — overrides VPBR's mountain textures.
4. Optionally install Tomato's PBR Whiterun and Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0 after VPBR.
5. Run PGPatcher last — all PBR texture mods above require it.
6. Only after core stack passes review, test optional landscape additions (Cathedralist's PBR Landscape, TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO).

Risks & Compatibility

- VPBR is newer (March 2026) than Faultier's PBR Skyrim (v3.0) — single-point-of-failure risk if abandoned. Active development so far (v1.0 → v1.32 in 2 months).
- Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k + ERM cover VPBR's landscape gap; Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes covers the gear gap.
- VPBR includes mountain textures that must be overridden by ERM. Load ERM after VPBR.
- Do NOT install Faultier's Skyrim AIO alongside VPBR — same texture paths.
- PBR ambition can outrun the rest of the stack if weather, trees, water, and lighting aren't held to a similar bar.

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Open Research

Open research for the graphics pipeline is tracked in `TODO.md`.

Textures & Meshes

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Textures & Meshes

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Textures & Meshes MO2 separator unless a different one is noted.

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Mesh Improvements And Parallax Support → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

Improve shape quality and silhouette readability without creating an unmaintainable conflict swamp. The best outcome is a stable baseline of mesh improvements, targeted fixes where they matter, and parallax support only where textures benefit from it.

🕒 Install order: Core foundation → doors & walls → locks → furniture & city detail → mesh replacers → environment props → alternatives. Follow the grouping below.

Core Foundation

Mod	Description	Nexus
Static Mesh Improvement Mod (SMIM)	Core mesh foundation. → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/659)
Unofficial Material Fix	Corrects material records for Community Shaders PBR. Install after SMIM.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/21027)
Simplicity of Snow v0.26	Main file only (32.8 MB). Skip Parallax Meshes and patches for mods not in the list.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56235)
XEMI Utility	Prerequisite for FYX collision fixes below.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/159084)
FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions	Collision geometry fix. Requires XEMI Utility.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/100295)
Flame VFX Edit	Mesh-only fire spell effect improvement. CS-compatible.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/109414)

Doors, Walls & Structures

Mod	Description	Nexus
Glorious Doors of Skyrim (GDOS)	Higher-detail door meshes for all architecture types. FOMOD: 2K textures, install all door categories, include Splendid Mechanized Dwemer Door (ESL).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/32376)
Whiterun Has Walls Redone	3D geometry and parallax textures for Whiterun's exterior walls. Replaces flat walls.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/119229)
Stockades of Skyrim 3D	Base layer for 3D stockade walls and barricades.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/43227)

FYX - 3D Stockades	Overwrites Stockades of Skyrim 3D meshes. Install after the stockade base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65104)
Born in a Barn - Door Curtains for Shacks	BOS-based door curtains for shacks and poor homes. No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/113432)

Security Overhaul SKSE Series

Install together. Use 2K textures for all — locks are examined up close but 4K is wasted VRAM.

Mod	Nexus
Lock Variations	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/58224)
Regional Locks	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/62781)
Lock Add-ons	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/59529)
Some More Locks	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/59961)
Extra Locks	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126119)
PBR	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/152269)

Furniture, Clutter & City Detail

Mod	Description	Nexus
Snazzy Furniture and Clutter Overhaul (SFCO)	Clutter objects, geometry, and variety beyond VPBR's base textures.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2414)

Snazzy City series (BOS-based, city-by-city clutter improvements):

Mod	Nexus
Whiterun AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147621)
Windhelm AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147620)
Solitude AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147618)
Markarth AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147624)
Riften AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147594)
Falkreath AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147671)
Dawnstar AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147758)
Winterhold AIO	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/150194)
Towns and Settlements	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147761)

Misc Locations	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147762)
Player Homes	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/182336)
Snazzy Interiors - Dawnstar Mortar and Pestle	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/140567)
Snazzy Interiors - Winterhold Birna's Oddments	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/138308)
Snazzy Interiors Patch Collection	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/91604)

Mesh Replacer Series

All mesh-only, no ESP.

Mod	Nexus
V.A.E.R.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/145018)
Thrones Expanded	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/139544)
Rustic Repose - A Common Bed Replacer	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/138889)
Use Those Blankets	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/75481)
Sleipnir Beds	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/143168)
The Royal Seat	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118892)
Divide and Conquer	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117295)
Oddments and Miscellanea	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118859)
Utenlands Nordic Tents	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/121203)
Redoran Reverie	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/132997)
HF's Archery Target Remodel	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/138492)
Diverse Grindstones	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/145870)
Blary's Booksets	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/159303)
ElSopa Misc Ruins Redone	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/153797)
Snazzy Orc Chests	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/142275)

Environment & Props

Mod	Description	Nexus
TB's 3D Driftwood	3D driftwood mesh replacer. No ESP. Complements coastal areas.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80418)
WiZkiD Hunter's Camp Overhaul	Visual overhaul for hunter camps (tents, campfires, pots, clutter). No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113558)
Improved Fish SE	Higher-quality fish meshes and textures.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17324)
Improved Fish PBR	PBR textures for fish. Requires Improved Fish SE as mesh base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/145624)
CC Fish PBRed	PBR textures for CC fish. Requires free AE fish addon.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131083)
JS Badges of Office	Replacer for Jarl's crown, court-mage's circlet, steward's key. Mesh-only, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/128579)

> PGPatcher: Use the PGPatcher workflow in → Graphics - PGPatcher for late-stage parallax generation rules.

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
High Poly Project	Optional. Keep only if the extra geometry earns its conflict cost.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/12029)
RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION	Higher-res diffuse/normal replacer. May be redundant with VPBR's clutter coverage — evaluate side-by-side.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5795)

Mesh Section Notes

- High Poly Project adds overlap and complexity for surprisingly small on-screen gains.
- Parallax looks excellent on some surfaces and broken on others if support is inconsistent.
- Snow, rock, landscape, and water meshes should not be finalized independently of texture and weather winners.

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Furniture, Clutter, And Item Replacers → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

Texture and mesh upgrades for furniture, clutter, and items beyond the Snazzy city series — Rally's, Arc's, and Kanjs author lines plus standalone BOS replacers. No cell-record edits; all are BOS-based or pure replacers.

Rally's, Arc's, And Snazzy Clutter

Mod	Description	Nexus
Rally's Noble Furniture - BOS		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/113326)
Rally's Orc Furniture		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111457)
Rally's Upper Furniture		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/112256)
Rally's Barsets		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114178)
Rally's Common Furniture		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/110370)
Rally's Dark Elf Furniture (High Poly - ENB Light)		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/112042)
Snazzy Common Wardrobes - BOS	Choose the BOS meshes main file.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/92809)
Whiterun Objects SMIMed (and fixes too)		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/69125)
Arc's WispMother Redux 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111330)
Arc's Kettle REDUX 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/110929)
Arc's Kitchen Redux 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111694)
Arc's MeadBarrel Redux 2K-4K	Stack: install all three (base + Bloody + Distributed). Choose 2K for base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111195)

Arc's Bloody MeadBarrel Redux		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116447)
Distributed Arc's Mead Barrels		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/119006)
Arc's Tankard Redux		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112567)
ElSopa - HD Iron Tools Redone SE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/60495)
Diverse BOS Kitchenware		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112361)
Dynamic Things Alternative - BOS		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/60741)
Nordic Stonewalls		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/57686)
Nordic Stonewall Terraces		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115210)
Nordic Stonewalls Complex Material and PBR	PBR upgrade. Install after base Nordic Stonewalls.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/127188)
Snazzy Wall Mounted Trophies - BOS		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115054)
Fluffy Wall Mounted Dead Animals		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/90369)
Wall Mounted Dead Animals Fixes	Install after Fluffy Wall Mounted Dead Animals.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/58511)
Snazzy Diverse Carriages - BOS		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112041)
Snazzy Diverse Carriages - Seasonal Patch	Required if Seasonal Landscapes is adopted.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112210)

Vanaheimr Series

Mod	Nexus
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[Vanaheimr - Mines and Caves - Complex Material - PBR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/137033)	[Vanaheimr - Ore Veins - Complex Material - PBR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/149148)
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Animated Items (mesh replacers)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Kanjs - Sanguine Rose Animated		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/113606)
Kanjs - Soup and Stew AIO Animated (SkyPatched)	Choose the SkyPatched version over the base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/113191)
Kanjs - Human Heart Animated and Beating Motion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/111616)
Kanjs - Taproot Animated and Beating Motion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/111446)
Animated Filled Soul Gems		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/110638)
Animated Ingredients		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/72852)
Kanjs - Stalhrim Weapons Animated	Animated Stalhrim weapon mesh replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/146167)
Kanjs - Nordic Puzzle Door Animated	Animated Nordic puzzle door mesh replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/133482)

Risks & Compatibility

- Kanjs Soup and Stew has two variants: the base animation mod (113104) and a SkyPatched version (113191). The SkyPatched version is recommended for better compatibility.
- Nordic Stonewalls + Complex Material: install the base mod first, then the PBR upgrade on top.
- Most Rally's and Arc's mods are texture-only or mesh-only; verify each against the load order for BOS overrides.
- Snazzy Diverse Carriages Seasonal Patch hard-depends on Seasonal Landscapes (→ Terrain & Flora).

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Unique Entity Replacers → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

Model and texture upgrades for unique named entities and one-of-a-kind objects — characters, corpses, set-piece models not covered by broad replay packs. Closes visual gaps without swelling into full NPC beautification.

Mod	Description	Nexus
Night Mother	High-quality model/texture replacer for the Night Mother's corpse. ESL-flagged, zero script or record conflicts.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/83527)
Skyland Imperial and Nordic Tents	4K tent textures with new mesh for the large Nordic fur tent. No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57002)

Risks & Compatibility

- Verify Night Mother does not conflict with lighting/interior overhauls that modify the sanctuary cell.
- Do not let this subsection grow into general NPC or creature overhaul — those are owned by → NPCs.

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Blood, Decals, And Combat Visual Effects → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

In-world visual effects during combat: blood pools, persistent decals, lingering marks. Separate from lighting/weather (ambient worldstate) and from hit-reaction/stagger (→ Third-Person Gameplay, → Expanded Systems).

Mod	Description	Nexus
Dynamic Bloodpool Framework	Blood and decal framework. Lock in after weather/lighting baselines are stable (decals must read correctly under both daylight and your night setup).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172080)
Dragon Breath VFX Edit	Dragon breath projectile/impact VFX replacer. Mesh-only, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118431)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Improved Sparks	Orange spark effects on metal impacts and grindstones. FOMOD with density options (1X-20X).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/19831)
Lightning VFX Edit	Lightning bolt VFX replacer. Mesh-only, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/124520)
Dynamic Footprints SKSE	Persistent footprints on snow, mud, sand. Add after blood/decals baseline is stable.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175254)

Risks & Compatibility

- Blood/decals can interact poorly with CS weather mods handling screen-space wetness. Verify under a locked weather baseline.
- Persistent blood decals can strain frame-rate and memory in long fights. Check MCM for decal lifetime and density.
- Blood pools can look odd in snowy regions if the framework lacks surface-specific blending.
- Ownership scope: persistent decals/pools, not hit-effect layer.

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Book and Paper Visual Overhauls → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

Visual upgrades for books, notes, and paper — the most-read world objects. Texture and mesh improvements make reading feel more tactile and library exploration more rewarding without touching gameplay records.

🌀 Install order: Book Covers Skyrim → Enhanced Textures → SkyPatched → Lost Library (optional content).

Base + Enhancements

Mod	Description	Nexus
Book Covers Skyrim	Core book-cover texture replacer. Every book gets a unique hand-crafted cover. 200K+ endorsements. Choose the Main Files download (not the USSEP Update variant).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/901)
Book Covers Skyrim Enhanced Textures	2K/4K texture upgrade. Install after base mod and overwrite. Optional but recommended for 4K displays.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/178820)
Book Covers Skyrim - SkyPatched	SkyPatcher-based forward-port resolving record-level conflicts. Choose Recommended Main File.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/109254)
Book Covers Skyrim - Lost Library	Adds 150+ lore books from earlier TES games. Content companion; quest-level decision owned by → [World Content](modlist-world-content.md).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/902)

Risks & Compatibility

- With USSEP in the load order, use the SkyPatched variant — it handles USSEP forwarding plus broader compatibility.
- Enhanced Textures is recommended for 4K displays. At 2K the base BC7 textures are adequate.
- Verify compatibility with mods touching book inventory records (e.g. Unread Books Glow). SkyPatched resolves most record-level conflicts.
- Base mod is 600 MB for 2K. Evaluate whether unique book covers earn their VRAM and disk space cost.

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Optional Texture And Mesh Replacements → separator: Graphics - Textures & Meshes

Small texture/mesh replacers that don't fit the main topic sections above. Each is a single-author or single-object upgrade. Adopt selectively based on which objects actually draw the eye in regular play.

Mod	Notes
[Visual Animated Enchants](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/7037)	Original VAE — superseded by V.A.E.R. in the main Mesh Replacer Series. Keep only if V.A.E.R. conflicts.
[Apophysis Dragon Priest Masks SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/5800)	Dragon priest mask retexture. Optional cosmetic upgrade.
[Runed Nordic Weapons](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/11559)	Nordic weapon mesh/texture replacer.
[Elven Armor replacer glow](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/73235)	Elven armor retexture with glow maps.
[Elsopa Iron weapons redone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/52605)	Iron weapon retexture.
[Ennead Banners and Shields](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/46360)	Banner/shield retexture.
[Elsopa Quivers Redone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65921)	Quiver retexture.
[Believable greatswords sheathed](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/36909)	Greatsword sheath mesh fix.
[ElSopa - HD Medieval anvil](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/48825)	Anvil retexture.
[Elsopa Grindstones](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/58149)	Grindstone retexture.
[Renthal's workbench](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/23164)	Workbench retexture.
[VFX Edit AIO - Spells Retexture](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/133774)	Spell visual effect retexture.
[JFresh's Mead Stein - A Tankard Replacer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26685)	Mead stein/tankard retexture.
[SD's Horn Candles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/40192)	Candle retexture.
[JS Dragon Claws](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57038)	Dragon claw retexture.
[Skyrim Remastered - Soul Gems](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/39397)	Soul gem retexture.
[Rally's Market Stalls](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/81282)	Market stall retexture.
[KanJS Spell Tomes Animated](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/103057)	Animated spell tome mesh replacer.
[Alt Markarth Forge](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/88936)	Markarth forge retexture.

[HD Unique Handmade Signs (ElSopa)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/21704)	Inn/shop sign retexture.
[Skyking Windhelm Bridge Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/147846)	Windhelm bridge mesh/texture replacer.
[Tomato's Windhelm - PBR or Complex Material](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174492)	Windhelm city-wide PBR retexture. 2K main file recommended.
[Distinguished Drapery](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/173894)	Curtain/hanging fabric retexture.
[The Mists of Blackreach](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/179487)	Blackreach mist/fog visual effect overhaul.
[Valhalla Bridges](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/157314)	Higher-detail bridge mesh replacers. Mesh-only, no ESP.
[Valhalla Bridges - Addons Patches and Fixes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/157804)	Compatibility patches and addon coverage for Valhalla Bridges. Install after base.
[Improved Closefaced Helmets](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/824)	Mesh/texture overhaul for closed-face helmets.
[Improved Closefaced Helmets - SkyPatched](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/146820)	SkyPatched variant; preferred over the base ICH for compatibility.
[Ivy - Gates of Riverwood](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/138864)	Ivy-covered gate mesh replacer at Riverwood entrance. BOS-based, optional cosmetic.
[Better Wine Labels - Vanilla and LotD](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34698)	Wine bottle label retexture. PBR patch: [175588] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/175588)
[Basic Dining Set Replacer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/30055)	Higher-detail dining table and chair meshes. No ESP.
[RUSTIC COOKING - Special Edition](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6142)	High-res cooking pot, oven, and kitchen clutter textures.
[ElSopa - Campfire HD SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/24511)	HD retexture of Campfire's portable crafting items. Requires Campfire.
[Petroglyphs of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/146569)	Rock carving/runestone visual replacers. Mesh-only, no ESP.
[Diverse Windmill Sails - BOS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121759)	BOS-based windmill sail variety.
[Diverse Foods - BOS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/91599)	BOS-based food item variety.
[Diverse Candles - BOS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94369)	BOS-based candle variety.
[Better Pelts and Hides](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/87277)	Pelt/hide texture replacer.
[Fluffy Hanging rabbits](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/89148)	Hanging rabbit mesh/texture replacer.
[FrankBlack's Honey in a Jar](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/104496)	Honey jar retexture.

[Slightly Better Nordic Henges - BOS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/97162)	Nordic henge object variety via BOS.
[One Quiver to rule them all](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/172070)	Quiver attachment positioning fix.
[HFs - Flagons (BOS and Model Swapper)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/145495)	Flagon/tankard variety via BOS.
[Divergence - Skytone - Runes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/150112)	Custom rune texture replacer.
[Temples of the Ancients (2K - 4K)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/38544)	Nordic temple/Aedric ruin retexture. 2K recommended.
[Temples of the Ancients Complex Material and PBR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/127371)	PBR upgrade for Temples of the Ancients. Install after base mod.
[SB - Pressure Plate Trap Blending - BOS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/86053)	Blends pressure plates into floor textures via BOS.
[Skyland Bits and Bobs - A Clutter Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/95032)	Clutter item texture/mesh overhaul. May overlap with Snazzy and Rally's coverage — evaluate side-by-side.
[CleverCharff's AIO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/44650)	Architecture and dungeon texture overhaul. Broad coverage — test for cohesion with VPBR.
[RUSTIC MAPS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42614)	High-res world map and local map texture replacer. Redundant with FWMF paper maps — pick one map route.
[Parallax Textures For Vanilla Game and Various Mods](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/125527)	Broad parallax texture pack for vanilla and mod-added objects. Use 2K for performance.
[Detailed Rugs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/9030)	Higher-detail rug texture/mesh replacer. No ESP.
[Detailed Rugs 4K-2K - Cleaned and Upscaled Textures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/70301)	Cleaned/upscaled rug textures. Overwrites Detailed Rugs — pick one.
[JS Rumpled Rugs SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/70534)	Rumpled rug mesh/texture replacer. Alternative to Detailed Rugs.
[Parallax Caves 4k-2k](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/83106)	Cave wall parallax texture replacer. Use 2K. Complements Vanaheimr Mines and Caves.
[Stacks of Septims - 3D Coin Piles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113071)	3D coin pile meshes. Mesh-only, no ESP.
[Stacks of Septims - My patches SE by Xtudo](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113152)	Compatibility patch hub — C.O.I.N., LotD, JS Septims, Ennead, Skyland Bits, Maple Manor, etc. Install after base.
[JS Purses and Septims SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37306)	Higher-detail coin purse and septim meshes/textures.
[Skyrim Fantasy Overhaul - Fantastic City Walls SE-AE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/130952)	City wall texture overhaul with fantasy-inspired style.

Lighting

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Lighting

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Lighting MO2 separator unless noted.

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Lighting Overhaul Strategy → separator: Graphics - Lighting

Build lighting as a coherent layer supporting the shader-first visual direction, stronger world scale, and third-person readability. Interior mood matters, but so do readability, compatibility cost, and coherence with the final weather route. The baseline is a Community Shaders-native stack with much lower patch burden than the LUX family.

🌀 Install order: SLT → CS Light + True Light + WSU → Based Lighting Configs → Ambient Templates → Helios → Embers XD → Luminous Atronachs.

Core CS-Native Stack

Mod	Role	Notes
[Standard Lighting Templates (SLT)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/66943)	Foundation	Standardized light template records. Replaces per-cell template work.
[CS Light](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/138443)	Core	CS-native interior/exterior lighting.
[True Light](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135488)	Exterior bulbs	Exterior bulb placement via Light Placer. Pin v3.4.1 — v3.5.x breaks LoS II lamppost ground illumination.
[Window Shadows Ultimate (WSU)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/150494)	Interior	Interior shadowed windows.
[Ambient Templates for Lighting Mods] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/153425)	Required	Required by the CS-native stack.

> True Light FOMOD: Select Exterior mode — attaches bulbs to exterior meshes (braziers, campfires, torches, lanterns) via Light Placer. This replaces Lux Orbis's exterior lighting role.

Configuration & Ambient

Mod	Role	Notes
[Based Lighting Configs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/136870)	Presets	Standardizes tone/behavior across interiors/exterior.
[Helios](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/181533)	Ambient	Dynamic auto-ambient adjustment for interiors and exteriors via Community Shaders.

Fire & Effects

Mod	Role	Notes
[Embers XD](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37085)	Fire	140K+ endorsements. Install after main lighting overhauls. → Graphics - Lighting
[Luminous Atronachs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/27732)	Effects	Self-illuminating atronachs via particle lights.

[KD Realistic Fireplaces](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/28877)	Fire	Optional fireplace visual upgrade. Cosmetic only.
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Alternatives

- EmbersXD Torch Edit ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/134219>)) — Torch visual replacer for Embers XD. Optional cosmetic.
- Relighting Skyrim SE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/8586>)) + Luminosity Lighting Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/16830>)) — Lightest vanilla-plus route. Falls back if the CS-native stack fails compatibility testing.
- ELFX Shadows ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/63790>)) — Strong alternate if CS-native proves insufficient for interior mood. Hard-requires base Enhanced Lights and FX ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/2424>)).
- iLluminous Elementals ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/138128>)) — Broader elemental-light approach. Alternative to Luminous Atronachs.
- Window Shadows RT - Updated ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/111091>)) / Ambiance ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/46383>)) — Fallback interior shadow mods.

Risks & Compatibility

- The CS-native stack has 35-55 total patches versus LUX's 80-120 across the Patch Hub.
- CS Light + True Light + WSU relies on Light Placer non-shadow-casting bulbs — test together before locking.
- WSU can hit shadow-caster limits and flicker in certain interiors — monitor during playtesting.
- Very dark interiors look impressive in screenshots and feel worse in long play sessions.
- Choosing lighting before weather is settled can produce a mismatched visual tone.
- True Light author is doing a major rework — monitor for a post-v3.5.x fix for the LoS II lamp post bug.
- SLT provides template-level standardization; verify it does not conflict with CS Light's template expectations.

Weather & Water

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Weather & Water

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Weather & Water MO2 separator unless noted.

Weather And Atmosphere → separator: Graphics - Weather & Water

Weather should be chosen as part of the Community Shaders presentation layer, not as an isolated plugin choice. The target is a grounded but modern visual tone that preserves forest, mountain, and travel readability in third person.

Primary candidates — test side-by-side:

Mod	Description	Nexus
NAT.CS III	Works on the conservative CS stack (no SSGI required).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139567)
Azurite III CS	Requires the balanced CS add-on tier or higher (SSGI, Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Wetness Effects).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/162153)
Sky Sync - Community Shaders	Sky colour/dome enhancement for CS. Lighter than full weather replacement.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/153543)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Raid Weathers CS	Gameplay-clarity route. Requires base RAID Weathers.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/171041)
RAID Weathers (base)		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/63116)
Vanilla Weathers for CS	Vanilla-plus CS-native. Has a True Storms patch.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/165393)
Obsidian Weathers	Fallback benchmark.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/12125)
Obsidian CS	Fallback benchmark.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/162627)
Cathedral Weathers	Fallback benchmark.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/24791)
Azurite Weathers III - Enhanced	Later tuning layer, not the first decision.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/150269)
Skydreamus CS Presets	Later tuning layer, not the first decision.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/171145)

Mists of Tamriel	Mist/fog atmospheric enhancement. CS-compatible — verify fog density in third-person readability.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78703)
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Azurite III Addon

Mod	Description	Nexus
[Azurite III CS - Realistic Darker Nights] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/183498)	Darker night preset for Azurite III CS. Requires testing — older nights affect third-person readability and combat detection. Needs Azurite III CS as base.	

Risks & Compatibility

- A weather setup that looks stunning in screenshots can flatten gameplay readability in forests, storms, or dusk travel.
- Overly aggressive fog, contrast, or dark nights work against third-person exploration and combat.
- Preset stacking makes the final visual chain harder to reason about if weather, CS options, and external presets all push tone differently.

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Water Visuals → separator: Graphics - Weather & Water

Treat water as a full visual stack: base water look, CS water features, mesh support, foam, waterfalls. Target: cold, readable, grounded water that holds up in motion during travel.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Water Effects - Community Shaders	Baseline shader feature layer. CS 1.5.2+ ships a Unified Water module — evaluate whether it replaces the need for a standalone water base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/112762)
A Water Made For CS in mind	Primary base-water candidate.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172959)
Splashes Of Skyrim	Baseline inclusion, not optional. SKSE plugin for water impact effects; CS 1.4.1+ includes FPS optimizations.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/47710)
Loki's Wade In Water	Water-interaction layer for wading. Mesh/anim replacer, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/42854)

Alternatives

Evaluate these only after the main water base is selected.

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simplicity of Sea		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56520)
Color and Transparency Tweaks		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148761)
Realistic Water Two SE	Legacy baseline.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2182)
Water for ENB	Legacy baseline.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37061)
FYX - Water Mesh Optimization	Only add if it clearly improves shorelines or performance.	
Natural Waterfalls		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/87261)

Rally's Water Foam		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/28922)
Water Debris	Floating debris VFX.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171371)
Underwater Bubbles - SKSE Plugin	No ESP, complements surface stack.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175559)
Refined Water Droplet Replacer for R.A.S.S.	Rain/water droplet visual replacer. Works with R.A.S.S.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/40793)
Wade in Water Redux - Swimming Overhaul	Swimming overhaul with wading physics. Broader scope than Loki's Wade.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/151353)
GKB Waves Reborn	High-quality animated wave shader for shorelines. Prerequisite for GKB Waves For Various Mods.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/71126)
GKB Waves For Various Mods	GKB wave coverage for mod-added coasts and new-lands. Requires GKB Waves Reborn. Verify compatibility with chosen water mod.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/124742)
WAVY Waterfalls Effect	Animated waterfall mesh replacer with wave motion. CS-compatible.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126073)

Risks & Compatibility

- Water can look strong in still shots and distracting in motion if foam, reflections, or wave response are overdone.
- Water tone can clash with the chosen weather route.
- Mesh fixes and waterfall add-ons can help one setup and hurt another.

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Sky, Stars, And Auroras → separator: Graphics - Weather & Water

The cosmic visual layer: night-sky stars, aurora rendering, sky-dome enhancements. Kept separate from weather because sky-dome work is about clear-night rendering and long-horizon reads, not precipitation and overcast coverage.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
AURORA S.E.	Adds proper northern-lights rendering. Genuinely upgrades the night vista without bloating the weather or lighting layer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6021)

Keep the discipline-first route alive if the weather mod's bundled star/sky textures already read well. Defer a full sky-dome overhaul if playtesting shows the night sky needs more investment.

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Rally's Celestial Canvas	Complete night-sky overhaul: auroras, galaxy, stars, constellations. Hand-drawn (8K galaxy, 4K stars).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/110869)
Realistic Galaxy	Galaxy texture replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/111458)
Ultra Hi-Res Nightsky	Hubble-imagery galaxy, up to 16K.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6096)
Worlds Behind Glass	High-res night sky for telescope mods.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/158077)
[Draco's fantasy auroras](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/120563)	Aurora/sky visual replacer. Optional cosmetic.	
[Draco's moons](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/40605)	Moon visual replacer. Optional cosmetic.	
[Shooting Stars SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/73090)	Adds randomized shooting-star streaks to the night sky. Script-free.	
[Praedy's Night Sky AIO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/47530)	High-quality night-sky and star texture replacer. Choose 2K.	
[Texture Overhaul Stars and Galaxy of Nirn](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/41260)	8K star and galaxy texture replacer.	

[Skyrim Textures Redone - Stars] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim/specialedition/mods/4931)	Star texture replacer. Lighter alternative to full sky overhauls.	
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Risks & Compatibility

- Aurora mods can look out of place in non-northern settings; verify southern holds.
- Sky-dome edits can fight with weather mods that tweak the night sky. Give the aurora mod priority for night-sky changes.
- Strong auroras require a real night-darkness baseline from → Performance; bright nights kill the aurora.

Terrain & Flora

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Terrain & Flora

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Terrain & Flora MO2 separator unless noted.

Terrain, Roads, And Snow → separator: Graphics - Terrain & Flora

Treat terrain, roads, and snow as one connected presentation layer. Must stay coherent with Community Shaders, PBR support, rock meshes, weather, and later LOD generation.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Better Dynamic Snow SE	Snow-and-ash multistage accumulation. Works with Simplicity of Snow; the BDSPatcher Synthesis patcher handles mod-added objects automatically.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/9121)
Better Dynamic Ash SE	Solstheim ash equivalent.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/54754)

Landscape And Terrain (candidates – narrow after testing)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyking Fantasia Landscapes		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/107256)
Atlantean Landscape - Majestic Edition		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/102170)
Atlantean Landscape - Complete - Complex Terrain Parallax		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/89542)
A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/137333)
TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/177621)
Vanaheimr - Landscapes - AIO - Complex Material - PBR	PBR pipeline support. Evaluate alongside Cathedralist and TomatoRim.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/145439)
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR	Primary mountain/rock identity. CS-native, no plugins, Complex Material support. Drop Majestic Mountains entirely (author inactive since June 2022, mesh misses snow coverage on rock piles).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121336)
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Fix and Addon	Extends ERM to underground spaces and Whiterun Skyforge.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142493)

Tomato's Complex Parallax Material Landscapes AIO - With DLCs	Older Tomato landscape release. TomatoRim PBR above is the newer version – evaluate which to use.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/110981)
Tomato's Whiterun Remake - PBR or Complex Material	Whiterun-specific terrain retexture.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173747)
Seasonal Landscapes	Seasonal texture-swap system. Requires extensive patching – evaluate patch debt before locking.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/66903)
Tomato's Whiterun Remake PBR - Seasonal Landscapes Patch	Required if both Whiterun Remake and Seasonal Landscapes are adopted.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174042)

Roads

Mod	Description	Nexus
Blended Roads - Light Plugin (ESL)		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171554)
HD Remastered Blended Roads	HD hand-made rework. Choose 2K for performance, 4K for visual sweet spot. Requires Blended Roads base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63674)
[Simplest Roads](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111255)	Minimal road texture replacer. Alternative to Blended Roads.	
[Simple Complex Parallax Roads](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173826)	Parallax road textures requiring CS Complex Material. Alternative to Blended Roads.	

Snow And Support

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simplicity of Snow		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56235)
Nordic Snow		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/670)
Nordic Snow - Complex Material		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/133034)
Hyperborean Snow SE - 8K	Comparison candidate, not locked.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/29283)

Better Dynamic Snow SE	Multistage accumulation with terrain-blended coverage.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/9121)
Better Dynamic Ash SE	Solstheim ash equivalent.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54754)
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - CM and PBR	See Landscape section above; listed here for snow coherence.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/121336)

Alternatives

- Windhelm Is Snowy - Base Object Swapper ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/165102>)) — BOS-based snow coverage for Windhelm. Complements Simplicity of Snow.
- Snowy Standing Stones for Snowy Regions ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/139000>)) — BOS-based snow coverage for standing stones in snowy regions.

Risks & Compatibility

- Snow can look good in isolation and fail once mixed with mountains, roads, and weather-heavy scenes.
- Heavy terrain parallax can look impressive close up while adding artifact risk or visual noise in motion.

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Flora Visuals → separator: Graphics - Terrain & Flora

Flora is the ground-level readability layer between terrain materials and tree coverage. It should improve grass density, wildland texture, and plant variety without making traversal unreadable or creating constant patch work.

Grass

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skoglendi - A Grass Mod	Baseline grass.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/93944)
Merethic Grasslands	Variety enhancer; pairs with Skoglendi for northern grassland texture.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/164058)
Origins Of Forest - 3D Forest Grass	Density enhancer. Add only if forests feel too sparse after terrain and tree choices are locked.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/45719)

Plant Replacers

Mod	Description	Nexus
Mari's flora		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/45952)
Freak's Floral Meadows	Meadow flower replacer. No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148525)
Freak's Floral Solstheim	Solstheim ash-covered grass/flora replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/138161)
A Nirnroot	Nirnroot mesh/texture replacer with glowing effects. No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/80281)
Flora Orientalis	Dependency for Vinland Grass Patch + mixed-route coverage.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64041)
Waterplants	Dependency for Vinland Grass Patch + mixed-route coverage.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/6092)
[Flora Additions - Water Plants] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/116324)	Optional water plant flora additions.	
[Reimagined Mountain Flowers - Base Object Swapper - Seasons of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135460)	Mountain flower replacer with BOS and Seasonal Landscapes support.	

3D Plant Replacers (mesh-only, no ESP)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Cathedral - 3D Plants (Clover, Deathbell, Dragons Tongue, Lavender, Thistle, Snow Berries)	Full Cathedral 3D series.	
Cathedral - 3D Stonecrop		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/110726)
DrJacopo - 3D Tundra Shrubs		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/108747)
Cathedral PBR Plants	PBR texture layer for the Cathedral 3D series. Requires original Cathedral plants and PGPatcher.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135836)
PBR Waterplants	PBR textures for underwater plants.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/129928)

Tree-Adjacent

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyfall's Sleeping Hist Tree Overhaul	Riften Sleeping Hist tree replacement. Mesh/texture only, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116792)
TMD The Rift Leaves	3D leaf particle replacer for The Rift. No ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/111461)
[Bigger trees](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5281)	Optional tree size multiplier.	

Environment-Plant Extras (visual polish, not baseline)

Mod	Description	Nexus
High Quality Ivy Replacer - BOS	Replaces ivy meshes/textures. Animated/static via FOMOD. No performance cost.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113578)
Grumbledook Swordferns - Optional PBR	New swordfern meshes/textures. Hard-requires BOS; PBR variant requires CS.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/163949)

> Evaluate these after grass, 3D plant replacers, and tree choices are locked. Both layer via BOS (no cell-record edits).

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
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Folkvangr - Grass and Landscape Overhaul	Main heavier alternate.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/44899)
Vinland Grass Patch	Only after the final grass combination is narrow enough.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/95273)
QW's Grass Patch 2	Only after the final grass combination is narrow enough.	
Grassreach - Blackreach Grass	Blackreach-specific grass replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179420)
Wildlands Renewal	Grass and groundcover improvement mod. Evaluate as Skoglendi alternative or layering candidate.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/139896)

Risks & Compatibility

- Grass that looks strong in screenshots can make traversal and combat readability worse.
- Layering multiple grass and plant mods creates real patch and cache maintenance cost.
- Forest-floor enhancers can become too dense once weather fog and heavy tree coverage are added.

—

Tree Overhauls For Dense Forests → separator: Graphics - Terrain & Flora

Trees are the main large-scale world-shaping layer for wilderness mood, canopy silhouette, and perceived regional scale.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Traverse the Ulvenwald - 3.3	Main dense-forest candidate.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57874)
Tomato's PBR Vanilla Trees	PBR tree texture option; can layer under whichever tree overhaul wins testing.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/139375)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Happy Little Trees	Safer fallback baseline.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/50961)
Fabled Forests		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/94462)
Nature of the Wild Lands	Compare only if Ulvenwald misses the right balance.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63604)
Happy Little Trees PBR	Support signal.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/159171)
Fabled Forests - Ulvenwald Patch (BOS)	Support signal.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/134501)
Nature of the Wild Lands - Animations Addon	OAR-based tree interaction animations for NotWL. Requires NotWL base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148132)
Nature of the Wild Lands - PBR	PBR texture layer for NotWL trees. Requires NotWL base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/150319)
Nature of the Wild Lands - Snowier Spruce Trees	Spruce tree snow coverage addon for NotWL. Requires NotWL base.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/149165)

Risks & Compatibility

- Dense tree overhauls can make roads, structures, and combat spaces harder to read in motion.
- Heavier worldspace tree edits create clipping, blocked sightlines, floating objects, and broad patch debt.

- A tree overhaul that looks excellent nearby can still fail if its distant silhouette is weak.

Characters & Creatures

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Characters & Creatures

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Characters & Creatures MO2 separator unless noted.

Character, Skin, And Creature Visuals → separator: Graphics - Characters & Creatures

Baseline visual treatment for player bodies, skin textures, and common creature visuals before NPC-specific overhauls are chosen. Target: grounded modern look that holds up in third person without drifting into overly glossy, doll-like, or hyper-stylized presentation.

Body Bases And Skins

 Install order: CBBE → CBBE 3BA → HIMBO → RaceMenu → BnP skins → female preset → male preset → overlay/freckle packs.

Female Body

Mod	Notes
[CBBE NSFW](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/74257)	Female body base.
[CBBE 3BA (3BBB)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/30174)	Extension and preset ecosystem.
[BnP – Female Skin](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/65274)	Female skin textures.

Male Body

Mod	Notes
[HIMBO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/74174)	Male body base.
[BnP – Male Skin](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/65402)	Male skin textures.

Character Creation

Mod	Notes
[RaceMenu SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/29624)	Character creation framework.
High Poly Head 1.4 SE	[Google Drive mirror](https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1V_jcYzwTiKnSv8Dbv-7Z0hh9SWbkn6Bi). Pair with Expressive Facegen Morphs + Expressive Facial Animation (Female + Male).
[SlimFantasy – 3BAv2 Body Preset](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/119145)	Female Bodyslide preset. Slim/lean dancer physique.
[HIMBO Preset – Chadborn](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/155757)	Male Bodyslide preset. Muscular build.
[Lovely Makeup – Racemenu Overlays](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94271)	Makeup overlay collection.
[Lovely Makeup 2](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/102335)	Additional makeup overlays.

[Koralina's Freckles and Moles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/62508)	Freckle and mole overlays.
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Face Mesh Branch Notes

- High Poly Head 1.4 still has current ecosystem support — used in Wabbajack compilations with a whitelisted Google Drive source.
- Treat it as a player-face and selective NPC-support branch, not a full beauty-overhaul stack.
- The strongest modern alternative (Alternate High Poly Head) still depends on the original HPH 1.4 package.
- Headpart mismatches, facegen conflicts, and vampire edge cases are still common — keep downstream patching documented in → Performance.

—

BodySlide And Outfit Studio Setup

- BodySlide and Outfit Studio ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/201>))
- Install as a normal mod in MO2.
- Register BodySlide x64.exe in MO2 as an executable.
- Create a dedicated BodySlide Output mod before generating anything.
- Keep BodySlide Output in the Output separator.
- Keep CBBE, CBBE 3BA, HIMBO, the chosen preset, and body-aware armor/outfit mods installed before building meshes.

Recommended Setup Order

1. Install CBBE NSFW
2. Install CBBE 3BA (3BBB)
3. Install HIMBO
4. Install BodySlide and Outfit Studio
5. Install SlimFantasy preset
6. Install OBody NG and all body-variety preset packs (before first BodySlide build)
7. Install selected skin textures (if the skin package expects a specific layout)
8. Install armor/clothing packs needing body refits (before first BodySlide build)
9. Add and enable the empty BodySlide Output mod before generating anything

BodySlide Configuration

- Run BodySlide through MO2, not from the game folder.
- Set output path to the dedicated BodySlide Output mod location.
- Female meshes: Select the SlimFantasy preset (not plain CBBE).
- Male meshes: Select the Chadborn preset before batch building.
- Use Batch Build once the baseline armor/clothing set is stable enough to avoid constant rebuilds.
- If multiple body variants appear, choose the option matching active CBBE 3BA and HIMBO ecosystems.
- Rebuild after installing or replacing major armor packs, outfit conversions, or body-shape presets.

3BA And Preset-Specific Notes

- The chosen female body path is CBBE NSFW + CBBE 3BA + SlimFantasy preset.
- Do not batch build female outfits against plain CBBE if the actual in-list preset requires 3BA/3BBB.
- When armor mods offer both CBBE and 3BA/3BBB options, choose 3BA/3BBB.
- Keep the female body stack consistent across base, preset, and outfit conversions.

Outfit Studio Guidance

- Treat Outfit Studio as the exception tool for fixing problem outfits, not a default for every armor.
 - Use when a chosen armor/clothing mod does not match the active CBBE or HIMBO setup cleanly.
 - Keep edited/converted outfit output separate from the original source mod.
 - Document manual outfit fixes so future rebuilds don't depend on memory.
-

Body Variety And Distribution

Distributes different BodySlide presets across NPCs so the world doesn't look like everyone shares the same body shape.

Baseline

- OBody NG ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/77016>)) — Core distribution layer.
- Real Body - 3BA (3BBB) CBBE Presets ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/83299>)) — Curated semi-realistic 3BA presets for OBody distribution.
- Realistic Racial Body Diversity - OBody NG Config ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/87239>)) — Per-race body distribution (broader Nords, leaner Elves, heavy Orcs). Covers both CBBE 3BA and HIMBO.
- Individual presets: Rugged Body - 3BA, Skinny Berry - 3BA, Realistic chubby and curvy body - 3BA.
- Male variety: HIMBO SliderPresets Pack 02 ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/176023>)) — 10 presets.

Alternatives

- OBody NG is the only maintained OBody version that works with both OStim and standalone.
- Additional male presets: The Common Guy - SerketHetyt's HIMBO Preset, Greek God -- HIMBO BodySlide Preset (adult-content page; review before adding).

Notes

- OBody NG requires building all included presets in BodySlide with Create Morphs ticked — larger batch build.
 - Every additional preset pack increases BodySlide build time. Keep pack size intentional.
 - OBody NG works with CBBE 3BA and HIMBO but may need config adjustment for other body mods.
 - SlimFantasy preset remains the player-character default; OBody distributes additional presets to NPCs only.
-

Clothing And Armor Texture Upgrades

Mod	Notes
[Immersive Fur Garments](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/77073)	New fur garments to leveled lists.
[Immersive Fur Garments — SPID](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/82177)	SPID distribution addon (ESL-flagged). Install base mod (delete .esp) + SPID addon.
[Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175319) (2.9 GB)	Complete PBR retexture of all vanilla armors/weapons/clothes. Requires CS + PGPatch.

[RUSTIC CLOTHING — SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/4703)	Higher-res clothing textures. Test for style consistency.
[Dwemer Armors and Weapons Retexture SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/93088)	Gear-side companion to VPBR's Dwemer ruin textures.
[Steel Armor Redone — PBR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/177513)	PBR retexture of CC Steel Armor. Requires CC Alternative Armors — Steel Soldier, CS, PGPatcher. Optional.
[Robes Retexture SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/110655)	Higher-quality robe textures for all vanilla robes.
[Divine Crusader Retexture SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123738)	Retexture of Divine Crusader armor set.
[Nirn Necessities — SMP Accessories](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112481)	SMP-physics clothing accessories. Add [PBR patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135807) if using CS PBR.
[aMidianBorn Book of Silence SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/35382)	Comprehensive armor/weapon/dragon retexture. 207K endorsements.
[aMidianBorn Content Addon](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/35390)	Extends aMidianBorn coverage to additional armors. Install after Book of Silence.
[aMidianBorn Content Addon - 3BA and HIMBO Patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/144952)	Body refit patch for Content Addon.
[Resurgence Armory - Artifact Weapons and Armor Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/83855)	Visual overhaul for artifact weapons and armor models.
[3BA and HIMBO Refits for Resurgence Armors](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/85669)	Body refit for Resurgence Armory armors.
[HDT-SMP Vanilla Armors](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142450)	Adds HDT-SMP physics to all vanilla armors.
[Master Thief Armor 3BA-BHUNP-UNP-CBBE-HIMBO-Vanilla](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/141700)	Armor set with CBBE 3BA / HIMBO support. Evaluate for visual fit with the rest of the armor stack. Alternative — not baseline.

Recommended Creature Baseline

Mod	Notes
[Bellyaches Animal and Creature Pack SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6839)	Creature texture foundation.

General Notes

- Body-base choices create a large armor-refit and outfit-conversion workload later.
- Choosing 3BA/3BBB increases female outfit compatibility requirements versus plain CBBE.
- Letting BodySlide output overwrite source mods makes auditing and rebuilds much harder.
- Skin mods that look strong in screenshots can still appear too polished or glossy in gameplay lighting.

- High Poly Head 1.4 adds headpart and facegen complexity with vampire fixes, NPC overhauls, and custom presets.
- Do not let this section expand into full NPC beautification — that belongs in → NPCs.

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Hair, Eyes, And Beards → separator: Graphics - Characters & Creatures

Per-character face assets: hairstyles, eye textures, and beard options. Ensures character close-ups match the grim-dark tone without pulling in full NPC face-gen overhauls.

Mod	Type	Notes
[KS Hairdos SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6817)	Baseline	Community-canonical hair pack. 141K endorsements.
[Eyes Nouveaux](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131210)	Baseline	Khisartin-style eye textures, grim-dark tone.
[LDD Clean Cubemap for Eyes 4K](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/168060)	Baseline	Cleaner eye cubemaps. Stacks on eye-texture baseline.
[Brows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1062)	Baseline	Brow shape and texture replacer for all races.
[Better Argonian Horns](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80568)	Baseline	Higher-quality Argonian horn meshes and textures. BOS-based.
[The Eyes Of Beauty SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16185)	Alternative	Community-standard alternative to Eyes Nouveaux.
[Argonian - Khajiit FabULook Eyes SSE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/15136)	Alternative	High-res eye textures for Argonian and Khajiit.
[Beards of Power](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42635)	Alternative	High-fidelity beard meshes and textures. Adds variety over vanilla.
[BnP - Teeth Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/84288)	Alternative	Higher-quality teeth meshes/textures. Complements BnP skin stack.
[New Beast Feet](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/107689)	Alternative	Higher-detail beast race (Khajiit/Argonian) feet with claws/digits.
[SG Female Eyebrows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/25890) + [Improved](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/93266)	Alternative	Higher-fidelity female eyebrow shapes. Use Improved variant.
[Eyes of Beauty - Nouveaux](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/152223)	Alternative	Combines Eyes Nouveaux meshes with The Eyes of Beauty textures. Requires both as dependencies.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	Rely on vanilla hair and eye textures entirely.

Keep the beard decision minimal; vanilla beards work well with the chosen body and face mesh stack.

Risks & Compatibility

- High-poly hair can clash with extreme lighting/shadow setups; verify KS Hairdos works with the CS-native lighting stack.
- Eye textures that lean too stylized look out of place; pick a realistic pack matching grim-dark.

- Hair assets are common in NPC-overhaul conflicts; check for hair-distribution patches when → NPCs is active.
- Adding a beard pack without testing creates obvious neck clipping under most lighting.

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Skeleton And Bone Replacers → separator: Graphics - Characters & Creatures

Visual upgrades to in-world skeleton and bone assets: skulls, bone piles, skeleton models in dungeons, Nordic ruins, draugr crypts, dragon priest rooms. Kept separate from the rigged skeleton baseline in → Animations.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Skeleton Replacer HD — SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/52845)	Baseline	High-res skeleton/bone models. Choose 2K main file.
[Skeleton Replacer HD — Mesh Patches] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/177253)	Baseline	Add only if modlist includes a creature/content mod needing a mesh patch.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	Rely on vanilla skeleton assets.

Risks & Compatibility

- Skeleton Replacer HD can conflict with creature mods that ship their own skeleton/bone assets.
- Some vanilla draugr and dragon priest models have unique assets the mod can override; verify they're preserved.
- High-resolution bones can look out of place in a dungeon without matching texture work.

LOD & Distant Detail

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail

All items in this section belong to the Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail MO2 separator unless noted.

LOD Generation And Distant Detail → separator: Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail

Distant detail determines whether Elder Wilds feels large and coherent during travel instead of collapsing into obvious pop-in and flat backgrounds.

Baseline

- DynDOLOD-based distant detail is the assumed standard.
- Use the balanced route: strong object and tree LOD quality with targeted support mods.
- Add support mods only where they visibly improve the chosen tree and texture stack.
- Judge distant detail from actual travel routes, mountain overlooks, and city approaches — not static showcase shots.

Required Tools And Dependencies

Core Support Mods

Mod	Nexus
DynDOLOD Resources SE 3	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/52897)
DynDOLOD DLL NG	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97720)

Optional Distant Detail Support

Mod	Notes	Nexus
HD LODs Textures SE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3333)
Skyfall's Sleeping Hist Tree Overhaul — DynDOLOD Add-On	Billboard generation for replaced tree. Required for correct distant-LOD display.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/169984)
Happy Little Trees DynDOLOD Optimizations		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/158587)
Far Object LOD Improvement Project SSE (FOLIP)	Improves distant object LOD.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79197)

World Map Support

Elder Wilds uses its flat map / paper-map framework — see `guide/modlist-ui.md`.

Core Workflow Dependencies

Mod	Nexus
No Grass In Objects	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/42161)

Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/55152)
Grass Cache Fixes	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/60891)
xLODGen Resource — SSE Terrain Tamriel	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54680)

Build Order And Configuration

Setup

- Install DynDOLOD Resources SE 3 as a normal mod in MO2. During FOMOD installation, uncheck Low-Res LOD Textures and Holy Cow. On Skyrim SE 1.6+, also uncheck Whiterun Exterior Grass. Place the mod relatively high in the left pane.
- Install DynDOLOD DLL NG as a normal mod in MO2. Provides the large-reference bug workaround from its own side — only use if the modlist ships with it and you understand the implications; not recommended unless the list explicitly requires it.
- Install No Grass In Objects, Grass Cache Fixes, and xLODGen Resource as support content.
- Register TexGen, DynDOLOD, and xLODGen as MO2 executables, not mixed into mod folders.
- Treat occlusion as generated output, not as a separate mod pick.

Dedicated MO2 Output Mods (create before generation)

Output Folder	Purpose
Grass Cache Output	Generated grass cache
Terrain LOD Output	xLODGen terrain output
TexGen Output	Generated billboards
DynDOLOD Output	DynDOLOD output
Occlusion Output	Occlusion data

Keep generated outputs in the Output separator. Do not generate final outputs until tree, terrain, snow, flora, and large worldspace picks are mostly stable.

Run Order

1. Confirm load order and conflict resolution first.
2. Generate grass cache (No Grass In Objects workflow).
3. Install/update Grass Cache Output.
4. Run xLODGen for terrain LOD (once terrain and snow are stable).
5. Install/update Terrain LOD Output.
6. Run TexGen.
7. Install/update TexGen Output.
8. Run DynDOLOD.
9. Install/update DynDOLOD Output.
10. Generate occlusion data near the end, keep in Occlusion Output.

Re-run relevant generated layers when a major tree overhaul, architecture change, landscape shift, grass change, or LOD-relevant texture pack is replaced.

Recommended Starting DynDOLOD Configuration

- First-pass preset: High — start here even if the setup is graphics-heavy. Move above only after checking travel performance and distant coherence.
- Generate both object and tree LOD on the first real pass to judge forest silhouette quality early.
- Keep large-reference and ultra-aggressive options off for the first pass.
- First-pass questions: do distant trees match the overhaul? Do mountain/road/city approach views feel coherent? Is performance acceptable in real travel?
- If using Happy Little Trees, test baseline output first, then compare DynDOLOD Optimizations.
- If using heavier tree overhauls (Ulvenwald, Fabled Forests, Nature of the Wild Lands), prioritize clean transitions and stable horizons before longer range.

Tree-Specific DynDOLOD Rules

Certain tree overhauls require specialised tree rules in DynDOLOD for correct distant rendering. Example for Happy Little Trees (from the DynDOLOD add-on page):

LOD Level	Rule
LOD4	Level0 / Mesh
LOD8	Billboard4
LOD16	Billboard(1)
LOD32	Billboard(6)

Apply matching rules for your chosen tree overhaul if its DynDOLOD add-on or author documentation specifies them.

Additional Configuration Guidance

- Ultra Trees (3D tree LOD): Recommended once first-pass High is validated. 3D tree LOD provides substantially better visual quality for a minor performance cost and unloads properly, unlike hybrid LODs. Anything above 1024 tile size for billboards provides diminishing returns — keep at or below 1024.
- Billboard brightness: Adjust the R/G/B brightness values in DynDOLOD's grass/billboard settings if distant tree LOD appears too bright in game. A common starting point is 0.500 across all channels.
- DynDOLOD DLL NG: If using DLL NG for the large-reference bug workaround, ensure DynDOLOD settings match its expectations exactly (tick the large-reference workaround options in DynDOLOD's advanced GUI). Not recommended unless the modlist requires it.

Baseline Starting Profile For Elder Wilds

- Preset: High
- Quality target: Balanced object and tree LOD with stable travel performance
- First-pass goal: Believable distant forests, readable city approaches, clean mountain silhouettes
- Keep optional LOD texture upgrades and tree-specific optimization mods disabled at first

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Grass Cache And Occlusion

- Use No Grass In Objects only after the main grass/flora direction is narrow enough that cache generation isn't immediately obsolete.
- Keep Grass Cache Fixes as part of the serious grass-cache path.
- Use Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script if the final setup needs tailored worldspace grass support.
- Treat grass cache as invalid whenever the winning grass combination, landscape coverage, or major worldspace edits change materially.

- Regenerate occlusion near the end of a major graphics pass, after grass, terrain LOD, and DynDOLOD inputs are stable.
- Keep occlusion output separate from all other generated mods for easy identification and replacement.

Validation

- No missing distant objects, giant billboard errors, or broken tree lines
- Near and far tree silhouettes transition cleanly during normal travel
- City approaches, mountain overlooks, and forest horizons look coherent under selected weather/lighting
- Generated outputs are enabled in MO2 and load after source mods
- Old generated outputs are replaced when the visual stack changes, not left active by accident

Risks & Compatibility

- Strong near-field visuals can still look broken in motion if distant terrain and tree lines don't match.
- Optional LOD texture and tree-optimization add-ons create extra maintenance for limited payoff.
- Generating too early produces stale outputs that quietly poison later comparisons.
- Partial rebuild habits leave mismatched terrain, tree, and occlusion outputs active simultaneously.

Rebuild Rules

- Grass cache: Rebuild if grass baseline, major flora layering, or worldspace edits change.
- Terrain LOD: Rebuild if landscape, snow, mountain, or terrain-color direction changes.
- TexGen + DynDOLOD: Rebuild if tree overhauls, large architecture, major LOD-support mods, or visual worldspace edits change.
- Occlusion: Refresh when major worldspace edits or the distant-detail pass changes enough to affect visibility/culling.
- If multiple major visual categories change together, prefer a clean full rebuild over partial guesswork.

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Seasonal LODs

When using Seasons of Skyrim SKSE + Turn of the Seasons, DynDOLOD and xLODGen can generate seasonal LOD passes so distant detail matches the current season. This multiplies generation time considerably — plan accordingly.

xLODGen seasonal: Tick the Seasons checkbox in the bottom-left corner and select which seasons need terrain LOD. Generation takes significantly longer than a single pass.

DynDOLOD seasonal: Tick the Seasons checkbox, the Snow checkbox, and select the desired seasons in DynDOLOD's GUI. Generation time scales with the number of seasons selected.

Rebuild seasonal LOD whenever the underlying terrain, tree, or landscape seasonal-swap data changes.

Modernized UI

MO2 Separators: UI - Framework & HUD, UI - Inventory & Items, UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

All mods in this section belong to one of the three UI separators as noted per subsection.

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UI Framework Prerequisites → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

The base menu and interface framework the rest of the UI stack builds on.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyUI	Non-negotiable baseline.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/12604)
Oathvein UI	Locked visual direction. Grim-dark presentation matches the project tone; cleaner dependency chain than Norden UI.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/160916)
UIExtensions	Support infrastructure, not competing UI identity.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/17561)
Constructible Object Custom Keyword System (COCKS)	Crafting-menu category infrastructure.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/81409)
MCM Helper	Persists MCM settings across saves. Hard dependency of TDM, CNO, and others.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/53000)
Stay At The System Page NG	Keeps System page open after loading a save. Most noticeable on gamepad.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/76927)
ImGui Icons	Icon font resource for ImGui-based mods (Dialogue History, etc.).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114790)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Norden UI	Modern-rustic by Nithog, but depends on Extended UI (no official SE port).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/166086)
Vel'dun UI	Dunmer-themed by Nithog; too narrow a fit for Elder Wilds.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/176230)
Prisma UI	Web-UI framework replacing SkyUI. Incompatible with Oathvein UI and UIExtensions mods.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148718)
SKSE Menu Framework	Low-level menu framework for SKSE-based UI mods.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/120352)

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HUD Overhaul → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

Health, stamina, magicka, target readability, and permanent interface structure during ordinary play.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyHUD	Baseline layout framework: widget positioning, visibility, style consistency.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/463)
TrueHUD	Combat-feedback: actor info bars, boss bars, player widgets, recent-loot logging. Same author as TDM.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/62775)
Casting Bar	Cast/draw timing for spells, shouts, and bow draw.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/80455)
Floating Damage	Optional combat-feedback overlay. Install only after confirming acceptable visual noise.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14332)
QuickLoot IE	Container/corpse loot window on interact. Improved controller support, third-person readability. FOMOD with placement presets.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/120075)
Oxygen Meter 2	Breath meter when underwater. Configurable position/opacity.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64532)
Oxygen Meter 2 - Lung Shaped	Cosmetic lung-shaped icon.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171910)
Oxygen Meter 2 - Fixes and Additions	Bugfixes and feature tweaks.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171916)
Detection Meter	Stealth detection meter. Pairs with RAID.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63057)
Detection Meter - AE Support	Required for 1.6.1170.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/77350)
Casting Bar Reskin - Edge UI Inspired	Cosmetic reskin of Casting Bar. Evaluate integration with Veldun UI's own casting bar (not in Elder Wilds stack).	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/140826)
STB Widgets	Lightweight modular widgets (clock, time, compass-free direction, stat bars). SKSE + MCM.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/136148)

Follower Stats	MCM-based follower stat tracking. Pairs with Nether's.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/159406)
Tween Menu Overhaul Improved	Main-menu and loading-screen visual overhaul. Updated version with additional scenes.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155036)
RUMINATE - Frost and Snow - Main Menu Video Pack	Frost-and-snow themed main menu cinematic.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/160831)
Skeuomorphism of Skyrim - Immersive Plaque Reading Interface	3D in-world plaque model. Requires BOS. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/119849)
Dynamic Location Pop-ups	Location discovery notification banner.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/153122)
Complete Controller Setup	SKSE-based controller config: remapping, radial-menus, camera profiles for gamepad.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/99978)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Stats Tracker Menu - STM	Brand new (May 2026), very low community signal. Test before locking.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/180653)
Kill feed	Kill notification overlay.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179053)

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Inventory And Item Card Improvements → separator: UI - Inventory & Items

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
moreHUD SE	Mandatory. Broader item-information layer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/12688)
moreHUD Inventory Edition	Mandatory. Extends readability into inventory views.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/18619)
Inventory Interface Information Injector	Value/weight/stat-per-weight columns. Same author as moreHUD.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/85702)
I4 Weapon Icons Overhaul	30+ weapon category icons. Depends on III.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/106432)
I4 Armor Icons Overhaul		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/119824)
I4 Shout Icons Overhaul		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/107334)
The Handy Icon Collection Collective (THICC)	Thousands of high-fidelity icons. Additive to I4 family.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/90508)
Favorites Menu Effects Description	Effect descriptions in favorites menu. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Essential for gamepad.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/143532)
B.O.O.B.I.E.S (aka Immersive Icons)	Icon overhaul for SkyUI. 28K+ endorsements. FOMOD: 2K recommended.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/89241)
B.O.O.B.I.E.S - POTIONS	Dedicated potion bottle icons.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/163838)
P.E.N.I.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.	Ingredient icon pack.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/90526)
A.S.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.	Food & drink icon pack.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/89823)
Rotols More Icons	Additional coverage for items B.O.O.B.I.E.S doesn't cover.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/113657)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyUI Item Card Fixes	Cleaner item-card presentation.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/29116)
Aura's Inventory Tweaks	Stronger sorting and icon structure.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/68557)
Weapon Stat Viewer V2	Weapon-stat overlay. Lock only if rendered cleanly.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/127249)
Enchanted Icon Overhaul	Depends on Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174246)
Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174136)
Book 'Em	Book reading/collecting tracking UI.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/84213)

Item Description Cards

Add descriptive text to inventory item cards for better readability. All by the same author, share a consistent style. Install as a set.

Mod	Nexus
Weapons Have Description	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116785)
Ingredients Have Description	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/129755)
Scrolls Have Descriptions	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/107202)
Soul Gems Have Description	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/118941)
Food and Drink Have Descriptions	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/107292)

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Map Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Flat World Map Framework (FWMF)	Non-negotiable map foundation.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/29932)
Local Map Upgrade	Local-map for interior/close-range navigation.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/129756)
HD Local Map	HD textures for the local map upgrade.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/74722)
Atlas Map Markers SE - Updated with MCM	Expanded map markers with MCM configuration.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/24104)
Traditional (8K) Skyrim and Solstheim Paper Maps for FWMF (AE and SE)	High-fidelity paper-map replacer for FWMF.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64493)
Custom Map Markers for Traditional Skyrim and Solstheim Paper Maps	Cosmetic map marker styling for the Traditional map set.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64777)
Updates to various maps for FWMF	Coverage patches for additional FWMF worldspaces.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/84112)

Alternatives

Mod	Nexus
The Nightmare Paper Map for FWMF by Limon	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/143113)
Skyrim and Solstheim Paper Maps by Mirhayasu for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/53788)
Immersive Paper Map (3rd Edition)	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/54710)
Skyrim Paper Map by FreelanceCartography for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/78995)
Legendary Map	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/157397)
[Pastel Map Markers](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3195)	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/3195)
Wurmstooth Paper Map for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/124686)
Apocrypha Paper Map for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/92774)

Beyond Reach Paper Map for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial/edition/mods/119215)
Blackreach Paper Map for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial/edition/mods/53878)
Soul Cairn Paper Map for FWMF	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial/edition/mods/55387)

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Magic And Journal Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Convenient Reading UI - SE	Reading comfort for normal play.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/50202)
Wider MCM Menu for SkyUI	Support fix for cramped config menus.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/22825)
Modern Wait Menu	Clock-face interface showing time, weather preview. Gamepad-friendly. SKSE plugin, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117661)
Completionist - Skyrim Completion Tracker (NG)	MCM-based quest/item/location/book/shout completion tracker. Run the Automated GUI Patcher.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/46358)
Completionist Addons	Mod-added content tracking.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/112406)
Quest Journal Overhaul	Journal UI redesign with quest tracking improvements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172488)
Quest Journal Overhaul - Unofficial Mods Support	Extended mod support patch. Install after the main QJO.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141837)
[Character Menu SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173074)	Character stats/sheet UI replacement. Alternative.	
[Character Menu SE - More Factions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175026)	Additional faction tracking for Character Menu SE.	
[Even Better Quest Objectives SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/159)	Quest objective text clarifications and journal improvements. Alternative.	
[Knotwork](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/128235)	Custom quest journal knotwork art for non-vanilla questlines. Complements Quest Journal Overhaul. SKSE plugin. Alternative.	

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Dialogue UI Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Better Dialogue Controls	First-pass dialogue friction fix.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1429)
Better MessageBox Controls	Same for message boxes.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1428)
Dialogue History	Scrollable dialogue log. Essential for gamepad.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114238)
Improved Alternate Conversation Camera	Dialogue camera baseline. Test for CS letterbox conflict.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/68210)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Dialogue Interface ReShaped	Visual dialogue flow.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/46546)
Convenient Dialogue UI - SE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57943)
Smart Talk (Dialogue Menu Enhancer)	Highlights quest options, reorders choices, gamepad-friendly skip. 5.5K endorsements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/161500)
Various Dialogue Tags	Adds contextual tags to dialogue options (e.g., [Lie], [Persuade], [Ask]). ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/103920)
Various Book Tags	Adds contextual tags to book-reading prompts. Same author as Various Dialogue Tags.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/151404)
Skyrim Autocorrect - Dialogue Grammar Fixes	Fixes grammar, spelling, and punctuation in vanilla dialogue. Text-only, no records.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141632)

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Controller-Friendly UI Support → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyrim SE Controller Interface Fix		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1147)
Show Player In Menus	Renders player character in menus for gear previews. Essential for third-person parity.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/122648)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Gamepad Plus Plus	Broader controller-input answer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/27007)
Wheeler - Quick Action Wheel	Radial interaction layer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97345)
WHEELER - Refined	Updated visuals, better controller support.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/167380)
Auto Input Switch	Automatically switches input device.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54309)
Show Player In Inventory	Renders player model in inventory screen.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/178689)

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UI Scaling For Ultrawide And High Resolution → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

Mod	Description	Nexus
Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer	Text readability for 16:9 4K HDR. Prefer Bold V8.9 first.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/386)
Complete Widescreen Fix	Secondary for ultrawide layouts.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1778)

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Compass, Markers, And Minimal HUD → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Compass Navigation Overhaul	First-pass navigational layer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/74484)
CoMAP - Common Marker Addon Project	Marker consistency across the FWMF ecosystem.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56123)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Immersive HUD - iHUD SE	Minimal-HUD branch.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/12440)
MiniMap	Very optional. Last updated May 2021; occasional crash reports on 1.6.1170.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/49490)

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Crafting Menu Improvements → separator: UI - Inventory & Items

Mod	Description	Nexus
COCKS	See Framework Prerequisites above. Directly improves the Constructible Object Menu.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/81409)
SkyUI - Vanilla Crafting menu	Fallback for vanilla-style split categories.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/18717)

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Loading Screens → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Elder Scrolls Legends - Loading Screens	Locked baseline. 110 lore-friendly Legends artworks. Install at 100% frequency in 16:9 with Fixed Height border. At 100% frequency, vanilla lore tips are suppressed.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37929)

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Optional HUD → separator: UI - Framework & HUD

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyrim Party Sheet - Follower and Player HUD	Persistent overlay for player attributes and follower info. v2.7 (June 2026). Research before installing — verify no conflicts with TrueHUD, Oathvein, or Nether's.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/167538)

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Open Research

Open research for the UI stack is tracked in `TODO.md`.

Animations and Movement

MO2 Separators: Animations - Framework, Animations - Movement & Idles, Animations - Combat, Animations - Interactions & Traversal, Animations - Creatures

All mods in this section belong to one of the five animation separators as noted per subsection.

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Animation Framework Landscape — What Goes With What → separator: Animations - Framework

Skyrim's animation stack has four distinct layers. Each layer has exactly one active owner. Understanding what replaces what, what depends on what, and what is mutually exclusive is the single most important prerequisite to building a stable animation load order.

The Four Layers

Layer	Role	One Active	Elder Wilds Pick
Behavior Engine	Generates behavior files from animation data. Runs as an external tool (MO2 executable).	Yes	Pandora
Conditional Replacer	Selects which .hkx file plays based on runtime conditions (weapon type, location, weather, NPC identity, etc.).	Yes	OAR (Open Animation Replacer)
Combat Animation Framework	Overhauls attack behavior: replaces vanilla attack chain logic with modern combo systems, enables motion-data-driven attacks, adds jumping/swimming/charged attacks.	Yes	TBD — MCO or BFCO (see below)
NPC Combat AI	Teaches NPCs to use combat animation movesets intelligently — combo selection, distance management, attack commitment.	None required	SCAR (Baseline after Precision is proven)

Behavior Engines

Behavior engines are the foundation. They read your installed animation mods, resolve conflicts between their behavior patches, and write out the final behaviors directory. You run them once after changing any animation mod that includes behavior data, and the output lives in a dedicated MO2 mod.

Engine	Status	Creature Support	Reads Nemesis Patches	Reads FNIS Formats	Notes
FNIS	Deprecated	Limited (Add-on)	No	Natively	Closed source. Last meaningful update 2016. No AE support. Do not use.
Nemesis	Superseded	Partial (never completed)	Natively	Partial	Open source. Replaced FNIS around 2020. Creature support

					was a promised feature that never shipped. Still works on AE 1.6.1170 but Pandora is the direct upgrade.
Pandora	Current	Full	Yes	Yes	Open source. Cross-platform. Error-tolerant (isolates illegal edits so one broken mod doesn't poison the whole patch). Faster generation. Reads both Nemesis patch format and legacy FNIS XML. Elder Wilds baseline.

Key compatibility rule: Pandora replaces both FNIS and Nemesis. You do NOT install FNIS or Nemesis alongside Pandora. Most mods that say “Requires Nemesis” work under Pandora without modification — the Nemesis patch format is read natively. The rare exception is a hypothetical mod using a Nemesis-only code plugin that Pandora hasn't implemented, but this is essentially nonexistent in a modern AE load order.

Nemesis page lists “Project New Reign — Nemesis Unlimited Behavior Engine” at mod ID 60033 (the real page), NOT the various fork/translation pages that share the Nemesis name.

Conditional Animation Replacers

Conditional replacers sit between the behavior engine output and the game engine. They don't generate behavior files — they decide which animation file to play at runtime based on configurable conditions.

Replacer	Status	Backward Compat	Open Source	Notes
DAR (Dynamic Animation Replacer)	Maintenance-only	—	No (closed)	Author inactive. Works on AE 1.6.1170 but no new features expected. If DAR ever breaks from a future Skyrim update, nobody can fix it except the original author.
OAR (Open Animation Replacer)	Current	Full DAR backward compatibility	Yes	Implements every DAR condition. Adds: animation variants (random/sequential), presets (reusable condition blocks), in-game editor, constant

				polling, paired animation support, graph variable conditions. Elder Wilds baseline.
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Key compatibility rule: Any mod packaged for DAR works in OAR without modification. OAR reads DAR's folder structure and condition format natively. You do NOT need DAR installed alongside OAR — OAR is a complete replacement.

DAR-based mods use folder paths like meshes\actors\character\animations\DynamicAnimationReplacer_CustomConditions\... OAR reads these same folders with no conversion needed. Mod authors increasingly ship OAR-native configs (JSON-based, richer conditions) but DAR-format mods remain fully functional.

Combat Animation Frameworks

Combat frameworks replace Skyrim's vanilla attack behavior — directional power attacks, combo chains, attack commitment, and motion-data-driven movement during swings. They are the layer that makes combat feel modern.

Framework	Requires	Built-In Features	Moveset Format	Notes
MCO / ADXP (Modern Movement Combat Overhaul / Attack - Distar Experience)	AMR + Payload Interpreter + Pandora/Nemesis + OAR/DAR	Directional power attacks (via separate mod), combo chains, motion-driven attacks	MCO_Attack*.hkx naming	Established standard. Vast moveset library. Active community. The "Distar ecosystem" includes MCO, DMCO (dodge), and related mods. Distar's mods have moved to Nexus (mod ID 117115 for the .esp; main files and movesets still reference the off-site download).
BFCO (Attack Behavior Framework)	AMR + Payload Interpreter + DMK + Pandora/Nemesis + OAR	Directional power attacks (built-in, single hotkey), combo chains, motion-driven attacks, jump attacks, swim attacks, charge attacks, NPC combo AI (bfcoAI), gamepad MCM hotkeys	BFCO_Attack*.hkx naming	Newer alternative. More features packed into one framework. Has an MCO→BFCO converter tool for movesets. Mutually exclusive with MCO/SkySA/ABR.

Key compatibility rule: MCO and BFCO are mutually exclusive. They perform the same function (attack behavior overhaul) and conflict on behavior files, power attack handling, and animation event processing. Pick one. Do not install both.

Both MCO and BFCO require AMR and Payload Interpreter as hard dependencies — these are not optional. BFCO does NOT eliminate the need for AMR; it lists AMR as a “must” requirement on its Nexus page. The shared dependency chain for either path is:

Pandora (behavior generation)

- + AMR (motion data in attacks)
- + Payload Interpreter (animation payload processing)
- + OAR (conditional animation selection)
- + XPMSSSE (skeleton)
- + [MCO OR BFCO] (attack behavior framework)

BFCO also requires Directional Movement Keys (DMK) for directional power attacks to work correctly — this is unique to BFCO. MCO handles directional input through its own .esp and optional companion mods like “Separate Power Attacks.”

Moveset portability: MCO movesets (.hmx files using MCO_Attack* naming) can be converted to BFCO format using the community “MCO To BFCO Converter” tool. The reverse (BFCO → MCO) is less common since BFCO has additional attack types (jump, swim) that have no MCO equivalent.

Companion mods that BFCO replaces internally (do NOT install alongside BFCO):

- One Click Power Attack NG / Elden Power Attack / For Honor Power Attack (power attack hotkey — BFCO has its own in MCM)
- Dual Wield Parrying (built into BFCO)
- UCBO — Unarmed Combat Behavior Overhaul (built into BFCO)
- One Handed Crossbow Framework (built into BFCO)
- CGO (conflicts — jump attacks cause stuck-in-falling state)

NPC Combat AI

NPC combat AI teaches enemies to use combat animation movesets the way a player would — picking appropriate attacks based on range, committing to combos, and varying their patterns.

Mod	Requires	Works With	Notes
SCAR (Skyrim Combos AI Revolution)	Pandora/Nemesis + Address Library. AMR recommended (not mandatory).	MCO, BFCO, or vanilla	NPCs use SCAR-annotated animations via scarAI. With BFCO: SCAR annotations take priority; animations without SCAR annotations fall back to bfcoAI. With MCO: SCAR handles all NPC combo logic. Elder Wilds baseline (after Precision is confirmed stable).

SCAR does NOT require AMR as a hard dependency (not listed in its Nexus requirements), but the two are designed to work together — AMR’s motion data makes SCAR-driven NPC attacks feel grounded and weighty rather than ice-skating.

Practical Compatibility Q&A

Q: I have a DAR mod from 2021. Will it work with OAR? Yes. OAR implements every DAR condition and reads DAR folder structures natively. Install OAR, don't install DAR, and the DAR-packaged mod will work.

Q: I have a mod that says "Requires Nemesis." Can I use Pandora instead? Yes, in virtually all cases. Pandora reads Nemesis patch format natively. The mod's Nemesis patch checkbox will appear in Pandora's UI just as it would in Nemesis.

Q: Do I need FNIS for creature animations (e.g., werewolf, vampire lord)? No. Pandora has full creature support. FNIS is completely unnecessary in a modern AE load order.

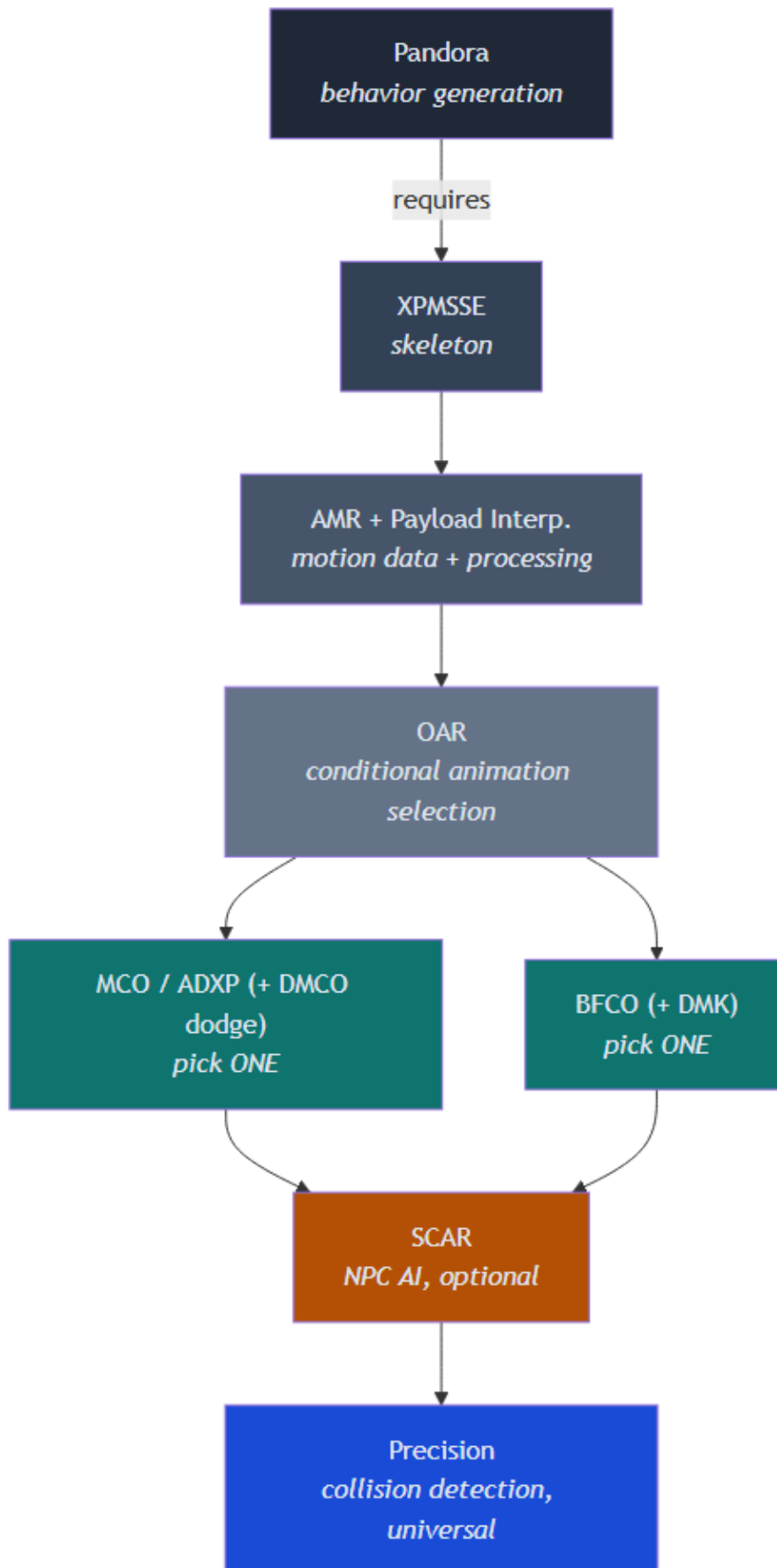
Q: I want to try BFCO instead of MCO. What do I need to change? Remove MCO and any MCO-specific movesets. Install BFCO, DMK, and BFCO-format movesets (or convert MCO movesets with the converter tool). Re-run Pandora, ticking BFCO's patch instead of MCO's. AMR, Payload Interpreter, OAR, and XPMSSE all stay — they're shared requirements.

Q: Can I install SCAR without MCO or BFCO? Technically yes — SCAR has no hard dependency on either. But SCAR is designed to work with MCO/BFCO movesets, and without them NPCs can only use vanilla attack animations, which defeats the purpose. Always pair SCAR with a combat animation framework.

Q: What about SkySA and ABR? Both are predecessors to MCO from the Distar ecosystem. SkySA was the original attack behavior mod; ABR was a fork. MCO superseded both. BFCO lists both as incompatible. Do not use either in a modern load order.

Q: Does Precision (accurate melee collisions) work with all of this? Yes. Precision runs at the collision-detection layer, independent of which combat framework you choose. It works with MCO, BFCO, and vanilla. No special compatibility configuration needed.

The Framework Dependency Map



Research Findings (July 2026)

All four tasks researched. Sources: Nexus mod pages, Nexus community posts tabs, official patch compatibility statements.

Task 1 – Pandora compatibility with modlist behavior mods

Pandora v4.3.1 is confirmed compatible with all behavior-requiring mods currently in the Elder Wilds modlist. The BFCO author (BF001) explicitly tested and confirmed: **“I tested in Pandora v4.3.1 + Skeleton Auto Patch, everything works perfectly”** (BFCO sticky post, May 2024, updated for v3.100+). Pandora reads both Nemesis patch format and legacy FNIS XML natively — the only edge case identified is SCAR (see Task 3 below).

Behavior-requiring mods in the current modlist and their Pandora status:

Mod	Has Pandora Patch	Notes
MCO/ADXP	Yes	Tick in Pandora UI. BFCO author confirmed Pandora works.
BFCO	Yes	Tick in Pandora UI. Author-tested with v4.3.1.
SCAR	Yes (requires fix)	Tick in Pandora. Also needs [SCAR - Pandora - Fix] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/164638) loaded after SCAR. Without the fix: WARN : Dispatcher > "SCAR" > defaultfemale~1hm_behavior > Replace > Element > \\#2521/event/Element0/id > FAILED.
Animated Armoury OAR	Yes	Tick in Pandora for new weapon-type behaviors.
EVG Animated Traversal	Yes	Tick in Pandora.
SkyParkour	Yes	Tick in Pandora.
SkyClimb	Yes (if chosen)	Tick in Pandora.
XPMSSE	Yes (OR skip)	Do NOT tick the XPMSSE patch checkbox if using Universal Behaviour Runtime — Auto Skeleton Patch (mod 176724). The Auto Skeleton Patch replaces the old Pandora XPMSSE checkbox.
Precision	No patch needed	SKSE plugin only; no behavior generation.
AMR	No patch needed	SKSE plugin only; no behavior generation.
Payload Interpreter	No patch needed	SKSE plugin only; no behavior generation.
OAR	No patch needed	SKSE plugin only; no behavior generation.
IFrame Generator RE	No patch needed	SKSE plugin only; install only when a pack explicitly lists it.

Task 2 – MCO vs BFCO community signal on AE 1.6.1170 with Pandora

Both frameworks are actively maintained and Pandora-compatible. The community signal divides along a clear line:

- MCO remains the established standard with the larger moveset library (hundreds of MCO-format animation packs). It is the proven path with the most community tutorials and troubleshooting resources. Distar’s ecosystem (MCO, DMCO, related mods) is mature.
- BFCO is the rapidly growing alternative. Key advantages: built-in jump attacks, swim attacks, charge attacks, vanilla attack speed support, and gamepad MCM hotkey support — all features that MCO requires separate companion mods (or can’t do) to achieve. BFCO v3.100+ is described by the author as “almost done with my idea,” indicating maturity.

The MCO→BFCO Converter ([mod 119926](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/119926>), v1.2.2) is actively maintained and handles: file renaming, annotation conversion (attack speed, power windows, recovery, next-attack chaining, multi-window annotations), and batch processing. It converts MCO_powerattackloop*.hxx and MCO_powerattackoutro*.hxx files (supported since converter v1.2.1 / BFCO >= 3.3). The converter has gone through 10+ bugfix releases, with progressively better annotation fidelity.

BFCO also has a BFCO NG companion ([mod 160505](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/160505>)) for flexible hotkey assignment. BFCO's FOMOD offers pre-input behavior choices: "Vanilla Like" (can only input next attack after hit frame) vs "MCO Like" (can input next attack almost immediately – same feel as MCO).

Recommendation: BFCO is the better long-term fit for Elder Wilds given its built-in gamepad support, fewer companion-mods-required, and the converter making the MCO moveset library accessible. However, MCO remains a fully viable alternative. The decision can be deferred – either path works with Pandora and the rest of the stack.

Task 3 – SCAR + Pandora interaction confirmed

SCAR works with Pandora but needs the SCAR - Pandora - Fix ([mod 164638](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/164638>)). Requirements: Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus + SCAR AE Support. Install order: SCAR → SCAR AE Support → SCAR Pandora Fix. Then re-run Pandora.

Additional SCAR compatibility notes from community posts:

- If using SCAR AE Support ([mod 77285](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/77285>)) with BFCO: do NOT install the default animations in the SCAR AE Support FOMOD – they cause compatibility issues with BFCO.
- SCAR version 2.0 from GitHub (not the Nexus page) reportedly has issues with BFCO – stick to the Nexus version (v1.06b) for now.
- SCAR does not hard-require MCO; it works with MCO, BFCO, or SkySA/ABR. The SCAR Nexus comments explicitly state: **"You don't need MCO if you are using ABR or SkySA for this mod to work."**

Task 4 – MCO→BFCO converter quality assessment

The converter tool (v1.2.2) is actively maintained with good annotation fidelity but is not lossless. The changelog reveals the conversion has gone through multiple rounds of bugfixing:

- v1.1.3: Multi-window annotations fixed (animations with more than one MCO_nextattack or MCO_PowerWinOpen now convert correctly).
- v1.1.4: Added MCO_powerWinOpen/MCO_powerWinClose → BFCO annotation recognition.
- v1.1.5: Added attack speed annotation conversion (MCO_AttackSpeed → BFCO_AttackSpeed).
- v1.1.6: Old BFCO annotations are removed on re-conversion.
- v1.2.1: Power attack loop and outro files supported (MCO_powerattackloop*.hxx, MCO_powerattackoutro*.hxx).

Known limitations: the converter handles standard MCO annotations. MCO movesets with heavily custom or non-standard annotations may not convert perfectly. Complex movesets should be tested individually after conversion for: animation timing drift, ice-skating (lost motion data), missing combo-chain windows, and power attack trigger reliability.

Risk assessment for the converter: For the vast majority of MCO movesets with standard Distar-ecosystem annotations, the converter should produce clean BFCO output. Edge-case movesets with hand-tuned custom annotations are the primary risk. Given that Elder Wilds hasn't locked specific movesets yet, this is a manageable risk – verify each adopted moveset post-conversion rather than counting on batch-convert perfection.

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Pandora Framework And Prerequisites → separator: Animations - Framework

Mod	Type	Notes
[Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/133232)	Baseline	Single behavior-generation owner. Register as MO2 executable; output to dedicated Pandora Output mod.
[Universal Behaviour Runtime — Auto Skeleton Patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/176724)	Baseline	Runtime skeleton patching for XPMSSSE. Do NOT tick Pandora XPMSSSE patch checkbox.
[A-Pose Bug Fix — Universal Behavior Runtime](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/168903)	Baseline	Runtime A-pose interception and LE animation backward compatibility.

Risks & Compatibility

- Validate current Pandora install guide and requirements tab during setup.
- Leaving old generated output active or mixing generators makes debugging much harder.
- SCAR compatibility: SCAR triggers a known Pandora warning (defaultfemale~1hm_behavior > Replace > Element > \#2521). Install [SCAR - Pandora - Fix](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/164638>) after SCAR + SCAR AE Support to resolve it. Re-run Pandora after adding.
- Do NOT tick the Pandora XPMSSSE patch checkbox if Universal Behaviour Runtime — Auto Skeleton Patch is installed — they are mutually exclusive. The Auto Skeleton Patch is the preferred route.

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Skeleton And Behavior Prerequisites → separator: Animations - Framework

Mod	Type	Notes
[XP32 Maximum Skeleton Special Extended — XPMSSSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1988)	Baseline	Single skeleton baseline.
[CBPC — Physics with Collisions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/21224)	Baseline	Default first-pass physics for CBBE 3BA.
[FSMP — Faster HDT-SMP](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/57339)	Baseline	SMP coverage alongside CBPC. Required by OStim and some outfits.
[XPMSSSE Fixed Scripts](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/44252)	Alternative	Companion script fix over XPMSSSE.
[ConsoleUtilSSE NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/76649)	Alternative	Keep available for script-dependent pieces.

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Parkour, Climbing, And Free-Form Movement → separator: Animations - Interactions & Traversal

Mod	Type	Notes
[SkyParkour v3 - Procedural Parkour and Climbing Framework (SPPF)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/132292)	Baseline	Vault, climb, traverse environmental geometry. 10,112 endorsements.
[EVG CLAMBER - Slope Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114753)	Baseline	Character posture adjusts dynamically on slopes and stairs. Complements SkyParkour.
[Feminine EVG Clamber Stair Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148067)	Baseline	Female-specific stair animations for EVG CLAMBER.
[SkyClimb](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97253)	Alternative	Climbing-first alternative built around EVGAT. Pick one (not cumulative with SkyParkour).
Discipline-first route	Alternative	Vanilla climbing + TDM + sprint/jump only.

Horse Animation Candidates

Mod	Type	Notes
[Thundertrot Horse Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/140941)	Candidate	OAR-based horse movement/idle replacer.
[Horse Animation Overhaul (WIP - OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/140122)	Candidate	Broader horse animation replacement. WIP — evaluate stability.
[Riding Animation Overhaul - RAO (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/102881)	Candidate	OAR-based horse riding animation replacer.

All three are OAR-based and work under Pandora. Do not install together without verifying mutual compatibility.

Companion Candidates (evaluate after baseline is locked)

- Dova Jump ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/125550>)) — Stamina-based jump height/distance. Complements parkour.
- Walk Speed Tuner ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179215>)) — Configurable walk speed hotkey.
- Beam Walking Assist ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175511>))
- RaySense - Jumping over obstacles ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175506>))
- RaySense - Edge Lookdown ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175514>))
- Inertia - Physical Movement Response System ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172783>))

Risks & Compatibility

- SkyClimb and SkyParkour are competing — not harmless companions.
- Parkour can expose navmesh gaps in older worldspaces.
- This subsection owns vertical/lateral movement; dodge, sprint, and camera belong in → Third-Person.

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Locomotion → separator: Animations - Movement & Idles

Mod	Type	Notes
[Leviathan Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/81463)	Baseline	Male locomotion.
[Leviathan Animations II - Female Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80760)	Baseline	Female locomotion.
[Vanargand Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/99999)	Alternative	Main male alternative.
[Vanargand Animations II - Female Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/100000)	Alternative	Main female alternative.
[NPC Animation Remix (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/63471)	Alternative	NPC-specific movement and idle animation remix.
[Arm Movement Animations (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/62849)	Alternative	Hand and arm idle animation variations.
[Conditional Armor Type Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51507)	Alternative	Add after base locomotion is accepted.
[Dynamic Female Weather Idles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/98493)	Alternative	OAR-based weather-aware idles. Complements survival/weather stack.
[EVG Animated Traversal](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/63232)	Alternative	Belongs in interaction/traversal bucket.
[Goetia Animations - Female Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/68005)	Alternative	Female locomotion animation pack.
[Goetia Animations - Male Idle Walk And Run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/68625)	Alternative	Male locomotion animation pack.
[Poser Hotkeys Plus SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17743)	Alternative	Hotkey-based pose/idle system.
[More Tavern Idles - SSE Port](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16757)	Alternative	Tavern-specific idle animation variety.
[Lightweight Headtracking and Emotions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/224)	Alternative	NPC/PCP headtracking and expression support.

[Smooth Random Jump Animation - Rework] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/59633)	Alternative	Randomized jump animation replacer.
[Smooth Weapon Jump Animation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/74748)	Alternative	Weapon-drawn jump animation replacer.
[Random Swimming Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/92951)	Alternative	Randomized swimming animation replacer.
[Dynamic Sprint](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/95561)	Alternative	SKSE-based sprint animation with motion-matched lean.
[Dynamic Sprint Stop](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/107057)	Alternative	Sprint-stop animation with deceleration. Companion to Dynamic Sprint.
[Vanargand Animations - Sneak idle walk and run](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54351)	Alternative	Sneak locomotion animation pack.

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Combat Animation Packs → separator: Animations - Combat

Mod	Type	Notes
[Precision - Accurate Melee Collisions] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/72347)	Baseline	Accurate melee collision detection.
[SCAR - Skyrim Combos AI Revolution] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/72014)	Baseline	Add after Precision is proven. Companion mods: [SCAR AE Support](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/77285) + [SCAR Pandora Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/164638). If using BFCO, skip default animations in SCAR AE FOMOD.
[Animated Armoury - OAR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/103577)	Baseline	12 new weapon types. Requires [DAR Version](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/35978) for meshes/collision/leveled lists. Tick in Pandora for new weapon behaviors.
[No Spinning Death Animation LITE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33597)	Baseline	Prevents spinning death animations.
[MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117115)	High-Commitment	System-level decision. Evaluate later.
[Animation Motion Revolution](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/50258) + [Payload Interpreter] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65089)	High-Commitment	Required MCO support.
[IFrame Generator RE AE Support] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/82737)	Support	Install only when a pack explicitly lists it.
[BFCO - Attack Behavior Framework] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117052)	High-Commitment	System-level framework competing with MCO/ADXP. Mutually exclusive. Requires [DMK](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174499) for directional power attacks. Confirmed working with Pandora v4.3.1. Companion: [BFCO NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/160505) for flexible hotkeys.
[Elden Ring DLC Light Greatsword Moveset](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/122800)	Alternative	Requires MCO or BFCO framework. 1H and 2H moveset.

[Vindictus Fiona Moveset BFCO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/183971)	Alternative	BFCO-specific moveset. Requires BFCO framework.
[Vindictus Delia Animation Remake](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/104717)	Alternative	Combat animation pack.
[MCO / BFCO / SCAR WoLong QuarterStaffs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/128749)	Alternative	Works with MCO, BFCO, or SCAR. Quarterstaff moveset.
[Dynamic Killmove - Pike](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/103707)	Alternative	Killmove animation for pike/spear weapons.
[KG Animations - One-handers and Dual Wield](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/129519)	Alternative	One-handed and dual-wield combat animation pack.
[KG Animations - Two-handers](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/101541)	Alternative	Two-handed combat animation pack.
[Smooth Random Blocking Animation 3.0](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/59239)	Alternative	Randomized blocking animation replacer.
[Precision - Enchanted Weapon Trails](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/106358)	Alternative	Weapon trail VFX requiring Precision.
[Killmove Fixes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/140398)	Alternative	Killmove trigger and camera fixes.
[Goetia Animations - Magic Spell Casting](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/70204)	Alternative	Magic spell casting animation replacer.
[Diverse NPC Movesets](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/141893)	Alternative	Varied NPC combat stances via SCAR/OAR.
[For Honor in Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/151478)	High-Commitment	Comprehensive combat overhaul. Competing with MCO/BFCO and Valhalla.
[Vanargand Animations - Sneak Strike Attacks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/55420)	Alternative	Sneak power-attack animation replacer.
[Vanargand Animations - Sneak Thrust Attacks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/55031)	Alternative	Sneak thrust-attack animation replacer.
[Vanargand Animations - Archery](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/60323)	Alternative	Archery draw-and-release animation replacer.
[Vanargand Animations - Sneak Archery](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/56788)	Alternative	Sneak archery stance and release animation replacer.

[Vanargand Animations - Dual Wield Sneak Strikes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64216)	Alternative	Dual-wield sneak attack animation replacer.
[Vanargand Animations - Crossbows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/66286)	Alternative	Crossbow draw-and-fire animation replacer.
[Vanargand Animations - Sneak Crossbows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/67282)	Alternative	Sneak crossbow stance and fire animation replacer.
[Goetia Animations - Sneak Magic](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/75482)	Alternative	Sneak magic-casting animation replacer.
[Goetia Animations - Conditional Shouts](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/76388)	Alternative	Conditional shout animation replacer.
[Dynamic Dodge Animation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79598)	Alternative	SKSE-based dodge animation with i-frames. DMCO-compatible.

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ADXP/MCO Install Workflow Reference → separator: Animations - Combat

External tutorial baseline: [Capt. Panda — STEP BY STEP GUIDE on How to Install ADXP MCO for Skyrim SE and AE (MO2)](<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YeS6Pwnv3b8>). Captures the canonical ADXP/MCO install flow; references below use the Elder Wilds stack (Pandora for behaviour generation, OAR for conditional selection).

Tutorial Mod List — Elder Wilds Status

Mod	Tutorial role	Elder Wilds status
ADXP / MCO — Modern Movement Combat Overhaul (modding-guild.com)	Core combat overhaul	Listed in Combat Animation Packs as High-Commitment; adoption is a system-level decision, not a drop-in.
Animation Motion Revolution (AMR)	MCO motion support	Listed in Combat Animation Packs.
Payload Interpreter	AMR dependency	Listed in Combat Animation Packs.
Separate Power Attacks (reza9892, AE build)	Power-attack input scheme	Not yet adopted. Nexus page requires verification before listing.
ADXP/MCO — Valhalla Nordic Animation Reworked (Very Mingming)	Recommended moveset	Not yet adopted. Nexus page requires verification before listing.
Elden Ring Inspired Movesets (Black)	Recommended moveset	Not yet adopted. Nexus page requires verification before listing.

Install Flow (Pandora/OAR)

1. Download ADXP/MCO, AMR, and Payload Interpreter from their canonical pages; match SE vs AE builds to the Skyrim build (Elder Wilds targets AE 1.6.1170).
2. In MO2, group these under the Animations - Combat separator (3-dot menu → Create separator). Order between the three is not load-order-sensitive.
3. Install ADXP/MCO, Animation Motion Revolution, and Payload Interpreter as separate MO2 mods.
4. Open Animation Replacer covers conditional selection across the whole stack (→ Conditional Animation Systems).
5. Optionally install a moveset (Very Mingming's Valhalla Nordic, or Black's Elden Ring Inspired) under Animations - Combat — only after its Nexus page has been verified.
6. Create a dedicated empty MO2 mod named Pandora Output to receive generated behaviour files (→ Pandora Framework And Prerequisites).
7. Configure Pandora to write into Pandora Output (set output target to that empty mod, not to overwrite).
8. In Pandora, tick ADXP/MCO, Payload Interpreter, and any power-attack mod once adopted. Tick every other behaviour-requiring mod present in the load order.
9. Run Pandora: Update Engine → Launch. Keep antivirus off during generation; re-enable afterwards.
10. On generation error, exit Pandora, reopen, repeat Update Engine → Launch.
11. Launch Skyrim and verify: separate power-attack input and weapon-sheathe behaviour intact.

Risks & Compatibility

- The tutorial's Separate Power Attacks choice overrides one-click/custom OCPA. Third-person gamepad parity depends on the bound input (see → Third-Person Gameplay) and has not yet been evaluated.

- The IFrame Generator entry in Combat Animation Packs is only relevant when a pack explicitly lists it — do not install speculatively.

Acceptance Criteria

- ADXP/MCO, AMR, and Payload Interpreter install cleanly under Animations - Combat.
- Pandora generation completes with ADXP/MCO and Payload Interpreter ticked; output lands in Pandora Output.
- Power-attack and weapon-sheathe inputs work end-to-end in third-person gamepad, validated against → Third-Person Gameplay.
- Any added moveset or power-attack mod has its Nexus page verified before being formally added to Combat Animation Packs.

Research Tasks

- Verify Nexus pages for Separate Power Attacks (reza9892), ADXP/MCO – Valhalla Nordic Animation Reworked (Very Mingming), and Elden Ring Inspired Movesets (Black). The tutorial’s description links are truncated and these mods are not currently in the modlist.
- Cross-check r/skyrimmods signal for ADXP/MCO on AE 1.6.1170 with Pandora before locking or removing the High-Commitment stamp.
- Confirm the Separate Power Attacks input scheme’s behaviour in third-person gamepad (potential collision with dodge or block inputs) before adoption.

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Non-Combat Interaction Animations → separator: Animations - Interactions & Traversal

Mod	Type	Notes
[Immersive Interactions - Animated Actions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/47670)	Baseline	Core interaction animation framework.
[Go to bed](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/4224)	Baseline	Bed interaction animations.
[Animated Interactions SKSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/143798)	Alternative	Can coexist only if overlapping actions are deliberately disabled.
[Take a Seat](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54193)	Alternative	Sitting interaction animations.
[Immersive Hunting Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/96961)	Alternative	Hunting-related animations.
[Immersive Carcass Carrying](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/99867)	Alternative	Carcass carrying animations.
[Flute Animation Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/69609)	Alternative	Flute playing animation fix.
[Witcher Flute](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/144660)	Alternative	Witcher-style flute animation.
[EVG Animated Traversal](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63232)	Alternative	Environment traversal animations.
[Beginner Bard Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/130776)	Alternative	For Skyrim's Got Talent.
[Immersive Interactions - Eating ingredients and apply poison animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/117983)	Add-on	Eating and poison-apply animations for II.
[Dynamic Crafting Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/116422)	Add-on	Crafting-station interaction animations.
[Dynamic Looting and Harvesting Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114547)	Add-on	Looting and harvesting interaction animations.
[Dynamic Horse Petting Animations for Immersive Interactions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111767)	Add-on	Horse interaction animations for II.

[Tools Not Weapons (Pickaxe and Woodcutter Axe) DAR Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/70117)	Prerequisite	DAR/OAR animations for mining/chopping tools. Prerequisite for Chop Chop and related woodcutting mods.
[HSF Male Furniture Idles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155228)	Alternative	Male idle animations for furniture interactions.
[Modern Female Sitting Animations Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/85599)	Alternative	Female sitting animation replacements.
[Paired Animation Improvements](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/99621)	Alternative	Improved paired NPC interaction animations.
[Ultimate Animated Potions NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97674)	Alternative	Potion-use animation replacer.
[JellyFish Ultimate Animated Potions NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/168108)	Alternative	Expanded potion animation pack for Ultimate Animated Potions NG.
[Simple Wall Lean (RaySense)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/176847)	Alternative	Contextual wall-leaning idle animation.
[Simple Wall Lean - More feminine Female animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/182365)	Add-on	Female-specific variant for Simple Wall Lean.
[Divines Prayer Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/109175)	Alternative	Conditional prayer-idle animation at shrine activations.
[Gesture Animation Remix (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64420)	Alternative	Expanded gesture/idle animation variety via OAR.
[Lively Children Animations (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/67557)	Alternative	Child NPC animation variety for play/idle/run.
[Lively cart driver animation replacer or OAR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/70595)	Alternative	Cart driver animation replacer for carriage rides.

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Conditional Animation Systems → separator: Animations - Framework

Mod	Type	Notes
[Open Animation Replacer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/92109)	Baseline	Single condition framework owner.
[EVG Conditional Idles](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/34006)	Alternative	Idle animation conditional framework.
[Conditional Armor Type Animations] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/51507)	Alternative	Armor-type-based animation switching.
[Unique Jarl Throne Sitting Animation (OAR)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174752)	Alternative	Throne sitting animation for Jarls.
[Malignis Animations - Conditions](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/132028)	Alternative	OAR condition pack for animation variety. Personal favourite.

—

Camera-Aware Animation Support → separator: Animations - Framework

Mod	Notes
[Improved Camera SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim-specialedition/mods/93962)	Only if hybrid perspective is a real playstyle.
[Comprehensive First Person Animation Overhaul - CFPAO] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim-specialedition/mods/87169)	Optional first-person polish.

—

Equipment Display Framework → separator: Animations - Framework

Equipment visibility, sheathing positions, and draw-sheathe animations. Builds on XPMSSSE for third-person gamepad parity.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Immersive Equipment Displays (IED)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/62001)	Baseline	Equipment visibility and positioning framework.
[Simple Dual Sheath](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/50049)	Baseline	Dual-sheathed weapon support. Requires IED.
[Weapon Styles - Draw-Sheathe animations for IED](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/85085)	Addon	Conditional draw/sheathe animations per weapon type. Requires IED.
[Walking Stick - Walk with staves or polearms - IED-OAR](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/120966)	Addon	Staff/polearm walking animation support. Requires IED.
[Ready to Play IED](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/158531)	Alternative	Pre-configured IED preset. Evaluate only if manual IED configuration proves too time-consuming.
[Weapons On Back](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/14997)	Alternative	Weapon positioning on back rather than hip. Complements IED/SDS.

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Creature Animations → separator: Animations - Creatures

Mod	Notes
[New Creature Animation - Giant](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/83317)	Giant animation replacer.
[New Creature Animation - Werewolf](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/83806)	Werewolf animation replacer.
[New Creature Animation - Falmer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/83572)	Falmer animation replacer.
[DCA - Dragon Combat Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/123113)	Dragon combat animation replacer.
[Draugr Greatsword Animation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114721)	Greatsword-wielding draugr animation replacer.
[Troll - MCO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175250)	Troll combat animation replacer (requires MCO).

Risks & Compatibility

- Validate per-pack combat-animation support individually. Keep layer small and intentional.

—

Animation Conflict Management → separator: Animations - Framework

Strict ownership: one clear owner per layer.

Owners

- Behavior generation: Pandora only
- Skeleton: XPMSSSE only
- Conditional selection: Open Animation Replacer only

Workflow

- Keep Pandora output isolated in dedicated MO2 output mod.
- Record which mods rely on generation, which on OAR, and which are pure presentation.
- Test in repeatable scenarios: town walking, idle downtime, dungeon corridors, uneven outdoor combat, interaction-heavy interiors, creature encounters.

Risks & Compatibility

- Animation conflicts look like camera, combat, or skeleton bugs until ownership is checked.
- Mixed generated output hides whether a problem is from load order or stale behavior files.

—

Open Research

Open research for the animations stack is tracked in `TODO.md`.

Third-Person Gameplay

MO2 Separators: Third-Person - Camera & Movement, Third-Person - Combat & Targeting, Third-Person - Mounted

All mods in this section belong to one of the three third-person separators as noted per subsection.

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Third-Person Camera Framework → separator: Third-Person - Camera & Movement

Baseline

- SmoothCam ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/41252>)) — Main third-person camera framework.

Alternatives

- Customizable Camera ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/12201>)) — Leaner fallback.
- True Directional Movement ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51614>)) — Governs movement/targeting, not the camera framework itself.
- Improved Camera SE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/93962>)) — Perspective support, not main third-person framework.
- Modern Combat Gamepad Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123409>)) — Gamepad-centric combat controls integration. Research before adding — evaluate overlap with TDM and the combat stack.

Risks & Compatibility

- A good preset can hide weak camera behavior — judge the framework, not the preset.
- Over-tuned cameras look impressive in clips but become tiring.

—

Camera Presets And Shoulder Switching → separator: Third-Person

- Camera & Movement

Restrained centered-to-light-offset baseline. Shoulder switching is a support feature for visibility problems, not the main camera identity.

Risks & Compatibility

- Aggressive over-the-shoulder framing creates visibility issues in interiors and dungeons.
- Shoulder switching that feels mandatory too often = poor baseline framing.

—

True Directional Movement → separator: Third-Person - Camera & Movement

- True Directional Movement - Modernized Third Person Gameplay ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/51614>)) — Modern 360-degree character-relative movement.
- Core value: freer facing, cleaner traversal, better animation-stack alignment.
- May feel awkward in tight interiors, stairs, or precision positioning.

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Target Lock And Targeting Behavior → separator: Third-Person - Combat & Targeting

- TDM as the targeting-behavior owner. Keep lock-on restrained — optional combat-readability tool, not permanent default.
- TrueHUD ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/62775>)) — Optional feedback companion. Add only if testing shows material improvement.

Risks & Compatibility

- Weak target selection/switching makes even good camera and movement feel unreliable.
 - TrueHUD can create illusion of a solved targeting system when the underlying behavior is still awkward.
-

Dodge, Sprint, And Movement Responsiveness → separator: Third-Person - Camera & Movement

Baseline

- TK Dodge RE - Script Free ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/56956>)) — First dodge candidate. Tactical repositioning, not combat pacing center.

Alternatives

- TK Dodge SE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/15309>)) — Legacy fallback reference.
- Dodge for all ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimpecialedition/mods/174544>)) — Newer (May 2026). Too early for baseline — low community signal.

—

Hit Reactions, Stagger, And Impact Feedback → separator: Third-Person - Combat & Targeting

Mod	Notes
[Valhalla Combat](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/64741)	Main gameplay-side comparison for hit feedback and stagger.
Precision (from → Animations)	Adjacent support for contact feel.

Risks & Compatibility

- Too much stagger flattens combat; too little leaves animations unsatisfying.
- Camera, animation timing, collision, and gameplay rules all affect impact feel — ownership blurs quickly.

—

Third-Person Combat Systems → separator: Third-Person - Combat & Targeting

Mod	Type	Notes
[Valhalla Combat](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/64741)	Baseline	Gameplay-rule framework.
[MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/117115)	Alternative	Ambitious alternative. Re-evaluate deliberately.
SCAR (from → Animations)	Baseline	NPC-side attack variety.
[Knockback SKSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/171277)	Support	Required only if MCO is chosen.
[RaySense - Cover Animation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/175504)	Optional	Cover animation system.
[Fire Ignites Arrows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/118544)	Optional	Arrow ignition from fire sources.
[Poisoned Arrows and Bolts](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123585)	Optional	Poison crafting for ranged ammo.
[Variadic Collision Dynamics](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/183892)	Optional	Runtime collision-capsule adjustments.
[Variadic Collision Dynamics - Resources] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/184110)	Optional	Ready-to-use JSON presets for VCD.
[Next-Gen Decapitations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135254)	Optional	Decapitation system replacement with improved gore visuals.
[Death Drop Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/151590)	Optional	Changes how NPC bodies ragdoll and drop on death.
[Dismembering Framework](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126203)	Optional	Dismemberment system framework.
[DF - Official Humanoid Asset Pack](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126327)	Add-on	Required asset pack for Dismembering Framework (humanoid).
[DF - Official Creature Asset Pack](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126328)	Add-on	Creature asset pack for Dismembering Framework (optional).
[Eviscerate](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/68884)	Optional	Combat gore / dismemberment alternative.

[Cinema - Dynamic Combat Letterbox] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171912)	Optional	Letterbox overlay during combat.
[Parry for All](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/167873)	Optional	Parrying support for non-equipped actors.
[Deadly spell impact](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/146299)	Optional	Spell impact visual + audio upgrade.

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Crosshair And Aiming Behavior → separator: Third-Person - Combat & Targeting

Mod	Notes
[Better Third Person Selection - BTPS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/64339)	Object-selection reliability.
TrueHUD	Optional aiming readability aid.
[Ricochet - Arrow Physics Framework](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/160603)	Lock only if archery is a meaningful combat style.

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Horse Camera And Mounted Controls → separator: Third-Person - Mounted

Mod	Type	Notes
[Press H to Horse](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/81195)	Baseline	Actively maintained (May 2026). Few vanilla record edits.
[Horses Simply Turn Better](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57790)	Baseline	Free add-on. Sharpens turning radius for TDM.
[Convenient Horses](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/9519)	Alternative	Last updated Jan 2022 (stale).
[Simplest Horses](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54225)	Alternative	Lightweight SPID+MCM drop-in.
[HorsePower - Modernized horse riding] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/169335)	Alternative	Modernized horse riding overhaul.

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Third-Person Interactions: Lockpicking → separator: Third-Person - Combat & Targeting

Gamepad-accessible lockpicking that works entirely in third-person without mouse input. Required by the design directive — every interaction must work in third-person with a gamepad.

Mod	Notes
[Break The Lock - OIF](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/154901)	Physics-based lockpicking with breakable locks via OIF. Gamepad-compatible, third-person usable. Requires OIF framework.

Open Research

Open research for the third-person stack is tracked in `TODO.md`.

Expanded Systems

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression, Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks, Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs, Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy, Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

Overview

This section owns the gameplay systems that expand Skyrim beyond its 2011 baseline: character creation, progression, magic, perks, survival, crafting, economy, followers, and social systems. Each pillar of the Expanded Systems section lives in its own sub-file.

The system is designed to be evaluated in order — progression choices (races, standing stones, perks) come before magic, survival, crafting, and social systems that build on them.

Sub-Files

Area	File	Separator	Topics
Character & Progression	[Character & Progression](modlist-expanded-character.md)	Expanded Systems - Character & Progression	Alternate starts, races, standing stones, traits, religion, vampire/werewolf/shouts
Magic & Perks	[Magic & Perks] (modlist-expanded-magic.md)	Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks	Perk overhauls, magic expansion, stealth/detection
Survival & Needs	[Survival & Needs] (modlist-expanded-survival.md)	Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs	Survival frameworks, hygiene, death alternative
Crafting & Economy	[Crafting & Economy] (modlist-expanded-crafting.md)	Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy	Alchemy, cooking, smithing, enchanting, economy
Followers & Reputation	[Followers & Reputation](modlist-expanded-followers.md)	Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation	Crime/reputation, follower frameworks, romance/marriage

Key Principles

- Simonrim progression family (Adamant, Mysticism, Thaumaturgy, etc.) is the default baseline; EnaiRim (Ordinator, Apocalypse, etc.) is the high-expression branch → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression, Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks
- Survival, difficulty, and balance interactions across the full load order are owned by modlist-survival-combat.md → Survival & Combat
- All system choices must be evaluated for third-person gamepad usability and compatibility with the Legacy of the Dragonborn museum pillar → Legacy of the Dragonborn

Character & Progression

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

All mods in this section belong to the Expanded Systems - Character & Progression MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](modlist-expanded-systems.md) section.

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Character Creation And Starting Choices → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

How Elder Wilds begins: a grounded alternate start, a utility-first start, or a configurable route. The decision should improve replayability and roleplay expression without pre-answering later race, progression, religion, survival, or follower choices.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Alternate Perspective — Alternate Start](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/50326)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Main baseline candidate.
[Dealing with Backstories](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/61106)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Origins companion — background-driven starting skills, bonuses, drawbacks, gear.
[Take Notes — Journal of the Dragonborn SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/13570)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Persistent in-game journal. Low-risk roleplay companion.
[Roleplaying In Skyrim — Origins](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/150186)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Origin-driven flavor and bonuses. Requires SKSE + Papyrus Ini Manipulator; soft-requires Actor Value Generator + SkyUI.
[Alternate Start — Live Another Life](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/272)	Alternative	all	Conservative fallback.
[Skyrim Unbound Reborn](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/27962)	Alternative	all	Configurable middle ground with more setup freedom.
[Realm of Lorkhan — Freeform Alternate Start](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/18223)	Alternative	\3	Freeform branch. Not the default baseline.
[Why I Came to Skyrim - Origin Stories](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/167166)	Alternative	all	Background-driven starting scenario with narrative hook.
[Why I Came to Skyrim - Skyrim Unbound Reborn patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/167577)	Alternative	all	Patch for Origin Stories + Skyrim Unbound Reborn.
[Skyrim Unbound Reborn - New started room](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/118648)	Alternative	all	Improvement to Unborn start room
[Racemenu Enhancer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/182536)	Alternative	all	RaceMenu character creation enhancement.

[Adventurer's Start - An Alternate Perspective Addon](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/145599)	Add-on	all	Additional starting scenarios for Alternate Perspective. Install after AP base.
[Alternate Perspective - Hole in the Wall Fix](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174222)	Add-on	all	Fix for AP's starting cell geometry. Install after AP base.

Risks & Compatibility

- Start frameworks carry world-state assumptions that ripple into later quest, city, survival, or follower decisions.
- Dealing with Backstories must be judged against the chosen race, standing-stone, perk, and survival stack.
- Take Notes only earns a slot if the list expects real roleplay or long-form journaling.
- A more immersive start loses value if it adds onboarding friction without materially improving the early-game tone.
- This subsection gets muddy if race, perk, religion, or survival decisions leak into it too early.

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Race Overhauls → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

How race traits shape long-term character identity. Choose before perks, magic, and religion build on top of it.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Aetherius — Race Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/26686)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route; pairs with Evenstar.
[Morningstar — Minimalistic Races](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22298)	Alternative	\3	Restrained fallback.
[Imperious — Races of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1315)	Alternative	\1, \4	High-expression comparison; pairs with Andromeda.

Roleplaying in Skyrim Companion Series: Race

> All RiS mods require SKSE. Check individual mod pages for specific dependencies.

Mod	Purpose	Dial	Requirements
[RiS — Races](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/149544)	Biological race overhaul	all	KID, SPID
[RiS — Lineages](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174443)	4 subraces per vanilla race	all	KID, SPID, Papyrus Ini Manipulator

Risks & Compatibility

- Race overhauls can quietly pre-decide too much of the character-building experience.
- A very expressive route can push optimization-heavy play even if the project wants immersive tone.
- A very light route can undershoot if later systems assume stronger identity hooks.

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Standing Stones → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

How standing stones and birthsigns provide ongoing passive identity. Judge together with race pick so the progression baseline stays coherent.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Evenstar — Standing Stones](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/41256)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route; pairs with Aetherius.
[Mundus — A Standing Stone Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33411)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Simonrim route; pairs with Aetherius.
[Andromeda — Standing Stones](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14910)	Alternative	\1, \4	High-expression comparison; pairs with Imperious.

Roleplaying in Skyrim Companion Series: Standing Stones

> All RiS mods require SKSE. Check individual mod pages for specific dependencies.

Mod	Purpose	Dial	Requirements
[RiS — Standing Stones](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/157053)	13 stones overhaul	all	aTweaks and Utilities, KID, Perk Entry Point Extender, SkyUI
[RiS — Birthsigns](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/154610)	Monthly waxing/waning birthsign effects	all	KID, Papyrus Ini Manipulator

Risks & Compatibility

- Stone and birthsign overhauls can quietly pre-decide too much of the character-building experience.
- Judge race and stone picks as a pair so the progression baseline stays coherent.

—

Character Progression Mechanics → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Supporting progression layers that govern how stats and skills grow over time.

> All RiS mods require SKSE. Check individual mod pages for specific dependencies.

Mod	Purpose	Dial	Requirements
[RiS — Classic Attributes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/151476)	10 classic RPG attributes	\1, \4	Actor Value Generator
[RiS — Useful MiscStats](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/149142)	Misc stat progression layer	all	Actor Value Generator
[RiS — Skill Based Stat Growth] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147455)	Health/Magicka/Stamina grow with skills	\1, \4	Papyrus Ini Manipulator

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Character Traits And Identity Hooks → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Opt-in character-defining quirks shaping a run from the start without replacing the broader progression stack. Goal: stronger roleplay identity and replayability, not a giant second character-build framework.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Biggie Traits](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/136384)	Baseline	\1, \4	Run-defining tradeoffs. Fallout-style traits. No hard dependencies.
[Pumping Iron — Dynamic Muscle Growth](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/13434)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Cosmetic muscle growth from combat + sleep. No gameplay impact.
Minimalist route	Alternative	\2, \3	Leave identity to race, standing stones, perks, and self-imposed roleplay.

Risks & Compatibility

- Trait systems can duplicate what race, perk, religion, or survival choices are already doing.
- If the best traits are too obviously optimal, the whole idea collapses into routine min-maxing.
- Traits should sharpen character identity and replayability, not replace the race-and-perk decisions above.

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Religion Or Roleplay Systems → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

How much explicit spiritual identity and day-to-day roleplay texture Elder Wilds wants.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Pilgrim — A Religion Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/54099)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Fits Simonrim-leaning progression family.
[Trua — Minimalistic Faiths of Skyrim] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/32549)	Alternative	\3	Restrained fallback.
[Wintersun — Faiths of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22506)	Alternative	\1, \4	High-expression route for stronger roleplay pillar.
[Gods And Worship](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/45011)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Full deity worship system with shrines, blessings, and penalties.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very light religion route can undershoot and leave roleplay identity too close to vanilla.
- A heavy deity-centered framework can make religion dominate character identity.
- Survival, economy, and follower expectations can drift into this section if faith routines aren't scoped carefully.
- Judge by ordinary play rhythm: prayer habits, shrine relevance, exploration texture.

—

Race-Specific Overhauls → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Dedicated overhauls for vampire, werewolf, and shout gameplay — three character-identity systems vanilla leaves shallow. These complete the EnaiRim suite begun with Andromeda (standing stones). All three are by EnaiSiaion, designed to work together, and require no cross-patching.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Sacrosanct — Vampires of Skyrim] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3928)	Baseline	\1, \4	Vampirism progression, 4 feeding tiers, blood-power by age. 133K endorsements.
[Growl — Werebeasts of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14645)	Baseline	\1, \4	Beast-form progression, perks, 5 werebear varieties.
[Thunderchild — Epic Shouts](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1460)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	19 new shouts (57 words), meditation mechanics, boss encounters.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\3	Vanilla vampire/werewolf/shout systems.

Risks & Compatibility

- All three are EnaiSiaion, designed to work with Ordinator, Andromeda, Apocalypse, and the broader EnaiRim ecosystem by design.
- Sacrosanct and Growl interact with Heart of the Beast (werewolf transformation audio) in section 10. Load transformation-sfx after transformation-system mods.
- Thunderchild's new shouts interact with shout-audio mods (Airgetlam - Shouts SFX) from section 10. Verify sfx replacements apply to Thunderchild's shouts, not just vanilla.
- Vampire feeding interacts with the crime-and-reputation baseline (Skyrim Reputation from → Followers & Reputation). Test feeding in cities.
- Thunderchild's boss encounters may overlap with world-content mods from → World Content.

—

Train And Study Systems → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

Training and study utilities for off-combat skill progression.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Train and Study](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17578)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Training overhaul: study skill books, practice at training dummies, learn from NPCs.
[Train and Study - Base Object Swapper] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42920)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	BOS addon for Train and Study — enables training dummy interaction via BOS. Install both together.

—

Experience and Leveling → separator: Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

How the player gains levels and skill points. Instead of vanilla sleep-to-level, use Experience (discovery-based leveling) paired with Static Skill Leveling Rewritten (cooldown-gated skill advancement) for progression earned through exploration and deliberate practice.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Experience](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/17751)	Baseline	\1, \4	Core leveling — exploration, quests, combat, discovery. Not skill grinding.
[Experience — MCM](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/65880)	Baseline	\1, \4	MCM config for XP rates and per-source toggles.
[Static Skill Leveling Rewritten](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/89940)	Baseline	\1, \4	Cooldown-based skill advancement. ESL-flagged.
[No Startup Quest XP](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/55682)	Baseline	\1, \4	Prevents XP from startup quests with alternate start.
[Skyshards](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/60748)	Baseline	\1, \4	60+ glowing shards granting XP on collection. ESL-flagged.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\2, \3	Vanilla sleep-to-level. Avoids patcher requirement.
Static Skill Leveling — Custom Preset	Alternative	all	Manual tuning instead of Simpler Preset.

Risks & Compatibility

- Experience's Synthesis Patcher must be re-run whenever the load order changes.
- Static Skill Leveling's cooldown may feel restrictive; the Simple Preset mitigates this. Tune via .ini if needed.
- Skyshards placement may clip with city overhauls, new-lands mods, or landscape edits.
- All four mods are ESL-flagged or lightweight, adding minimal plugin pressure.

Experience Configuration For #1 (Static With Hard Threat)

Settings tuned for the adopted combination: power fantasy XP pace, high level cap, rewarding discovery and quest completion, no skill grinding.

Setting	Value	Notes
iMaxPlayerLevel	250	Very high cap for content-heavy list — quest mods, discovery, clearing, Skyshards. Room to keep growing through all major quest content.
fSkillCapBase	18	Default — skills cap relative to player level.
fSkillCapMult	2	Default — +2 skill cap per player level. Reaches skill 100 at level 41.
bEnableKilling	true (default)	Kill XP enabled. Use the Synthesis Patcher for compatibility.
iXPQuestMain	75 (default)	Main quests feel rewarding.

iXPQuestSide	75	Slightly boosted from 50 — side content is where “living the world” lives.
iXPQuestDaedric	75 (default)	Daedric quests feel meaningful.
iXPQuestObjectives	10 (default)	Partial completion still awards progress.
All discovery XP	Default	Location discovery awards modest XP.
All clear XP	Default	Location clearing awards meaningful XP.
fXPLevelUpBase / fXPLevelUpMult	Vanilla	Uses the default Skyrim leveling curve (no change needed).
bUseRacialCaps	true (default)	Racial skill bonuses matter.
bEnableSkillXP	false (default)	No skill grinding — XP comes from doing, not training.

Magic & Perks

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks

All mods in this section belong to the Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](modlist-expanded-systems.md) section.

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Perk Overhaul Compatibility → separator: Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks

How much rules density and specialization pressure the list actually wants once race and standing-stone choices are in place.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Adamant — A Perk Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/30191)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route.
[Vokrii — Minimalistic Perks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26176)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Restrained if Adamant feels too system-forward.
[Ordinator — Perks of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1137)	Alternative	\1, \4	High-complexity branch. Pairs with \1's heavy-perks recommendation.

Risks & Compatibility

- A dense perk framework can dominate the character-building experience and make later systems feel secondary.
- A restrained framework can make the list feel under-committed if other systems also land on the conservative side.
- Compare perk candidates against the already-preferred race-and-stone direction so the full progression stack stays coherent.

—

Magic System Expansion → separator: Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks

How broad, readable, and build-defining magic should feel once race, standing-stone, and perk baseline are in place.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Mysticism — A Magic Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/27839)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route.
[Triumvirate — Mage Archetypes] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/39170)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Identity-driven archetype spells (Cleric, Druid, Shadow Mage, Shaman, Warlock).
[Strange Runes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/19438)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Floating Nordic runes during spell charging. Visual only, no records.
[Odin — Skyrim Magic Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/46000)	Alternative	\1, \4	Moderate expansion.
[Apocalypse — Magic of Skyrim] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1090)	Alternative	\1, \4	Maximum spell variety.
[Lost Grimoire SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/4455)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	115+ lore-friendly spells. Compatible with any primary overhaul.
[Elemental Mastery Magic](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139953)	Alternative	\1, \4	Elemental specialization and tiered mastery bonuses.
[Immersive Illusion Spells](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142357)	Alternative	\1, \4	New illusion types beyond fear/calm/frenzy.
[360 Ward](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/156225)	Alternative	all	Wards block from any direction. Third-person improvement.
[Sanguine Symphony](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/148388)	Alternative	\1, \4	Blood-magic spells costing Health. Compatible with all overhauls.
[Revealing Rune](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/120935)	Candidate	all	Makes rune traps visible. Evaluate after primary overhaul locked.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very large spell ecosystem can dominate progression and make race, perk, and religion feel secondary.
- Layering multiple spell packages casually turns this into a compatibility problem.
- Mysticism and Odin should be treated as competing primary overhauls, not a default combined baseline.
- Choose one primary magic overhaul first, then decide whether extra spell volume is actually needed.

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Stealth And Detection → separator: Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks

How Skyrim's detection system should be recalibrated for modern stealth mechanics without replacing the existing perk, magic, and combat layers.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Realistic AI Detection (RAID)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/2345)	Baseline	\1, \4	Script-free detection recalibration. 23.8K endorsements.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\2, \3	Rely on perk overhaul + Foundations bugfix mods.
Deferred high-commitment branch	Alternative	all	Add stealth toolkit only if playtesting requires it.

Risks & Compatibility

- Detection recalibration can make encounter zones feel too easy or hard if it interacts with difficulty mods from → Survival & Combat.
- A detection overhaul can make stealth-only play too dominant if it stacks with a perk overhaul that already buffs sneak.
- Detection changes can affect follower behavior; verify follower behavior under RAID with the chosen follower framework.
- RAID last updated April 2022 — script-free means less breakage risk, but verify detection feels right against the chosen perk overhaul.

Survival & Needs

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs

All mods in this section belong to the Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](modlist-expanded-systems.md) section.

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Survival Systems → separator: Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs

How much day-to-day bodily upkeep the list wants: enough hunger, fatigue, cold, weather, disease, and wilderness friction for roleplay and travel texture, or a heavier survival framework as a central system. This section owns the baseline survival direction; → Survival & Combat owns later balance and difficulty interactions.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Starfrost — A Survival Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97536)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Fits Simonrim-aligned progression family.
[SunHelm Survival](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/39414)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Practical if Starfrost proves too tightly tuned.
[Last Seed — Survival Needs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56393)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Heavier classic route.
[Frostfall](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/671) + [Campfire](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/667)	Alternative	\1	Harsh wilderness route. Adds: [Campfire - Script Optimization](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/149913), [Frostfall - Seasons](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/16317), [Frostfall Spell Monitor Optimized](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65700).
[Skills of the Wild](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37693) v2.0+	Optional	\1	4 new skill trees (Hunting, Foraging, Tracking, Camping). Requires Campfire. Full compatibility with any survival baseline.

Risks & Compatibility

- A heavy survival system can dominate pacing and crowd out other expanded systems.
- A very light setup can undershoot the immersive-travel pillar if later downtime decisions expect more texture.
- Cold, disease, food, sleep, and camping can blur together between survival, cooking, roleplay, and religion ownership.
- Judge survival primarily on travel texture, downtime rhythm, and world feel rather than maximum hardship.

—

Roleplay Upkeep And Hygiene → separator: Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs

Lighter day-to-day body-maintenance layer between full survival needs and pure visual flavor. Adds believable downtime rituals without turning hygiene into a second dominant survival framework.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Bathing in Skyrim — Renewed] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135288)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	SKSE + KPE + PO3 Papyrus Extender. Auto freecam, custom bathing animations, washable blood decal removal, bundled dirt overlays, unique soap with SkyPatcher distribution.
Minimalist route	Alternative	all	Leave hygiene implied through inns, rivers, roleplay.

Key Features

- Washable Blood — Uses a KPE function (not Dirt & Blood's overlay-based system) to remove blood decals directly. Compatible with Enhanced Blood Textures, Just Blood, Sanguine Symphony.
- Dirtiful Dirt — Bundles Zaki's 2K dirt overlays. Optional: Zaki's higher-res variants or MoonMods alternative textures.
- Custom Animations — Packaged male animations (Tweens) and female animations (BakaFactory, Krzp). Auto-detects JVRaven's Malignis Bathing animations. Falls back to vanilla bathing idles — no FNIS/Pandora requirement for basic use.
- Unique Soap — Craftable at cooking pots from vanilla materials, or buy from general merchants (SkyPatcher). Multiple soap types with different benefits. Linen wash rag as a soap-free fallback.
- Automatic Freecam — Switches to third-person freecam during bathing, matching the pattern of other animation frameworks.
- Follower Support — Tracks and manages follower hygiene alongside the player.

Hard Dependencies

Already in the → Foundations baseline: Kris's Papyrus Extender, PapyrusUtil, PO3's Papyrus Extender, RaceMenu. No additional dependency installs needed.

JSON Configuration

BiSR supports auto-start via JSON in `ModOrganizer.ini`:

```
[CustomConverter]
\path\data/mods/Bathing in Skyrim Renewed/SKSE/plugins/BathingInSkyrimRenewed.json
```

Use `"!!doautoload" : 1` and `"!!doautostart" : 1` to skip MCM setup on new games.

Configuration Discipline

- Hygiene busywork risk. Configure overlay intervals and NPC tracking counts to taste.
- Equipment handling, overlays, and optional integrations need stricter discipline than a simple immersion add-on.
- Only hard runtime requirements should be treated as mandatory.
- For Steam runtime 1.6.1170, Backported Extended ESL Support requirement does not apply.

—

Death Alternative System → separator: Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs

What happens when the player falls in combat. Goal: add consequence and narrative texture to defeat without making every lost fight permanent.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Shadow of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/72924)	Baseline	\1, \4	Nemesis system — respawn with debuffs, enemies gain name/buffs/presence, defeat nemesis to restore progress.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	all	Vanilla death-and-reload loop.

Risks & Compatibility

- Death-alternative systems interact with every combat mod. Verify compatibility with Valhalla Combat, Precision, TK Dodge, and combat-animation mods from → Animations.
- The nemesis system adds persistent NPCs and effects; verify save file size remains reasonable over long playthroughs.
- Death-alternative mods can create edge cases with scripted-death sequences in quests. Check compatibility with Alternate Perspective, Wurmstooth, The Forgotten City, and major quest mods from → World Content.
- Confirm compatibility with Steam 1.6.1170 and the SKSE plugin stack from → Foundations.

Crafting & Economy

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy

All mods in this section belong to the Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](modlist-expanded-systems.md) section.

—

Alchemy Overhaul → separator: Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy

Whether alchemy is a disciplined support system for potions/poisons/ingredients or a larger rework reshaping cooking and survival-adjacent loops.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Apothecary — An Alchemy Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/52130)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route.
[Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/19924)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Large integrated alchemy + cooking pillar.
[Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/5877)	Alternative	all	Lighter fallback.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very large alchemy package can quietly absorb cooking and food design.
- A restrained overhaul can undershoot if too many adjacent systems also land on conservative choices.
- Treat large food-and-cooking coverage as a deliberate expansion choice, not something hitchhiking into the alchemy baseline.

Flavor Additions

Mod	Dial	Notes
[Alchemy Requires Bottles] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/137443)	all	Empty potions at alchemy lab. Adds bottle-crafting step. Tentative — evaluate gameplay friction.

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Cooking Systems → separator: Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy

Whether food and cooking are mostly ambient support for travel and downtime or a deliberate progression-and-preparation layer.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Gourmet — A Cooking Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/96876)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Balanced modern route.
[Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/19924)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Integrated alchemy + cooking.
[Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5877)	Alternative	all	Lighter fallback.
[Mealtime](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22496)	Alternative	all	Recipe-density companion if Gourmet's scope feels too narrow.
[More Plants and Recipes SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69955)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Adds new plants and recipes to cooking/alchemy. Complements Gourmet.

Visual Companions

Mod	Dial	Notes
[Hyper Realistic Cooked Beef](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/173752) + [Hyper Realistic Bread](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/173283)	all	Mesh/texture-only replacers. Zero plugin overhead.
[Skyrim 3D Cooking](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/23007)	all	Higher-detail cooking pot, oven, food-prep meshes. Mesh-only, no plugin.
[Realistic HD Food Remastered](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22087)	all	Photorealistic food textures.

Risks & Compatibility

- Cooking can become too dependent on the survival framework and stop making sense as its own system.
- A very large cooking package can quietly absorb alchemy and economy ownership.
- Judge cooking on inns, camps, home bases, travel prep, and downtime rhythm rather than recipe volume alone.

—

Smithing And Crafting Expansion → separator: Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy

What crafting is supposed to do: lightly improve vanilla smithing, become a broader rules-and-materials framework, or shift responsibility toward NPC services and roleplay texture.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Ars Metallica](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/321)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Smithing XP, tanning, mining improvements. No heavy rules restructuring.
[Honed Metal](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/61015)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	NPC crafting/enchanting services. Makes gold economy matter.
[Thaumaturgy — Enchanting Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/57138)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Simonrim-aligned. Pairs with Mysticism + Adamant. Prerequisite for artifact overhauls.
[Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/28608)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	High-complexity material logic and crafting rules.
[Summermyst — Enchantments](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6285)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	140 new enchantment effects. Verify compatibility with Thaumaturgy.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very large crafting framework can absorb economy and loot-balance ownership.
- Mixing player-centric crafting with strong NPC-service assumptions can produce an incoherent progression loop.
- Ars Metallica and Honed Metal serve different purposes and should be locked together as complementary.

Woodcutting Support

Prerequisite chain for Chop Chop woodcutting gameplay:

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Woodcutting Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/53538)	Prerequisite	all	Woodcutting behavior improvements.
[KN Cutting Trees](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/28715)	Prerequisite	all	Cutting Trees framework for wood-chopping. Required by Chop Chop.
[Chop Chop](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/171529)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Interactive wood-chopping gameplay with choppable trees and resource gathering.

Also requires Tools Not Weapons (Pickaxe and Woodcutter Axe) DAR Animations from → [Animations & Movement](modlist-animations.md) for mining/chopping weapon animations.

Farming & Gardening

Mod	Dial	Notes
[Simplicity of Seeding - Better Hearthfires and Farming CC Planter Scripts](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/94428)	all	Improves Hearthfires planter scripts for more reliable farming. ESL-flagged.

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Economy And Loot Balance → separator: Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy

What economy and loot should feel like: lightly rebalanced merchant-and-pricing, deliberate loot distribution, or harsher scarcity-driven progression.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
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[Trade and Barter](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/23081)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Merchant-pricing route.
[C.O.I.N. — Coins of Interesting Nature] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51439)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Regional coin variety. No price/loot changes.
[C.O.I.N. — Treasury Exchange](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131682)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	Currency exchange for coin type conversion.
[Open World Loot](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/49681)	Alternative	\1, \4	Curated loot progression and encounter rewards. Prefer SkyPatched variant below.
[Open World Loot - SkyPatched](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/110795)	Alternative	\1, \4	SkyPatched forward-port resolving record-level conflicts. Preferred over original.
[MorrowLoot Ultimate](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/3058)	Alternative	\1	Heavy scarcity. Only if delevled loot is a defining pillar.

RiS Economy Series (optional)

Mod	Purpose	Dial	Requirements
[RiS — Encounter Zones] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/149899)	Reworks encounter zones with randomizer. ESL-flagged.	\1, \4	None
[RiS — Evolving Economy] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/149830)	Dynamic pricing by resources, season, Civil War, reputation, distance.	\1, \4	Papyrus Ini Manipulator, Po3 Papyrus Extender
[RiS — Loot Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/157259)	Rarity-driven loot, equipment breakage, delevled artifacts.	\1	Papyrus Ini Manipulator, SkyUI

Flavor & Content

Mod	Dial	Notes
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[Narrative Loot](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/12812)	all	1,629 lore-friendly misc items. No economy changes. Stacks cleanly.
[SUDs — Skyrim's Unique Drinks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/85824)	all	50+ unique drink items with custom meshes, textures, effects.
[Amulets of Skyrim SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/487)	all	Adds wearable amulets for every deity, new quest amulets, and improved visuals.
[Amulets of Skyrim - Tweaks and Fixes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/31814)	all	Bugfix and compatibility patch for Amulets of Skyrim. Install after base.
[Immersive Jewelry SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5336)	all	800+ earrings, rings, necklaces, bracelets. Heavy leveled-list integration.
[Immersive Jewelry - Lower Value](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51255)	all	Value rebalance for Immersive Jewelry items. Optional — review for economy fit.

Risks & Compatibility

- A heavy loot-distribution framework can absorb crafting and progression ownership.
- Harsh scarcity can make exploration, crafting, and reward pacing feel punitive rather than immersive.
- Barter Limit Fix belongs in → Foundations (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the economy-framework answer.

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Weapons, Armor, And Equipment Content

Weapon packs, armor packs, artifacts, and clothing content have been consolidated into their own dedicated section. See → [Weapons & Armor](modlist-weapons-armor.md).

Followers & Reputation

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

All mods in this section belong to the Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](modlist-expanded-systems.md) section.

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Crime, Reputation, And Social Systems → separator: Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

How much the world should notice what the player does socially — reputation, crime tools, city suspicion, and guard behavior.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Skyrim Reputation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/22374)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Main reputation baseline.
[The Choice is Yours](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/3850)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Quest auto-start control for content-heavy runs.
[To Your Face SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/24720)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Social polish for city/tavern greetings.
[Steal off Scoundrels](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/171870)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	SKSE plugin — pickpocketing criminals not flagged as stealing. No ESP.
[Suspicious City Guards](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/38762)	Alternative	all	Urban tension around suspicious behavior.
[Book Of Shadows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/76086)	Alternative	all	High-expression crime and stealth pillar.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very light social-response layer can leave crime and reputation too close to vanilla.
- A stealth-heavy crime toolkit can make one playstyle dominate a subsection meant for broader roleplay.
- City suspicion systems can become annoying without enough payoff.
- Targeted fixes like Simple Offence Suppression belong in → Foundations (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the social-system answer.
- Keep stealth-expression tooling separate from broader world-reaction goals.

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Followers And Companion Systems → separator: Expanded Systems

- Followers & Reputation

How companion management should function at the systems level.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Nether's Follower Framework](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/55653)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Modern flexible route.
[EFF — Extensible Follower Framework] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/7003)	Alternative	all	Simpler established management.
[Amazing Follower Tweaks SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/6656)	Alternative	all	Heavy-management branch.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very light or dated framework can leave companions awkward to manage once the modlist grows.
- A heavy follower-control framework can make party management dominate ordinary play.
- Generic frameworks can conflict with custom companions better left outside them.
- This subsection owns party-management philosophy, not named companion selection (→ NPCs).

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Romance, Marriage, And Companionship → separator: Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

The SFW romance and marriage layer: expanded marriage mechanics, modern dialogue with spouses and romance interests, and opt-in quest-driven romance arcs. Baseline is fade-to-black, not explicit content. Custom named followers belong in → NPCs.

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Relationship Dialogue Overhaul – RDO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/1187)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	5,000+ voiced lines for NPCs/followers/spouses. 137K endorsements, fully SFW.
[Amorous Adventures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/7305) (clean variant)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Opt-in romance quests, fade-to-black. Lock only clean build.
[Marriage Mod – To Have And To Hold](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/8589)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Up to 11 spouses, divorce, enhanced wedding, dynamic events.
[Serana Dialogue Add-On](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/32161)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	7,000+ voiced lines, new story arcs, romance. 51K endorsements.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	all	Vanilla marriage mechanics.

Risks & Compatibility

- The wrong Amorous Adventures variant breaks the SFW rule. Download must be the clean build.
- Do not stack To Have And To Hold with another multi-spouse mod.
- Romance dialogue can conflict with custom-voiced follower mods from → NPCs that replace the same NPC’s voice.
- Romance quest mods add non-trivial content — review against → World Content to avoid doubling up on a single NPC’s quest line.
- Marriage events triggered by To Have And To Hold can fire during unintended moments; check MCM for event timing/cooldown settings.

World Progression Philosophy

> Adopted Combination: \#1 — Static with Hard Threat (see [Suggested Combinations](suggested-combinations)). The static-with-threat dial is the base; the “Living the World” pillar is layered on top — the home is a real anchor (survival warmth, food, rest, family), and the player quests when they want, not on the main quest’s clock.

This document owns the design dial that connects four concerns: leveling, encounter zones, loot distribution, and difficulty. They are not independent picks — change one and the other three shift. The modlist’s section files cite this document when they need to justify a concrete pick.

No concrete mod picks live here. The owning sections (notably → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) for loot distribution, → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) for

encounter zones and difficulty) make the final call. This document presents the three styles, analyzes them across shared axes, and ends with suggested combinations for different list identities — the curator picks the combination that matches the list’s intent.

Tagging convention: Mods in the section files are tagged in a Dial column with one or more combination codes (\#1, \#2, \#3, \#4, all, none). \#1 is the adopted combination for Elder Wilds; mods tagged \#1 (or all) are on-dial, others are off-dial for the list’s intent and need explicit justification.

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The Three Styles

Develed — World no longer scales to the player. A Bandit Chief is dangerous at level 1 and level 50; loot tables are decoupled from player level so a high-tier weapon can be found in a low-level dungeon. MorrowLoot Ultimate is the canonical implementation. Open World Loot (in its “decapitate leveled lists” mode) sits in this camp.

Static Leveling — World is fixed but the loot tables are hand-curated rather than the messy vanilla lists. Top-tier gear is rare, but it isn’t gated behind specific zones — it’s gated behind a curated drop table that the player learns over time. Open World Loot (default philosophy) is the closest popular implementation.

Vanilla With Curated Lists — Keep leveled lists essentially as Bethesda shipped them, but curate content additions (new weapons, armors, jewelry) to fit the existing economy rather than inflating it. The base game is the default; new items plug in cleanly. Trade and Barter style interventions, content packs that match vanilla tier-spread, light Rarity-style interference at the edges.

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The Interlocked Dial

The four concerns are coupled, and the dial really has six knobs — the four named plus the experience mod (how fast the player levels and what skill-ups do) and the perks overhaul (what perks do and how perk points are spent). All six need to sing together or the list feels incoherent:

- Leveling style (develed / static / vanilla) — what gear the world offers at what level.
- Encounter zones — what threat the world offers at what location.
- Loot distribution — what the player can actually pick up off that threat.
- Difficulty — how hard any given encounter feels.
- Experience mod — how fast the player accumulates levels and skill-ups relative to those four knobs.
- Perks overhaul — what the player can build into, which determines whether a given dial feels like a wall or a puzzle.

Common failure patterns when the six knobs don't sing:

- Develed loot + encounter-zone overhaul stacks gating. The world closes in fast; progression has to come from skill, knowledge, and LoTD-style meta-progression, not from better gear.
- Vanilla loot + no encounter overhaul produces the canonical problem: by level 30, glass and ebony are everywhere and nothing feels like a reward.
- Static loot + encounter-zone overhaul is the most common “modern list” dial — it gates the **threat** without gating the **gear**, so the player feels strong against a curated threat ladder.
- Develed loot + survival framework can overshoot into punitive early-game, especially in cold biomes where food and warmth are themselves scarce.
- Heavy perks overhaul + fast XP floods the player with build options before they've explored the world — the list feels like a build simulator rather than a world.
- Vanilla perks + slow XP + develed loot starves the player of both gear and build options; every fight is a coin-flip.
- Heavy perks overhaul + develed loot is actually a **natural** pairing: the player can build into a counter for any encounter the world throws at them, which softens delevel's flat-late-game problem and gives the perks tree real purpose.

A list that locks a strong position on one or two knobs without thinking through the other four will feel incoherent. This document is the place to think it through.

—

Deleveled

Power Fantasy

Late-game power fantasy is weaker: the world never feels “below you” because the world is the world. Early-game power fantasy is stronger in a punishing way: nothing hands you gear, you have to earn every step. For a list that wants the player to feel small and threatened, this is the right dial. For a list that wants the player to feel like they’re growing into a legend, it can feel like the dial never moves.

Longterm Play

Excellent for replayability — knowing where the best gear is, or where the hardest fights are, doesn’t trivialize the playthrough because the player level doesn’t unlock anything. A new character in six months has the same discovery space. Weak for in-list long-term progression — if the player plans to spend 200+ hours in a single character, the lack of a power curve can feel flat late.

Exploration & Discovery

Excellent incentive structure. “I should go everywhere, because anything I find could be a game-changer.” Pairs well with Legacy of the Dragonborn (museum-as-reward) and big-world lists. A high-tier weapon found at level 5 is a story, not a balance violation.

NPC & Encounter Balance

NPCs stay dangerous; the curve is flat. Pairs cleanly with encounter-zone overhauls that **add** a curve (so the world still has a sense of progression through the map even if the player’s gear doesn’t track). The risk is the over-gated trap: delevel + encounter overhaul + harsh survival + low early-game loot = the first ten levels feel like a wall. Survival & Combat already flags this combination as the “overshoot from moody into over-gated” pattern.

Modlist Synergy

The hardest style to balance with content-heavy modlists. Every new leveled-list mod (every new weapon, armor, jewelry, alchemy ingredient) has to be tested against the deleveled tables — does this new sword break the world at level 5? Does this new jewelry inflate the merchant economy? The more mods in the list, the more curation work. Lists that are content-rich (like this one, with Heavy Armory, Immersive Armors, Immersive Jewelry, Narrative Loot, C.O.I.N., etc.) pay a high cost for running deleveled.

Risks

- Punitive early-game, especially combined with survival frameworks.
- Content-mod curation overhead scales with modlist size.
- Late-game power-fantasy curve can feel flat.
- Easy to over-gate when combined with encounter-zone overhauls.

Experience & Perks

Pairs naturally with a heavy perks overhaul and slow-to-moderate XP. Without leveled lists to gate gear, the player’s power growth comes almost entirely from perks and skill-ups, so a rich perks tree carries real weight and a fast-XP setup would front-load that growth. A heavy-perks / slow-XP / deleveled-loot triple is the cleanest expression of the “earn every step” fantasy. Vanilla perks with fast XP undermines this — the player levels up faster than they can spend points and the world still doesn’t give them anything.

Static Leveling

Power Fantasy

Balanced. The player grows into a legend against a threat that also has structure. Late-game still feels earned because curated late-game loot is meaningfully better than curated early-game loot, but a high-level player isn't drowning in game-breaking gear. For a list that wants both the growth fantasy and the threat, this is the natural dial.

Longterm Play

Strong for in-list long-term progression — the player has a 100-hour power curve, and curated loot tables mean the curve is well-paced. Acceptable for replayability — a new character will find roughly the same gear at the same general progression points, but the discovery of **where** is still open. LoTD-style meta-progression carries replayability.

Exploration & Discovery

Incentive structure is moderate. “Go everywhere to find good gear” is still true, but the curve is shallower than de leveled because the player knows tier-1 zones won't drop tier-5 items. Pairs well with maps and markers, with the museum, and with curated content packs that respect the tier spread.

NPC & Encounter Balance

The cleanest combination with encounter-zone overhauls. Encounter zones add a **spatial** progression (Whiterun hold is easier than the Rift, the Rift is easier than Skrim wide); static loot adds a **temporal** progression (early-game player has starter gear, late-game player has curated late-tier gear). The two dials don't fight.

Modlist Synergy

The most content-mod-friendly style. New weapons, armors, jewelry, and ingredients slot into curated tier slots. A new weapon mod that adds ten glass-tier swords integrates naturally; the same mod in a de leveled list has to be tested for “does this break level-5 progression.” Lists that are content-rich benefit from static's lower curation overhead.

Risks

- The vanilla-curated-lists approach can feel like “vanilla with extra steps” if the curation isn't visibly better than Bethesda's default tables.
- Late-game still risks the glass/ebony-everywhere problem if the curator isn't careful with the tier-4 and tier-5 entries.
- Less distinctive than de leveled — the dial is “more polished” not “different feel.”

Experience & Perks

Pairs naturally with a heavy perks overhaul and a power-fantasy XP curve (high level cap, rewarding quest/discovery, no skill grinding). The player levels up faster than vanilla through quests and exploration while the static threat world keeps every level meaningful.

—

Vanilla With Curated Lists

Power Fantasy

Closest to Bethesda's intent. The player grows into a legend against a world that grows with them. Late-game the world hands you legendary glass and ebony because you earned it. For a list that wants to honor the original game and add modern systems on top, this is the right dial.

Longterm Play

Strong for in-list long-term progression (same as static). Weaker for replayability — a new character finds the same gear in the same places at the same levels. The strongest replayability lever is Legacy of the Dragonborn (different museum-fill order, different artifact quest chains, different pacing) rather than the loot dial itself.

Exploration & Discovery

Weakest incentive structure of the three styles. The player learns the loot ladder quickly and the motivation to “go everywhere” weakens. Lists that want exploration incentive need to add it through other levers: Legacy of the Dragonborn museum-fill, Evolving Locations content, hand-placed world encounters, Interesting NPCs style content, etc.

NPC & Encounter Balance

Pairs cleanly with the least intervention. Vanilla encounter zones + vanilla loot + light difficulty tuning produces a coherent, low-curation list. Adding heavy encounter-zone overhauls to vanilla loot often overshoots (the world gates but the gear doesn't, producing late-game “I'm level 50 in glass armor and a Bandit Chief one-shots me” frustration).

Modlist Synergy

The lowest curation overhead. New content packs that respect vanilla tier-spread integrate trivially. The cost is that the list feels like “vanilla plus mods” rather than “a designed list.”

Risks

- Late-game loot inflation is the canonical failure mode of this style.
- Exploration incentive is weak; other systems have to carry it.
- Distinctiveness depends entirely on what you put on top of vanilla (art, content, mechanics) — the loot dial alone doesn't sell a list.
- Easy to under-tune and end up with the unmodded game's pacing problems.

Experience & Perks

Pairs naturally with vanilla or light perks and a moderate-to-fast XP curve. The Bethesda-style growth fantasy works best when the player is unlocking perks at the rate Bethesda intended — fast enough to feel the build opening up, slow enough that the unlock matters. A heavy perks overhaul here can work, but the dial is doing less of the lifting, so the perks tree has to be the thing that makes the playthrough feel different. Slow XP with vanilla perks and vanilla loot produces a list that feels underpowered even at level 30 — the most common “is this modlist even on?” failure mode for this style.

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Suggested Combinations

These are suggestions for different list identities, not a ranking. The owning sections still pick the concrete mods; the combinations just steer those picks in compatible directions. The curator picks the combination that matches the list's intent.

1. “Big, Dark, Awe-Inspiring World” — Deleveled Or Static With Hard Threat

Suggested dial: Static leveling (preferred) or deleveled (committed), encounter-zone overhaul (Arena baseline or RiS Encounter Zones), harsher difficulty, deliberate loot scarcity at tier 1-2, heavy perks overhaul (Simonrim-class depth) with slow-to-moderate XP so the player's power growth comes from build choices against a flat world, not from gear inflation. Survival framework (cold, hunger, fatigue, disease) is on-dial — it makes the home a real anchor.

What it serves: Exploration that makes Skyrim feel vast and threatening. The player feels small, the world feels dangerous, gear feels earned, and the perks tree is the primary expression of “I'm getting stronger.” Pairs naturally with Legacy of the Dragonborn because the museum becomes the player's long-term reward ladder. The “Living the World” layer sits on top: a player home with a family, choosing when to quest, living a life in between the dragon-born moments.

Trade-offs: High curation overhead for content mods if deleveled. Risk of over-gating early-game if survival and encounter overhaul stack. Late-game power curve depends heavily on the perks tree carrying it; a shallow perks overhaul breaks the fantasy.

Owned by: → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) for the loot-distribution mod, → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) for encounter-zone and difficulty mods.

2. “Living The World / Museum-And-Collection” — Vanilla With Curated Lists

Suggested dial: Vanilla with curated lists, light or no encounter-zone intervention, balanced difficulty (Simply Balanced tier), LoTD-anchored progression carrying the long-term reward ladder, moderate perks overhaul (Path of the Berserker or Adamant tier) with vanilla-or-slightly-slow XP to preserve Bethesda's growth pacing while giving the build a little more shape.

What it serves: A list that wants to add modern systems and lots of new content on top of a Skyrim that still feels like Skyrim. The museum is the meta-progression; the loot dial is “vanilla with polish, not overhaul.” Honors Bethesda's pacing intent while modernizing everything around it.

Trade-offs: Late-game loot inflation is the canonical failure mode — mitigation is required curation of any new gear mods. Exploration incentive is weak; LoTD and content mods have to carry it. Distinctiveness depends on what you put on top. A heavy perks overhaul (Simonrim) here can overpower the “Skyrim that still feels like Skyrim” intent — the perks tree starts to feel like it's from a different game.

Owned by: → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) for trade-and-barter-style interventions and content-mod curation rules, → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) for minimal encounter-zone intervention and balanced difficulty.

3. “Power Fantasy” — Vanilla Or Static, Lenient

Suggested dial: Vanilla with curated lists (preferred) or static, no encounter-zone overhaul, lenient difficulty, vanilla or light perks with vanilla-to-fast XP so the growth fantasy matches Bethesda's intent. Late-game gear arrives as Bethesda intended; the player becomes a legend.

What it serves: A list that wants the player to feel like a growing hero, not a survivor. Pairs well with the “Dragonborn quest as the spine” playstyle — if the user is going to play the main quest, the loot dial should support that arc.

Trade-offs: Same late-game inflation risk as combination 2. Risk of feeling like an unmodded game in the first 20 levels. Exploration incentive is the weakest of the three styles; needs other systems to compensate. A heavy perks overhaul contradicts the “Bethesda’s growth pacing” intent and tends to overshoot into a build-simulator feel by mid-game.

Owned by: → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) for trade-and-barter and minimal loot intervention, → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) for the lenient difficulty pick and minimal encounter-zone changes.

4. “Longterm Replayability” — Static, Moderate Gating, Tunable Difficulty

Suggested dial: Static leveling, moderate encounter-zone intervention (Arena tier, not harsher), difficulty mod with tuning knobs (Simply Balanced, not Blade and Blunt), curated content packs that respect the tier spread, moderate-to-heavy perks overhaul (Path of the Berserker or Simonrim tier) with moderate XP so a new character has a fresh build-puzzle to work through every restart.

What it serves: A list the curator wants to come back to in six months and start fresh. Static gives the new character a fresh-but-familiar power curve; moderate encounter-zone intervention gives the world structure without punishing early exploration; a tunable difficulty mod lets the new character be tuned up or down as the player prefers; a moderate-to-heavy perks overhaul means each new character has a different build to commit to.

Trade-offs: Static-with-curated-lists is the most balanced but the least distinctive dial — the list has to differentiate through art, content, and mechanics. The “vanilla-with-extra-steps” risk is real.

Owned by: → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) for the static-with-curated-lists implementation (Open World Loot default or hand-rolled curated leveled lists), → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) for moderate encounter-zone changes and tunable difficulty.

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How To Use This Document

When a section file picks a mod that touches the loot / encounter / difficulty / XP / perks dial, it should briefly note which suggested combination the pick serves. Example: “Picking Open World Loot (curated default) supports combination 1 (Big, Dark, World) or 4 (Longterm Replayability) and is not the right pick for combination 3 (Power Fantasy / vanilla-loot).”

When two sections make picks that would push the list toward different combinations, the conflict is a signal to revisit this document and pick the combination explicitly. The document does not own the final answer — it owns the framework for making the answer coherent. The owning sections for the six knobs are: → [Crafting & Economy](modlist-expanded-crafting.md) (loot distribution), → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance](modlist-survival-combat.md) (encounter zones + difficulty), → [Magic & Perks](modlist-expanded-magic.md) (perks overhaul + XP mod), with → [Character & Progression](modlist-expanded-character.md) holding the cross-cutting growth philosophy.

Immersive Scale and World Feel

MO2 Separators: World Feel → World Feel - Timescale & Travel, World Feel - Soundscapes, World Feel - Nights & Wildlife, World Feel - Cities & Landmarks

All mods in this section belong to one of the four world-feel separators as noted per subsection.

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Timescale And Calendar Adjustments → separator: World Feel - Timescale & Travel

How quickly days pass, whether routine actions consume believable chunks of time, and season/calendar support.

Baseline

- Time Flies SE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/39426>)) — Grounded play loops without turning into abstract clock tuning.
- Seasonal Calendar ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/18164>)) — Narrow companion if weather-and-season direction makes calendar readability worthwhile.
- Seasons of Skyrim SKSE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/62861>)) + Turn of the Seasons ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63623>)) — High-commitment seasonal branch. Cost: 4× DynDOLOD passes, 4× grass caches, meaningful patch footprint. Only adopt if the project owns that LOD-generation workflow.

Alternatives

- Dynamic Timescale - Remade ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141531>)) — Environment-aware time shifts.
- [Extended Stay - Longer inn](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/156>) — Optional longer-stay inn mechanic. Adopt only if the project leans into “living the world.”
- [Sleep Tight SE](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/20680>) — NPC sleep schedule enforcement and sleepwear.
- [Sleep Tight - NPCs wear underwear](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/87132>) — NPC sleepwear variant without sleep schedule changes.

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Travel Pacing And Carriage Fast Travel Rules → separator: World Feel - Timescale & Travel

How much friction, structure, and world texture sits between major locations.

Baseline

- Carriage and Ferry Travel Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/8379>)) — Improves vanilla public-travel layer. Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility (predates AE).
- Carriage Drivers Are Alive ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51260>)) — Names, schedules, dialogue for carriage drivers.
- Carriages and Stables Dialogue Bundle ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79297>)) — Bribes, rumors, destination chat. Stacks cleanly with above.

Alternatives

- Carriage Stops of Skyrim ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/10434>)) — Broader route coverage.
- Fast Travel Cost ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/20200>)) — Economic pressure on map fast travel.
- Campfire ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/667>)) — Camping-and-rest companion. Already in the survival conversation.
- Journeyman - A Fast Travel Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/92220>)) — Restricts fast travel unless a Travel Pack is crafted/purchased. SKSE plugin + ESP. Fits “living the world” without forcing no-fast-travel.

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Encounter Spacing And Wilderness Feel → separator: World Feel - Nights & Wildlife

How busy, calm, or deliberately spaced wilderness travel feels between destinations.

Baseline

- Extended Encounters ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/44810>)) — Broad wilderness and road activity, lightweight.

Alternatives

- Radiance Encounters ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/19720>)) — World reactivity and consequences.
- Immersive Patrols SE AE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/718>)) — Faction-patrol route.

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Soundscape And Ambient Audio → separator: World Feel - Soundscapes

What roads, settlements, wilderness, and interiors sound like during ordinary exploration.

Baseline

- Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/8286>)) — Roads, wilderness, dungeons, settlements in one exploration-facing project.

Alternatives

- Acoustic Space Improvement Fixes ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78992>)) — Interior ambience and reverb treatment.
- Discipline-first — Keep current sound stack if playtesting shows world already sounds readable.

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City Size, Outskirts, And Population Feel → separator: World Feel - Cities & Landmarks

How large, inhabited, and spatially convincing cities feel during ordinary play.

Baseline

- Spaghetti's Cities - AIO ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/84735>)) — Denser, more inhabited without giant patch-management.

Alternatives

- Dawn of Skyrim (Director's Cut) ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/9074>)) — Stronger city-core expansion. Last updated June 2020.
- JK's Skyrim ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/6289>)) — Heavier all-in-one. Only if city transformation should become a loud identity pillar.

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Roadside Clutter, Ruins, And Landmark Density → separator: World Feel - Cities & Landmarks

Small-to-mid-scale worldspace texture between major destinations.

Baseline

- Ancient Land ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22900>)) — Static worldspace flavor and distant landmark presence.
- Point The Way ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/352>)) — Road guidance and signposting.
- Ryn's Standing Stones ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/64256>)) — Locked landmark baseline. Each stone becomes a unique environmental setpiece. World geometry only, no gameplay effects.

Alternatives

- Interesting Roads ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42749>)) — Lighter roadside variety. Asset-only, low compatibility risk.
- Giant Crab Shells - Mihail's Shards of Immersion ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/124681>)) — Coastal scenery. ESL-flagged.
- [Nordic Runestones](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/32019>) — Optional Nordic runestone world-object additions.
- [Place of Power](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6109>) — Optional standing-stone mesh/texture enhancement.
- [Whiterun Horse Statues](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51417>) — Cosmetic Whiterun landmark additions.
- [Solitude Statuary](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94526>) — Cosmetic Solitude landmark additions.
- [s6o6t LORE - Mundus Stones](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51191>) — Mundus standing-stone lore expansion.

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Wildlife And Creature Ecology → separator: World Feel - Nights & Wildlife

How varied and biologically alive wilderness travel feels.

Baseline

- Animallica SE - Skyrim Wildlife Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/20456>)) — More biologically varied during travel.
- Butterflies Land True ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/29434>)) — Insects land on surfaces. No scripts, ESL-flagged, 1 KB.

Alternatives

- One With Nature ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/13343>)) — Creature relationship tuning. Script-heavy — verify AE compatibility.
- Savage Skyrim ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37768>)) — Heavier danger-and-behavior.
- Frogs - Mihail ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/120998>)) — 4 frog variants. ESL-flagged.
- [Wearable Lanterns](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/7560>) — Optional wearable lantern mechanic for night exploration.

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Road Network And Surface Overhaul → separator: World Feel - Cities & Landmarks

Roads as built infrastructure at mesh/geometry level (separate from surface texture ownership in → Graphics).

Baseline

- Blended Roads - Light Plugin (ESL) ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/171554>)) — Locked baseline. Seamless road-to-terrain blending. No worldspace edits, no patch requirements.
- Interesting Roads ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/42749>)) — Roadside character (barrels, carts, signs). Asset-only.
- Point The Way ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/352>)) — Navigational signposting at junctions.

Risks & Compatibility

- Northern Roads was evaluated and rejected due to patch burden at this modlist's complexity level. Northern Roads - Clutters Only ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126175>)) is a lighter variant with only roadside clutter — re-evaluate if the full Northern Roads patch burden remains too high.

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Environmental Atmosphere: Wind And Dynamic Effects → separator: World Feel - Soundscapes

Weather-aware wind physics, dynamic cloth, and airborne particles for physical world-layer motion.

Mod	Notes
[Dynamic Wind Framework - SKSE Plugin](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/177023)	Infrastructure baseline.
[Dynamic Wind - Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/177024)	Required data companion with weather/location profiles.
[Particle Wind - SKSE Plugin](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174812)	Dust, leaves, snow, ash respond to wind direction.
[Realistic Boat Bobbing SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26080) + [BOS Edition](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/88885)	Boat bobbing with BOS mesh swap support.
[R.A.S.S. - Rain Ash And Snow Shaders](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/22745)	Visible rain droplets, snow accumulation, ash/frost shaders on player/NPCs. 33K+ endorsements.
[Animated Icebergs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/121420)	Drifting iceberg meshes in northern waters.
[Animated Ice Floes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/90634)	Animated ice floe meshes in cold regions.

OIF Ecosystem — Physics-Based Fire & Destruction Effects

Mod	Notes
[Dynamic Inn Fireplace - OIF](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155492)	Physics-enabled inn fireplace embers, smoke, and debris via OIF. Adds ambient fire life to interiors.
[No Fire During The Rain](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/161369)	Exterior campfires and braziers are extinguished during rain/storms. Requires OIF.

Risks & Compatibility

- R.A.S.S. + CS coexistence: CS Wetness Effects handles terrain/objects; R.A.S.S. handles actor surfaces. Should coexist without conflicts — verify in testing.
- OIF-based fire effects depend on the OIF framework being installed and stable in the core library stack.

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Night Darkness And Visibility Balance → separator: World Feel - Nights & Wildlife

Mod	Notes
Darkness baseline from the weather mod and CS pair selected in → Graphics	Base darkness level.
[Simply Darker Nights](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14269)	Simple image-space overlay. Verify it's not redundant before adding.
[Lanterns of Skyrim II](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/30817)	Road and settlement exterior lantern placement. FOMOD patch hub covers 30-50 patches.
[CS Lantern Lights - Lanterns of Skyrim II](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179964)	CS particle lights for LoS II. Install after LoS II.
[Simple Wearable Lanterns - Remastered](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/132196)	Preferred carried-visibility branch. Modern, lightweight, no SKSE.

Mod	Notes
[Torches Candlelight and Lanterns](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/162694)	Physics-equipped lanterns, NPC distribution. Requires BOS, MCM Helper.
[Realistic Usable Lanterns](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/110563)	Finite candles as consumable resource.
[Handheld Lanterns - HDT-SMP](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135973)	Physics-equipped with sway. Requires FSMP.
[Dynamic Torches NG - OIF](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155838)	Torch fire reacts to movement, collisions, and wind via OIF. Requires OIF framework.

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Activation Text → separator: World Feel - Timescale & Travel

Baseline

- Roleplaying In Skyrim - Immersive Activators ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/149908>)) — Descriptive activation text (e.g., “Read Book” instead of “Activate”), hides NPC names until interaction (toggleable). 8KB, no scripts, no SKSE.

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Open Research

Open research for the world-feel stack is tracked in `TOD0.md`.

World Content

MO2 Separators: World Content → World Content - Overhauls, World Content - Quests, World Content - Homes & Bases, World Content - Underwater

All mods in this section belong to one of the four world-content separators as noted per subsection.

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Landscape Overhauls → separator: World Content - Overhauls

Large worldspace-content changes making regions feel meaningfully different to cross.

Baseline

First experiment:

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Marshlands	Gives Hjaalmarch strong identity without redefining a central travel space.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/23062)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Whiterun Forest Borealis	Heavier compatibility pressure.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/11343)
Aspens Ablaze	Rift identity layer. Keep only if → Terrain & Flora can absorb it.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/39998)

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Cities, Towns, And Villages → separator: World Content - Overhauls

Authored settlement content — real places, not just denser vibes.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE	First-pass baseline giving multiple underbuilt settlements stronger structure.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/20272)
The Great Cities- Resources	Prerequisite resource mod for all The Great Cities series mods. Install first.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/104373)
Cities of the North - Dawnstar	Default modular lock for four smaller hold capitals. Designed to stack.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/28952)
Cities of the North - Morthal		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/34168)
Cities of the North - Falkreath		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/56731)
Cities of the North - Winterhold		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/40088)
Settlements Expanded	Makes seven underbuilt settlements feel inhabited (no city geometry changes). Must load late.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/7777)
The Great City of Solitude SSE	Port expansion with new homes, shops, warehouses, NPCs.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/22243)
JK's Whiterun Outskirts	Whiterun-area expansion. Independent of JK's Skyrim AIO; stack without patching.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78351)
JK's Raven Rock	Solstheim settlement. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141070)
JK's Tel Mithryn	Telvanni tower. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/151512)
FYX - Eastern Empire Company Building		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/86526)

FYX - Riften - Window Consistency		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/182707)
The City of Crossed Daggers - Riften Expansion	Riften market and canal expansion with new shops, NPCs, and quests.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/168629)
Grand Solitude - The Walls of High King Erling	Solitude wall and exterior expansion adding new areas and detail.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/157506)

Locked Faction-HQ Additions

Mod	Description	Nexus
JK's Fort Dawnguard	ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/110645)
JK's Castle Volkihar	ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116314)
JK's Dark Brotherhood Sanctuaries	ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121950)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Cities	Major-hold-capital follow-on. Treat as deliberate second-step.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/320)
Capital Whiterun Expansion	If JK's patch missing, mutually exclusive with JK's Whiterun edits.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37982)
Skyfall's Fortified Morthal	Morthal city overhaul. Overrides COTN Morthal – choose one.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126871)
The Great Town of Ivarstead SSE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34505)
The Great Village of Kynesgrove		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42639)
The Great Village of Mixwater Mill SSE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/36350)
The Great Town of Shor's Stone SSE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/35977)
The Great City Of Winterhold SSE Edition	Full Winterhold city overhaul. Incompatible with COTN Winterhold – choose one.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17127)

Riton Solitude	Solitude architecture overhaul. Likely conflicts with Grand Solitude — choose one.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/98390)
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College of Winterhold → separators: World Content - Overhauls / World Content - Quests

Coordinated three-mod sub-stack designed to work together without inter-mod patches.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus	Separator
Obscure's College of Winterhold	Architecture baseline. FOMOD with 50 built-in patches including LotD.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/20514)	World Content - Overhauls
Immersive College NPCs	ESL-flagged, vanilla assets, no cell edits. Integration patch in Obscure's FOMOD.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/9252)	World Content - Overhauls
College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion	Skill-gated entry, 7 starter lessons before Saarthal. ESL-flagged, by jayserpa.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/66666)	World Content - Quests
JK's College of Winterhold	Exterior and interior overhaul. Stack on Obscure's via combo patch below.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/65676)	World Content - Overhauls

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Magical College of Winterhold	Cleaner fantasy aesthetic but weaker grim-dark fit.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1539)
Immersive College of Winterhold	Architecture+NPCs+crafting. Unmaintained since Dec 2020.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17004)
College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion (alone)	Questline-only option — lowest patch overhead.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/66666)

Patch Support

Mod	Description	Nexus
JK's College of Winterhold (Immersive or Obscure) Combo Patches	Compatibility patch enabling JK's College to stack over Obscure's or Immersive College.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/67820)

Compatibility Notes

- Obscure's ↔ COTN Winterhold: Compatible without patch. Load COTN before OCW.

- Obscure's ↔ CS-native lighting: No official patch. Verify CellSettings.esp forwarding for CS Light + True Light bulbs. Install OCW Meshes Optimized and Merged for CS patch ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/139165>)).
 - Obscure's ↔ LOTD: Patch in OCW's own FOMOD. ESP-FE format.
 - ICN ↔ NPC appearance: Load ICN after broad NPC overhauls to avoid blackface.
 - Quest Expansion ↔ FDE Brelyna Maryon: Both touch her dialogue tree — test for overlap.
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Inns, Farms, And Small Settlements → separator: World Content - Overhauls

Travel-stop identity, small community presence, memorable rural pauses.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Village of Old Hroldan SSE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33189)
Candlehearth - An Inn Overhaul	Locked inn-overhaul baseline. Every inn in Skyrim.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/97542)
Ask Innkeepers To Show Room SE	Preview room before renting. 5,351 endorsements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/5990)
Inns Can Be Closed	Inns close at night, must knock for entry.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57407)

Alternatives

Mod	Nexus
Granite Hill	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14658)
Lund's Hamlet - An Overhaul	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/169830)
The Great Town of Karthwasten SSE	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33032)
Oakwood	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/61007)

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Dungeons And Ruins → separator: World Content - Overhauls

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Forgotten Dungeons (SSE)		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/449)
Dungeons - Revisited	Improves existing ruins rather than adding new destinations.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/51798)
Iconic's Crown of Barenziah	High-quality crown/gems/display stand.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/137469)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hammet's Dungeon Pack 1 SE	Curated hand-authored dungeons.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/12186)
Children of the North Wind	Bespoke Nordic architecture at 9 locations.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147701)
Skyrim Underground SSE	Larger subterranean layer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/131)
Icy Dungeons Pack	Icy retexture of nordic crypt dungeons. Visual-only, no record edits.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/136080)
[Ancient Falmer Ruins (Snow Elf Dungeons)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126428)	7+ Ancient Falmer dungeon/ruin locations — temples, cities, vaults across Skyrim. Hand-authored, lore-friendly.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126428)

Navmesh Support

Mod	Description	Nexus
Navigator - Navmesh Fixes - Patch Collection	FOMOD covering Dungeons Revisited, LotD, Helgen Reborn, JK's interiors, etc. Install after content mods and Navigator are in place.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111379)

Dungeon Visual Overhauls

Visual-only overhauls for specific dungeons. No record or navmesh edits, but confirm compatibility on a per-dungeon basis if world-content mods touch the same cell.

Mod	Nexus
[Bleak Falls Tower](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/83466)	[Northern Scenery - Bleak Falls Barrow](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94647)
[Northern Scenery - Ansilvund](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94720)	[Northern Scenery - Angarvunde](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94650)
[Northern Scenery - IronBind Barrow](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/95788)	[Bleak Falls Barrow Overhaul Version 2](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131057)

Note: Bleak Falls Tower and Bleak Falls Barrow Overhaul touch the same location (Bleak Falls Barrow). They are likely incompatible — pick one. Northern Scenery series covers separate dungeons and can be installed together.

Mod	Nexus
[Immersive Dungeon's Fire](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/162277)	Enhanced fire VFX and ambient fire behavior in dungeons. Requires OIF. Tentative — evaluate visual and gameplay impact.

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Points Of Interest And Roadside Content → separator: World Content - Overhauls

Smaller discoverable places between headline destinations.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hidden Hideouts of Skyrim SE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2625)
Daedric Shrines - All in One		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78772)
Daedric Shrines - Patch Collection		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78809)
Environs - Abandoned Abodes	ESL-flagged, zero script overhead.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/82410)
Evolving Locations - Riverside Shack		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/124268)
Evolving Locations - Lucky Shack		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/123700)
Evolving Locations - Cliffside Retreat		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/124524)
Reinforced Civil War Camps		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/153645)
Hagraven Houses Animated	BOS mesh replacer.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/101952)
Ivarstead Source	Landscape fix. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118825)
Animated Ships		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/110260)
Finer Sails		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/112517)
Dynamic Boats at Docks - Official Patch Hub		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172901)

Snowy Ships for Snowy Regions	BOS-based.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111827)
Unmarked Locations Pack - All In One	1. addon packs for Bruma, Wyrnstooth, Gray Cowl if those worldspaces are adopted.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/113660)
Ascend - Hidden Peaks of Skyrim	Climbing challenge locations across Skyrim. Complements parkour movement.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/120802)
Graveyards of the Marshlands	Atmospheric graveyard locations in Hjaalmarch. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/132767)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hold Border Guards - Definitive Edition		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/61170)
Hold Border Banners	Visual hold-border signposts and banners. Mesh-only, no ESP.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1737)
Immersive Hold Borders SSE Fixed	Hold-border checkpoint improvements with structures and guards.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/47918)
Nordic Ruins of Skyrim SSE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/20382)
Hidden Hideouts City Edition SE		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2626)
7000 Steps of Sanctum		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/128478)
Gildergreen Regrown		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/348)
The Gildergreen Grows	Incompatible with Regrown.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147742)
HAG Occult Orphan Rock		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/137996)
Lore Friendly Roadside Ruins		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/130581)

HAG - Occult Witchmist Grove	Witch-themed point of interest. Same series as HAG Occult Orphan Rock.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/143685)
HAG - Occult Cradle Stone Tower	Occult tower point of interest. Same series.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/148542)
Haunted Shipwrecks	Haunted shipwreck encounter locations. BOS-based, no cell edits.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/142986)

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Underwater → separator: World Content - Underwater

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Depths of Skyrim - An Underwater Overhaul SSE	New grass, coral, kelp, 1000+ fish, unmarked treasures.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26913)
Depths of Skyrim - Mesh fixes		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174995)
More Underwater Treasures - AIO	56 treasures (Skyrim) + 35 (Solstheim). Marked compatible with Depths of Skyrim.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/128247)

Setup Requirements

- Use SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm for LOD generation (→ Performance).
- Requires iMaxGrassTypesPerTexture=7 in Skyrim.ini.
- Depths is script-free but adds 1000+ fish references — verify no unexpected Papyrus load.

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Side Activities: Fishing, Hunting, And Downtime → separator: World Content - Quests

Non-combat downtime making Skyrim feel lived-in when the player isn't dungeon-delving.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simple Fishing Overhaul	200+ lines improved dialogue, NPC reactions, MCM. ESL-flagged, by jayserpa.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/103440)
Hunterborn SE	Dressing, skinning, harvesting, butchering. 20K endorsements. Use Hunterborn Extender via Synthesis.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/7900)
Headhunter - Bounties Redone	Locked. Transforms vanilla bounties. By jayserpa, 28K+ endorsements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/119228)
Skyrim's Got Talent	Locked. Instrument practice, skill progression, inn performances. By jayserpa.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/106106)
SGT - Player Reactions Addon		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/78629)
SGT - Show in UI		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135473)
SGT - Visual Improvements		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/172079)
Immersive Fishing	New spots, rods, fish types, radiant quests.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115249)
Fishermen Fish	No ESP, mesh replacer only.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134408)
Garbage Loot - Barrels and Sacks	ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/18047)
Brawling - No Hitting Bystanders		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116941)
Skyshards - Tweaks and ESLeD	Collectible shard system tweaks and ESL conversion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115820)

Skyshards and Immersive interactions FLM	First/Last mod patch for Skyshards + Immersive Interactions.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/68072)
The Dragonborn's Bestiary - Lively's Alchemy Addon	Alchemy recipe data addon for the Bestiary book.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/135010)
The Dragonborn's Fishiary - Bestiary Addon	Fishing data addon for the Fishiary book.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134739)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simple Hunting Overhaul	Simpler alternative by jayserpa. If chosen, replaces Hunterborn. Requires Dynamic Activation Key.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/95943)
Dynamic Activation Key	Required by SHO.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/96273)
Immersive Hunting Animations	SHO companion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/96961)
Immersive Carcass Carrying	SHO companion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/99867)
Hunters Loot	SHO companion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/119348)
Streamlined Fishing		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80683)
Become a Bard / Bards Reborn	Not compatible with SGT without patch.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/47994)
Fishing Extension Framework	Required for new-lands fishing.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139626)

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Weapons, Armor And Equipment Additions

Weapons, armor, artifacts, and clothing content has been consolidated into its own dedicated section. See → [Weapons & Armor](modlist-weapons-armor.md).

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Quest Additions → separator: World Content - Quests

Everyday & Radiant

Mod	Description	Nexus
Sidequests of Skyrim		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/54245)
Missives	Dual everyday-quest baseline with Sidequests.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/17576)
Missives - Voice and Quest Expansion	20 new types, voiced.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/166094)
Missives - Notes Retexture		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/46201)
Missives - Notes Retexture Darkened		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111765)
Diverse Witcher Missives Boards	BOS-based.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111770)
Missives - Unique Missive Boards		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/111375)
Missives Quest Conversion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135984)
Missives - Worldspace Additions	Required for new-lands.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26788)

Faction Expansions

Mod	Description	Nexus
A Chance Arrangement Plus Plus	Thieves Guild quest overhaul.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/175885)
Opulent Thieves Guild	Visual-progression companion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/10932)
Improved Companions - Questline Tweaks	Removes forced radiant-quest spam between Companions missions.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/120609)

The Companions Extended Collection	Patches for several Companions mods. Integrates quest/dialogue/visual overhauls.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/95001)
Penitus Oculatus	Locked. “Destroy the Dark Brotherhood!” replacement faction with radiant quests. 11.5K endorsements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/21061)
The Brotherhood of Old - Dark Brotherhood Continued	Post-DB-questline continuation with new sanctuary, quests, and radiant content. Complements Penitus Oculatus alternative route.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/15322)

Optional alternative: Destroy The Dark Brotherhood - Quest Expansion ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118229>)) – jayserpa’s quest-expansion approach to destroying the DB.
Incompatible with Penitus Oculatus – choose one.

Quest Pacing

Mod	Description	Nexus
At Your Own Pace	Quest pacing mod – delays main quest, faction quests, and College entry via optional skill-gating and trigger delays. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/52704)

Civil War Content

Mod	Description	Nexus
[Open Civil War SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/11076)	Expands civil war into a dynamic campaign with multiple front-lines, siege battles, and faction maneuvering. High-commitment – significant world interaction and patch footprint.	[Serious Civil War Defense for OCW](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/81557)
Adds settlement defense scenarios triggered by OCW campaign events. Requires Open Civil War.	[After the Civil War - Siege Damage Repairs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/20668)	Post-war world repair: damaged cities and fortifications are restored over time. Complements OCW.

Alternatives: Civil War Lines Expansion ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/77566>)) – jayserpa’s dialogue expansion for civil war soldiers. Also listed in → [NPCs](modlist-npcs.md) (Dialogue Expansions). Check for overlap with the NPCs entry.

Quest Expansions (Vanilla+)

Mod	Description	Nexus
House of Horrors Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/57285)

Paarthurnax Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51711)
The Only Cure Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/57683)
The Whispering Door Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/76606)
Quest Expansions Patches Hub		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113083)
Saints and Seducers Extended Cut	Transforms thin vanilla Creation into proper Shivering Isles return.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/72772)
Infiltration - Quest Expansion	Thieves Guild / Skyrim quest expansion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/114054)
Caught Red Handed - Quest Expansion	Riften jail quest expansion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/65708)
The Heart of Dibella - Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94863)
Innocence Lost - Quest Expansion		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80974)
The Taste of Death - Quest Addon	Namira quest expansion.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123173)
More to do in the Soul Cairn	Soul Cairn quest and content addon.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115962)
Boethiah's Calling - Alternate Questline	Boethiah daedric quest alternative.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121499)
Mephala's Curse - Whispering Door Addon	Whispering Door quest addon. Separable from the Quest Expansion — evaluate for overlap.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/120650)

Alternative: Boethiah for Good Guys ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/329>)) — older alternative that allows completing Boethiah's Calling without sacrificing a follower. Incompatible with Boethiah's Calling - Alternate Questline — choose one. | Dungeon Quests are not Miscellaneous | Converts 7 misc dungeon quests to full side quests with journal entries. | [Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123559>) |

Standalone Adventures

Mod	Description	Nexus
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The Forgotten City	Locked. Most decorated Skyrim quest mod. Self-contained murder-mystery, LoTD integration.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1179)
Mysteries of the Dwemer	Dwemer-theme quest mod.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114863)
[Frozen in Time - Definitely Not Another Snow Elf Waifu Mod] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/39732)	Quest to reanimate an ancient Snow Elf warrior. 2-part quest, 2 dungeons, custom assets, portable player home. 2,833 endorsements.	AI-voiced (ElevenLabs). Vanilla/UUNP/CBBE body options. No AFT during quest.

Alternatives

New Lands

Mod	Nexus
Wormstooth	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/45565)
Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/10917)
Beyond Reach	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/3008)
Falskaar	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/2057)
The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal - 10th Anniversary	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/141327)
[The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal - Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/125416)	Gameplay tweaks for Gray Cowl of Nocturnal. Install alongside the base mod.
The Isle Of Valfrost SE	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecial edition/mods/103215)

New Lands (High-Commitment)

Mod	Description	Nexus
[Land of Vominheim SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/31472)	Expansive new worldspace — Valenwood-themed region, quests, dungeons, followers. High patch and compatibility debt. Evaluate against existing new-lands commitments.	[Snowpoint](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/146533)
New snow-covered worldspace with quest content. Lighter footprint than Vominheim.		

Vicn Trilogy (GLEN-MORIL + Unslaad + VIGILANT)

The Vicn trilogy covers three connected quest mods. VIGILANT is already in the alternatives list above; GLEN-MORIL and Unslaad complete the set.

Mod	Nexus
[GLEN-MORIL - English Translation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/33146)	[GLEN-MORIL - ElvenLabs Voiced](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/156978)
[GLEN-MORIL - Delayed Start](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/57963)	[Unslaad SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/11789)
[UNSLAAD - ElevenLabs Voiced](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/155073)	[VIGILANT SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/11849)
[VIGILANT - English Translation (Plus Voiced Addon)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/11894)	[VIGILANT (missing lines) - ElevenLabs Voiced](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/161442)
[VIGILANT - GLENMORIL - UNSLAAD - Book Covers](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/32940)	[Animated Armoury Unslaad Patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/89322)

All three have LoTD integration (→ [Legacy of the Dragonborn](modlist-lotd.md)). Voiced addons replace subtitle-only dialogue. Delayed Start postpones GLEN-MORIL's initiation until the player reaches a minimum level. The VIGILANT voiced addon covers all missing lines for v1.8.0 and requires the English Translation.

Standalone Quest Mods

Mod	Description	Nexus
Moon and Star		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/4301)
The Wheels of Lull		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/748)
Whispers of the Depths		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/127087)
Before the End		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/142238)
Val Serano - Pirate Custom Voiced Follower and Quest Adventure		
The Frozen Heart		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/159911)
Midnight Sun		[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/163295)
Echoes of Oblivion	AI-Generated Content.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/153979)

Lightweight Additions

Mod	Description	Nexus
Leaps of Faith	Lightweight pilgrimage. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/53074)

Rescue Missions	Radiant rescue. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/144251)
Sleepwalking Into A Nightmare - New Daedric Prince Quest	New Daedric quest mod. Evaluate for LoTD integration.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141047)
SIRENROOT - Deluge of Deceit	Quest adventure with new dungeon, voice acting. LoTD patch status: needs verification.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/70917)
Legends of Aetherium - New Dungeon - Quest - Armour - Weapons	Quest mod expanding the Aetherium storyline.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/69807)
Restoring the Aretino Residence SE	Short quest adding Aretino family home restoration. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/30447)
Better Skyrim Parties - Weddings - Funerals - Crowd Events Overhaul	Overhauls crowd events and ceremonies. Lightweight, ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/102594)
SpiderWIP	Morthal-themed quest mod. Evaluate for coverage overlap.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/84053)
Better Courier	Courier improvements – better delivery dialogue and behavior.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/40709)
Quests Are In Skyrim	Restricts radiant quest destinations to Skyrim province only. ESL-flagged.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/18416)
Andrealletius' Harder Quests	Higher requirements for quest objectives – thaneships, nirnroot, solstheim quests, etc.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/27939)
Finding Derkeethus	Quest expansion to find and rescue the Argonian follower.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/19550)
Finding Derkeethus Duplicate FormID Fix	Fix for duplicate FormID conflict.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/46391)
Jiub's Opus	Quest to find Jiub's journal pages across Solstheim.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/17056)
Informed Mail Delivery	Quest-aware mail delivery with timed courier dispatches.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/66339)
[The Surviving Falmer - An Alternate Start](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/131974)	Alternate start addon for Snow Elf player characters + small player home. Supports LAL and Alternate Perspective.	Requires a Snow Elf race mod (The Ancient Falmer, Lost Races of Nirn, or similar).

NPCs

MO2 Separators: NPCs → NPCs - Appearance, NPCs - Population, NPCs - Followers

All mods in this section belong to one of the three NPC separators as noted per subsection.

> Creature/enemy content moved to → [Enemies & Creatures](modlist-creatures.md).

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NPC Appearance Overhauls → separator: NPCs - Appearance

Face, hair, and presentation direction for Skyrim's named NPCs. Does not re-decide the body/skin/baseline character-visual stack already owned by → Characters & Creatures.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Northbourne NPCs of Whiterun Hold] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/35404)	Baseline	Modern, regionally textured look. Grounded route.
[Northbourne NPCs of Winterhold](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/43413)	Baseline	Same author/series. Regionally textured look for Winterhold.
[The Men of Winter SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/10902)	Baseline	Dedicated male coverage. Last updated Aug 2020 – verify 1.6.1170.
[Children of the First — Altmer NPC Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/122167)	Baseline	Race-specific modular overlay for Altmer.
[Children of the Ash — Dunmer NPC Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/122165)	Baseline	Race-specific modular overlay for Dunmer.
[High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/74226)	Alternative	Vanilla-faithful fallback. Broad NPC coverage.
[Pandorable's NPCs (AIO)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/78524)	Alternative	Beauty-forward branch. Broad female coverage.
[DiBella's Blessing](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/82606)	Alternative	233 female characters.
[Males Of Skyrim by zzjay](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/37485)	Alternative	Broad male coverage.
[The Woven Widow — SerketHetyt's Elisif Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/62209)	Alternative	Single-NPC overhaul (Elisif).
[Val Serano - Another Replacer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/168735)	Alternative	Single-NPC replacer for Val Serano (Pirate Quest Follower).
[Pride of Skyrim — AIO Male HPH Overhaul] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/48904)	Alternative	400 male NPCs with High Poly Head. Broad coverage.
[BeastHHBB](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/38480)	Alternative	Khajiit and Argonian NPC/PC replacer — player character, NPCs, adoptable children, Interesting NPCs integration, fangs.
[Bijin Wives SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/11247)	Alternative	Female NPC replacer for wives and selected NPCs.

Overwrite Order

Stack broad-coverage mods first, then region/race-specific, then single-NPC overhauls last. The later mod wins for any NPC it covers.

1. Broad base layer — Choose one male and one female branch: High Poly True to Vanilla, Pandorable's, DIBella's Blessing, Males of Skyrim, or Pride of Skyrim.
2. Region or gender-specific — Northbourne NPCs of Whiterun Hold (Whiterun only), The Men of Winter SSE (males broadly). Override specific holds or gender groups on top of the base layer.
3. Race-specific overlays — Children of the First (Altmer), Children of the Ash (Dunmer) — load after general overhauls so race-specific facegen wins for their target NPCs.
4. Single-NPC finishers — The Wolven Widow (Elisif) — load last so named individuals use the intended facegen.

After the appearance stack is final, run FacegenBaseline via Synthesis (→ [Patcher Reference] (facegenbaseline-npc-stat-patcher-reference)).

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NPC AI & Behavior → separator: NPCs - Population

NPC schedule, behavior, and AI overhauls that affect how NPCs act rather than how they look.

Mod	Type	Notes
[AI Overhaul SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/21654)	Baseline	NPC schedule and behavior overhaul. Pairs with any appearance route.

Risks & Compatibility

- AI Overhaul SSE is compatible with all listed appearance overhauls. Load AI Overhaul after appearance mods so schedule records win.
- Quest mods that move NPC schedules may need AI Overhaul patches — check the mod page for supported mods.
- Do not install Immersive Citizens – AI Overhaul SE alongside AI Overhaul SSE (→ [Population] (civilian-and-traveler-population-additions)).

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Civilian And Traveler Population Additions → separator: NPCs - Population

Extra background people making towns, inns, and roads feel used — without re-deciding city feel and roadside atmosphere.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Crowded Streets](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/127723)	Baseline	Compatibility-first crowd: zero cell edits, dynamic cleanup, configurable density.
[Travellers of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1973)	Alternative	Road-traveler route. LE-era port — verify 1.6.1170.
[Populated Skyrim Reborn SSE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/32190)	Alternative	Heavier legacy route.
[MINPCs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/29483)	Alternative	Adventurer-style incidental content.
[Immersive Citizens — AI Overhaul SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/173)	Alternative	Known conflict with AI Overhaul SSE.
[Interesting NPCs SE (3DNPC)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/29194)	Alternative	Authored content NPCs.

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NPC Name Variety → separator: NPCs - Population

Making named NPCs feel more regionally distinct without changing appearance or dialogue.

Mod	Coverage	Notes
[NPCs Names Distributor](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/73081)	Framework	Distributes name variations by race, faction, location.
[Tamrielic Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/73153)	Human NPCs	Nord, Imperial, Redguard, Breton.
[Reachmen Tribes Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/73312)	Forsworn / Reach	
[Ashlander Nomads Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/73315)	Dunmer / Solstheim	
[Dovah Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/74053)	Dragons	
[Daedric Names](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/74055)	Daedra	
[Player Name Randomizer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/92438)	Player	Randomizes display name on new game.

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NPC Dialogue Expansions → separator: NPCs - Population

Targeted dialogue additions for existing NPCs — expanding what vanilla characters say via spliced vanilla voice assets.

Mod	Description	Notes
[Dialogue Expansion — Windhelm](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/112415)	180+ lines for citizens/guards/court	Discontinued — installed copies work, no future updates.
[Dialogue Expansion — Imperial Soldiers](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113208)	Imperial soldier dialogue	Discontinued — same status.
[Bandit Lines Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/87961)	Spliced vanilla bandit assets	
[Extended Bandit Dialogue](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/113168)	Additional bandit lines	
[Falmer Servant Lines Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/120995)	483 lines, pro voice talent	ESL-flagged. Optional plugins: More Spawns, More Unique Servants.
[Civil War Lines Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139920)	Civil war faction dialogue	
[Forsworn and Thalmor Lines Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/130880)	Forsworn / Thalmor dialogue	
[Guard Dialogue Overhaul SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/22075)	600+ lines for guards reacting to player deeds/gear	26.2K endorsements. Older mod — verify 1.6.1170.
[Shouts of Stallholders](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139025)	AI-Generated Content	Evaluate voice quality.
[Naked Comments Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142249)	NPC comments on player nudity.	Alternative
[Collision Dialogue Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/115079)	Dialogue triggered by NPC collision events.	Alternative
[Chattier Hunters and Fishermen](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/179154)	Expanded ambient dialogue for hunters and fishermen.	Alternative

Follower Dialogue Expansion (FDE) series by Anbeegod

> AI-voiced, each ESL-flagged. Core entries listed below; the [official FDE collection](<https://next.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/collections/uu3kpb>) includes 26 mods total.

Follower	Lines	Notes
[FDE — Aela the Huntress](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/114801)	2700+	Romance arc, werewolf mechanics.
[FDE — Brelyna Maryon](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/113359)	400+	
[FDE — Lydia](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/119226)	400+	
[FDE — Roggi Knot-Beard](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/134694)		
[FDE — Aranea Ienith](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/141907)	495	
[FDE — Borgakh the Steel Heart](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/133571)	478	
[FDE — Uthgerd the Unbroken](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/122487)	233	
[FDE — Ysolda](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/124787)	180	
[FDE — Jenassa](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/120255)	500+	
[FDE — Olfin Gray-Mane](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/172562)	578	
[FDE — Mjoll the Lioness](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/116025)	451	Quest and location awareness.
[FDE — Faralda](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/155510)	441	Self-contained follower, personal quest. Verify overlap with College Quest Expansion.
[FDE — Eola](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/157012)	233	Namira cultist dialogue.

Mod	Description	Notes
[Extended NPC Dialogue Hub](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/179341)	Central dialogue framework	
[Small Talk](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/168228)	NPC-to-NPC ambient dialogue	SKSE plugin, no ESP.

[Companions Dialogue Bundle] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/93592)	Expanded Companion faction dialogue bundle.	Alternative
[Snow Elf Dialogue](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155222)	Race-aware dialogue for Snow Elf PCs across quests — Helgen, TG, DB, Dawnguard.	AI-voiced (ElevenLabs). Supports The Ancient Falmer, Lost Races of Nirn, True Snow Elf Race. Requires SKSE, Address Library, KID.
[Custom Race Dialogue](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/169521)	Consolidated race-dialogue mod combining Snow Elf, Dwemer, Ayleid, Maormer, Tsaesci.	Same author as Snow Elf Dialogue. Incompatible with Race Compatibility Dialogue SSE.

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Custom Followers → separator: NPCs - Followers

Custom fully-voiced follower additions with authored dialogue, quest commentary, and personal content. The follower framework decision (NFF vs EFF vs AFT) is owned by → [Followers & Reputation](modlist-expanded-followers.md).

Follower	Lines	Notes	Dependencies / Extras
[Lucien — Immersive Fully Voiced Male Follower](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/20035)	5000+	Personal quest, LoTD-aware. 30K+ endorsements.	See framework notes.
[Remiel — Custom Voiced Dwemer Specialist](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/51874)	5000	Custom framework — do not assign via NFF/AFT.	Banter with Inigo, Auri, Kaidan 2.
[INIGO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/1461)	7000+	100K+ endorsements.	[Inigo Official Patch SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/62868) required for 1.6.1170. Visual replacer: [Lulu's INIGO 2.0](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126199).
[Khajiit Will Follow](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/2227)		4 Khajiit followers. 8K endorsements.	See framework notes.
[Song of the Green (Auri Follower)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/11278)	1000+	Romance option, Inigo banter. Custom framework — do not assign via NFF/AFT 2.0+.	Visual replacer: [Majestic Auri] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/72361).
[Sofia — The Funny Fully Voiced Follower](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/2180)		Comic relief. May be cut for tonal mismatch.	See framework notes.
[Kaidan 2](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/19075)	1200+	Romance arc. Custom AI — do not assign via NFF/AFT.	Use [Immersive Features AIO] (https://kaidanmod.com) (Nexus Extended Edition deprecated). Extras: [A Makeover for Kaidan](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/100586), [Immersive Kaidan Start] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/64064).

Framework Notes

NFF compatibility per follower:

Follower	NFF-Safe?	Notes
Lucien	Yes	Tested with NFF, also works standalone.
Remiel	No	Custom system — banter with Inigo, Auri, Kaidan 2.
INIGO	Yes	Use Official Patch for 1.6.1170.
Khajiit Will Follow	Yes	Designed for NFF.
Auri	No	Custom system — has Inigo banter.
Sofia	Yes	Works under NFF or standalone.
Kaidan 2	No	Custom AI — use built-in track/summon powers.

- Verify cross-follower banter: Remiel + Auri have Inigo patches; Kaidan 2 has extended banter with Remiel.
- Backported Extended ESL Support listed for Majestic Auri does not apply to AE 1.6.1170 — do not install.

Additional Mods

- [Keep Up — Follower Locomotion Fix](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/169808>) — Alternative. Prevents followers from getting stuck behind the player. Evaluate after the follower framework baseline is locked.

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Playable Race Additions → separator: NPCs - Appearance

Playable race mods enabling new character options at game start. Snow Elf (Ancient Falmer) race mods are the primary focus — adding the option to play as the last surviving Snow Elf in Skyrim.

Race Framework

Mod	Notes
[RaceCompatibility for Skyrim Special Edition](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/26869)	Required by several custom race mods.
[Race Compatibility SKSE (RCS)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/122592)	Modern replacement for RaceCompatibility — no ESP/ESM file. Required by Lost Races of Nirn. Do not use alongside RaceCompatibility (ESP).

Snow Elf Race Options

Mod	Type	Notes
[The Ancient Falmer - A Snow Elf Race SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16854)	Baseline	Most comprehensive snow elf race mod. Adds Snow Elf race, Gelebor/Vyrthur overhaul, optional followers (Valrysa, Ashian), craftable Ancient Falmer weapons. 2,752 endorsements. Requires RaceCompatibility. Last updated Oct 2023.
[Lost Races of Nirn](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69467)	Alternative	Modular race pack: Ayleid, Dwemer, Maormer, Snow Elf, Tsaesci. Separate plugins per race via FOMOD. Requires RCS (no-ESP framework). HPH Addon available ([mod 147619](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/147619)).
[True Snow Elf Race](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/7880)	Alternative	Vanilla-faithful standalone Snow Elf race. Last updated 2018. Does not require RaceCompatibility — standalone BSA.

Recommended Companions

Mod	For	Notes
[Frosty Snow Elf Skin Renewal](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16854?tab=files)	The Ancient Falmer	Hyperborean BnP skin for Ancient Falmer. Download from the Ancient Falmer Patch Center. Core mod per Ancient Falmer requirements.
[High Poly Head For Custom Races](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/43098)	The Ancient Falmer	Patches High Poly Head to work with 30+ custom races including The Ancient Falmer. 2,306 endorsements. Requires High Poly Head (off-site, vectorplexis) and RaceMenu.

[Lost Races of Nirn - High Poly Head Addon](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/147619)	Lost Races of Nirn	HPH patches for Lost Races of Nirn 3.0+. ESP-FE. Includes Dwemer, Maormer, Snow Elf, Tsaesci.
[Lost Races of Nirn - Female Skin Textures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/90443)	Lost Races of Nirn	High-quality female textures based on Reverie Skin. UNP/CBBE, 4K-2K, ESP-FE. Fixes neck-seam issues with custom body textures.

Risks & Compatibility

- Ancient Falmer vs Lost Races of Nirn: These are competing race frameworks. The Ancient Falmer is more comprehensive (followers, spells, leveled-list weapons) but has a larger patch footprint (RaceCompatibility, Patch Center). Lost Races of Nirn is modular, uses the lighter RCS framework, and has better HPH support. Evaluate which to adopt as baseline — running both is risky.
- RaceCompatibility vs RCS: Do not use both simultaneously. RaceCompatibility (ESP/ESM) is required by The Ancient Falmer. RCS (no ESP) is required by Lost Races of Nirn. This is a hard fork — pick one race framework.
- Race-aware dialogue: Both race mods support [Snow Elf Dialogue](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/155222>) — see NPC Dialogue Expansions section.
- Alternate start synergy: The Surviving Falmer ([mod 131974](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/131974>)) and alternate-start frameworks (LAL, Alternate Perspective) provide Snow Elf-specific starting scenarios.
- Third-person/gamepad: Race mods are character-creation content — no third-person impact beyond face/body visuals at character gen.
- Perk/Combat overhauls: The Ancient Falmer adds custom sunfire spells and racial abilities. Verify compatibility with the chosen perk overhaul (Simonrim or other) in → Magic & Perks.
- BodySlide: Followers from The Ancient Falmer (Valrysa, Ashian) require BodySlide builds for the chosen body mod (CBBE/3BA). Factor into → Performance BodySlide rebuild cycles.

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FacegenBaseline & NPC Stat Patcher Reference

These Synthesis patchers resolve facegen and stat issues introduced by NPC appearance and behavior overhauls. Both run as part of the Synthesis pipeline documented in → [Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration](modlist-performance-patches.md).

FacegenBaseline

What it does: Generates missing or corrected facegen data (face morphology .nif files and tint layers .dds) for NPCs added or changed by appearance mods. Without it, NPCs can display the black-face bug (dark head on light body), mismatched facial features, or incorrect tint layers.

When to run:

- After every change to the NPC appearance stack — adding, removing, or reordering appearance overhauls
- After installing any mod that adds new NPCs (quest mods, world content, new lands)
- After running any Synthesis patcher that changes NPC head parts or face morphs
- Every time the load order of NPC-related plugins changes

How to set up in Synthesis:

1. Add the FacegenBaseline patcher to your Synthesis pipeline (Stage 1 in → [performance-patches.md](modlist-performance-patches.mdstage-1-npc-ai-and-facegen)).
2. Configure the Source Mods list — select every NPC appearance overhaul and any mod that adds NPCs with custom facegen. The patcher reads facegen from these source mods and copies it into the output.
3. Set Output Mod to a dedicated mod folder (e.g., FacegenBaseline Output in the Output MO2 separator).
4. Run Synthesis with the full pipeline — FacegenBaseline runs after KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer and HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART.

Configuration options:

Option	Recommendation	Notes
Source Mods	Select all NPC appearance overhauls + any mod listed in this file that ships facegen	Missed source mods are the \1 cause of black-face
Output Mod	Dedicated mod in Output separator	Do not output into an existing NPC overhaul mod
Overwrite Mode	Replace (default)	Keeps output clean on each rebuild
Include Tint Layers	Yes	Required for correct NPC skin/ makeup in dialog

Troubleshooting:

Symptom	Likely Cause	Fix
Black face (dark head, light body)	NPC's facegen .nif missing from output, or a later mod overwrites it	Add the NPC's source mod to FacegenBaseline Source Mods; verify load order places FacegenBaseline output after all NPC overhauls
Face doesn't match appearance mod (wrong morph, wrong hair)	A different mod's facegen is winning the conflict	Reorder mods so the intended appearance mod loads after conflicting overhauls, then re-run FacegenBaseline

Grey face (no tint layers)	Tint layers not generated or not found	Verify “Include Tint Layers” is enabled; check that Textures\actors\character\FacegenTints exists in the output mod
CTD when approaching an NPC	Corrupted facegen data — mismatched head part count or missing assets	Delete FacegenBaseline output, re-verify all source mods are selected, re-run Synthesis from scratch
FacegenBaseline fails with “no facegen found”	Source mods list is empty or the patcher can’t find compatible face NIFs	Check that at least one source mod is selected and contains meshes\actors\character\facegen\data\fa

NPCStatRescaler

What it does: Rescales NPC stats (health, magicka, stamina, level, skills) to match the list’s encounter balance. Ensures NPCs added by appearance or content mods don’t fall outside the intended power curve.

When to run: After any NPC appearance overhaul, new NPC mod, or encounter-zone change. Runs in the same Synthesis stage as FacegenBaseline.

Configuration: Set target stat ranges to match the encounter design in → [Survival, Difficulty, and Balance] (modlist-survival-combat.md). Default Synthesis profile applies reasonable vanilla+-derived values.

Key relationship: NPCStatRescaler runs after FacegenBaseline in the Synthesis pipeline. If both are active, FacegenBaseline runs first so that NPC records have complete facegen data before stats are rescaled.

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Open Research

Open research for the NPCs stack is tracked in `TOD0.md`.

Enemies & Creatures

MO2 Separator: Enemies & Creatures

All mods in this section belong to the Enemies & Creatures MO2 separator.

> NPC-specific content → `[NPCs](modlist-npcs.md)`.

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Enemy Variety → separator: Enemies & Creatures

How hostile enemy groups feel less repetitive across ordinary play.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Lawless — A Bandit Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/88080)	Baseline	Cleanest vanilla-plus bandit variety. Bandits are the most overexposed enemy family.
[OBIS SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/4145)	Alternative	Heavier legacy bandit route.
[Haugbui — A Draugr Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26188)	Alternative	Lighter undead route.
[Skyrim Revamped — Complete Enemy Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/14598)	Alternative	List-wide enemy rebalance.
[Skyrim Bandit Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/154352)	Alternative	New bandit variants, gear, and encounters.

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Creature Visual Overhauls → separator: Enemies & Creatures

Creature-specific visual direction layered on top of the Bellyaches texture foundation from → Characters & Creatures.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Fluffworks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/56361)	Baseline	Broad furred-animal presentation layer.
[Bears of the North](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/47541)	Baseline	Species standout for common large wildlife threat.
[Iconic's Dragon Retexture](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/101712)	Baseline	Clean dragon presentation upgrade.
[Dragons SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/132218)	Baseline	Full dragon model replacer. Not compatible with Iconic's — choose one.
[Draugrs — New models and textures] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123170)	Baseline	Most-seen undead enemy.
[Spider SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/182638)	Baseline	
[Deer Reworked — Ultimate](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/155433)	Baseline	
[TNT - True Nordic Trolls - Revamped] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/140979)	Baseline	Troll model/texture overhaul.
[Cannibal Draugr on Solstheim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/21238)	Baseline	Bloodmoon-flavored identity.
[Hagraven — New models and Textures] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/160407)	Baseline	
[Butterfly Improved by zzjay](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37302)	Baseline	
[Fusa Fusa Project](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5514)	Alternative	Don't casually stack with Fluffworks.
[Splendor — Dragon Variants](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/9670)	Alternative	Last updated Sept 2017.
[Next Gen Dragon VFX](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/168405)	Alternative	Dragon breath/VFX visual upgrade.
[Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/146462)	Alternative	Dragon model variety via SkyPatcher. Requires Dragons SE.

[Sleep of the Dead – Draugr Leather and Shroud Replacer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/178057)	Alternative	Draugr shroud/leather retexture.
[Frozen Electrocuted Combustion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3532)	Alternative	Elemental creature death effects.
[Better Butterflies](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79332)	Alternative	Butterfly insect visual overhaul.
[Bear Replacer - Chakra's Creatures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/177594)	Alternative	Bear model replacer. Alternative to Bears of the North.
[Sabre Cat Replacer - Chakra's Creatures] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179058)	Alternative	Sabre cat model replacer.
[Sabrecats of Skyrim - CS ENB Fur Parallax] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/172385)	Alternative	Sabre cat fur parallax texture upgrade.
[All the Sabre Cats - Model Swapper](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/179353)	Alternative	Sabre cat model variety via Model Swapper.

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New Creature Additions → separator: Enemies & Creatures

Mihail Creature Additions (all ESL-flagged)

Mod	Notes
[Farm Geese](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/156242)	
[Sewer Rats](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/137591)	
[Giant Bats and Rats](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/140134)	
[Imps](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/33759)	
[Giant Centipedes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/26192)	
[Ogrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/27243)	
[Ruinachs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/49543)	

Non-Mihail Creature Additions

Mod	Notes
[Swamp Skeletons - Chakra's Creatures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/151282)	Swamp-themed skeleton variants. ESL-flagged.
[Edmond's Nature Series — BIRDS](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123068)	Species: Ravens, Pheasants, Seagulls, flocking birds and bats, Bone Hawks (unique audio), Ghost Ravens (Soul Cairn), plus additional placed hawks and hawk nests. ESL-flagged. Raven tris from Mihail (with permission), Seagulls from Mr. Siika community resource. Do not stack with Seagulls — Mihail. Pair with [Xtudo optimized textures](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/123210) — pick 2K main file.
[Morrowind Creatures SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/50435)	
[Ogres SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/59363)	
[Sea Turtles — Mihail](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/122141)	

Additional Species Follow-Ups

Mod	Notes
[Diverse True Wolves and Dogs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/38058)	
[Real Rabbits HD](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/29223)	
[Rally's Shaggy Cows of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/47742)	
[Realistic Horse Breeds by Krittakitty](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/7685)	Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility.

Creature Behavior Improvements → separator: Enemies & Creatures

How creatures attack, react, and express identity once combat starts.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Dragons Use Thu'um](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/87085)	Baseline	Smarter dragon shout usage and encounter AI.
[The Restless Dead](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/94100)	Baseline	Undead-behavior baseline. Replaces abandoned Draugr Upgrades and Improvements.
[Epic Dragon Combat REDONE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/126680)	Alternative	Full dragon combat overhaul — 20+ new types, unique abilities, custom VFX. Self-contained; replaces baseline dragon visual direction.
[Dragon War](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/51310)	Alternative	Heavier dragon route for fight structure/tempo.
[Dragons actually fall down](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/156824)	Alternative	Dragons collapse on the ground when staggered/low health.
[Epic Dwarven Centurion Combat](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/181405)	Alternative	Dwarven Centurion combat/animation overhaul.
[New Creature Animation - Dwarven Centurion - SCAR2.0 - MCO - Nemesis or Pandora](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/137805)	Alternative	Dwarven Centurion animation pack requiring MCO/BFCO or SCAR. Mutually exclusive with Epic Dwarven Centurion Combat — pick one.
[SkyTEST Lite ESL](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/84539) / [Animal Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1532) / [Pelagius's Wildlife AI](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/144909)	Alternative	Animal-side mods drifting into ecology territory.

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Wildlife Density And Rarity Balance → separator: Enemies & Creatures

Mod	Type	Notes
[True Hunter — fewer animals per square meter](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/25628)	Baseline	Spawn-chance reduction for more deliberate wildlife.
[No Predators on roads](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/11901)	Alternative	Abandoned (Aug 2017). Coexists with True Hunter.

Open research for this section is tracked in `TODO.md`.

Weapons & Armor

MO2 Separators: Weapons & Armor → Weapons & Armor — Weapons, Weapons & Armor — Armor, Weapons & Armor — Artifacts, Weapons & Armor — Clothing & Wardrobe

All mods in this section belong to one of the four weapons-and-armor separators as noted per subsection.

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Weapon Pack Additions → separator: Weapons & Armor – Weapons

Weapon content packs adding new named and leveled-list weapons fitting vanilla's medieval-Nordic aesthetic. More variety without diluting the loot ladder.

Baseline

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Heavy Armory](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6308)	Baseline	\1, \2, \4	150+ lore-friendly weapons, 11 new types. OAR-compatible polearm animations.
[Dawnguard Arsenal SSE - SkyPatched] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/25094)	Baseline	\1, \4	Dawnguard-themed weapons, enhanced crossbows. SkyPatched variant.

Alternatives

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/2017)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Upgraded vanilla weapon silhouettes. Stacks with Heavy Armory.
[Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/8273)	Alternative	\1, \4	Specialty named/unique crossbows and bows. Lock if ranged is a viable build path.
[Immersive Weapons](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16788)	Alternative	\1, \4	230+ weapons. Unmaintained since Apr 2018. Prefer the SkyPatched variant below.
[Immersive Weapons SkyPatched] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/142044)	Alternative	\1, \4	SkyPatched forward-port resolving record-level conflicts. Preferred over original.
[Moonblade](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/170595)	Alternative	all	Unique moon-themed weapon with quest content.
[Sorcerer Staff](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/178148)	Alternative	all	Unique staff / Staff of Magnus replacer with expanded mechanics.
[Occiglacies - Ancient Falmer Blade] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/35637)	Alternative	\1, \4	Ancient Falmer greatsword/sword. Switchable 1H/2H at Skyforge. 1,471 endorsements. Found in Forgotten Vale area. LoTD display patch available.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\3	Vanilla weapons only.

Risks & Compatibility

- Heavy Armory uses standard leveled-list integration; doesn't require Synthesis patcher intervention like Immersive Weapons. A Heavy Armory - Adamant Addon (mod 144316) provides Simonrim-aligned perk integration.
- LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons can conflict with Unique Items Tweaks and Reliquary of Myth on unique-weapon records.

- Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows makes crossbows a meaningful archetype — → Survival & Combat difficulty decisions need to account for ranged output.
 - All weapon mods add new models — Pandora and BodySlide rebuilds in → Performance fire when any of them is updated.
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Armor Pack Additions → separator: Weapons & Armor – Armor

Armor content packs adding new named and leveled-list armors fitting the medieval-Nordic aesthetic. More variety without diluting the loot ladder.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
[Immersive Armors](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3479)	55 armor sets, 396 shields. 206K endorsements.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/3479)
[Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/75891)	Brings visuals in line with 4K PBR stack.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/75891)

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
[NordwarUA Total Armor Compilation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/61423)	Visual model overhaul — 6 NordwarUA mods. Cubemap standardization.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/61423)
[Common Clothes and Armors](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/21305)	Clothing/light-armor variants for bandits, sellswords, travelers.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/21305)
[Bandolier — Bags and Pouches](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2417)	Carry-capacity utility with MCM config.	[Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/2417)
Discipline-first route	Vanilla armor sets only.	

Immersive Armors Visual Pipeline

> Stack order: Immersive Armors → Retexture and Mesh Fixes → (optional) Realistic Armors replace by Xtudo → (choose one female path) CBBE 3BA BodySlide OR HIMBO's CBBE patch → (if male) HIMBO Conversion V2.

Mod	Role	Dial	Notes
[IA — SSE CBBE 3BA BodySlide](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/22382)	Female path	all	BodySlide for all female IA outfits. Do not stack with Retexture/Mesh Fixes' bundled CBBE meshes.
[IA HIMBO Conversion V2](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/76552)	Male path	all	BodySlide for all IA armors for HIMBO. Stacks on Retexture/Mesh Fixes. Includes CBBE patch.
[IA — Realistic Armors replace by Xtudo](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/36746)	Optional	all	Swaps 10 IA sets for NordWarUA Realistic Armors. Requires Realistic Armor (36151).

Armor Set Additions

Mod	Description	Notes
[Armor Variants Expansion] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34100)	Visual variants for every vanilla armor set.	Has CBBE patch. Fits medieval-Nordic aesthetic.
[Ufok's Reinforced Leather Armour](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/183824)	D&D-inspired light armor.	3BA, CBBE, UBE, HIMBO, Vanilla. ESL, craftable, Skypatcher integration.
[Tera Armors Collection](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/9651)	Armor collection ported from TERA MMO.	CBBE. Evaluate visual fit.
[Lustmord Vampire Armor - SSE CBBE Bodyslide](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/16676)	CBBE 3BA vampire armor with physics.	14K endorsements.
[Wilderness Witch Outfit](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/40963)	CBBE witch/mage outfit.	Fits grim-dark aesthetic.
[Dark Mage of Plegia - hdt SMP (CBBE 3BA)](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/84554)	CBBE 3BA SMP dark mage outfit.	9K endorsements.
[Dremora Markynaz Armor SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79753)	Daedric-themed armor set.	Requires HDT-SMP. HIMBO refit ([125150](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/125150)), CBBE ([79968](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79968)).
[Silver Armor SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79088)	Silver-themed armor set.	CBBE ([79319](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79319)), HIMBO ([87675](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/87675)), HDT-SMP patch ([79255](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79255)).
[Colovian Prince Set](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/79894)	Colovian-themed armor set.	
[Lifesworn Vestiges – Champion of Arkay Armor](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/136837)	Arkay-themed armor with optional SMP.	3BA/HIMBO ([175271](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/175271)).
[Traveling Mage HDT-SMP Armor](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69394)	Mage travel outfit with SMP.	CBBE 3BA/HIMBO ([69407](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69407)).

[JS Helm of Yngol SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/51346)	Unique helm mesh/texture replacer.	
[Wind Ruler Armor SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/60842)	Wind-themed armor set.	HDT-SMP ([63036](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/63036)), HIMBO ([106036](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/106036))).
[Imperial Guard Centurion Armor SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/50410)	Imperial guard armor set.	3BA/HIMBO ([178841](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/178841)), SPID ([123487](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/123487))).
[Fur-lined Steel Armor](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/106305)	Fur-trimmed steel armor.	
[Travelling Priest Robes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118327)	Priest robe outfit. HIMBO/CBBE.	SPID distribution ([118464](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/118464))).
[Nibenean Armors and Outfit SE] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/50785)	Nibenese-style armor/outfits.	SPID ([123477](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/123477))), male HIMBO refit.
[Templar Assassin Armor](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135547)	Assassin-themed armor. 3BA/BHUNP/CBBE/UNP.	HDT-SMP patch ([135910](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/135910))).
[Visage of Mzund](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/69047)	Unique Dwemer face visor. Xtudo version.	
[Legendary Alpha Shields] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/49387)	Shield variety pack.	SPID for NPCs ([80041](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/80041))), Xtudo patches ([79895](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79895))).
[Legendary Alpha Shields 2] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79264)	Additional shield variety pack.	SPID for NPCs ([80110](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/80110))), Xtudo patches ([79617](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/79617))).
[JS Unique Utopia SE - Rings] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/102226)	Unique ring mesh/texture replacer.	
[Land of Vominheim - Unique Rewards by Xtudo](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/102226)	Unique rewards patch for Land of Vominheim.	Install if Vominheim is adopted.

nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/102839)		
[Callisto HDT-SMP Armor] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134752)	Female HDT-SMP heavy armor. Craftable, ESL-flagged.	Requires FSMP. Xtudo patches ([134900])(https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134900)) add SPID, Ancient Falmer replacer, LOTD, beast-race support. HIMBO male addon ([134789])(https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134789)).
[Elven Chainmail (SSE Port)] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/14978)	Female-only elven light armor set + scimitar. Found in Northwatch Keep.	LE port by JWGaming75. Requires CBBE. Last updated Jan 2018 — verify 1.6.1170.
[HD Falmer Elven Chainmail Retexture](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/35669)	HD retexture for Elven Chainmail.	By trion77/Vindition. Install over Elven Chainmail base mod.

Risks & Compatibility

- NordwarUA Total Armor standardizes cubemaps across all six sub-mods — any mod depending on original cubemaps needs re-testing.
- Common Clothes and Armors adds clothing to NPC leveled lists. Verify NPCs look right if Armor and Clothing Extension is also active.
- Bandolier changes inventory — carry-weight design must account for additional slots.
- The Retexture/Mesh Fixes mod and CBBE 3BA BodySlide are not stackable for female meshes. HIMBO Conversion V2 avoids this conflict (designed to stack on top of Retexture/Mesh Fixes).
- All IA companion mods trigger Pandora and BodySlide rebuilds in → Performance.

—

Artifact And Unique Item Overhauls → separator: Weapons & Armor – Artifacts

Unique-item content packs that add depth to Daedric artifacts, dragon priest masks, unique weapons, and quest items. Treats artifact overhauls as a separate layer from crafting — they change what named items are, not how the player makes generic items.

Baseline

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Reliquary of Myth](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/31612)	Baseline	\1, \4	Artifact stats and effects. 12K endorsements.

Alternatives

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[ArteFakes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/41254)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Higher-detail 3D models for unique items. Stacks with Reliquary of Myth.
[Konahrik's Accoutrements](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/22206)	Alternative	\1, \4	Dragon-priest gear, masks, harder fights. LoTD museum integration.
[Unique Items Tweaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33723)	Alternative	\1, \2, \3, \4	Gap-filler for artifacts Reliquary of Myth doesn't cover.
[Artificer](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/99619)	Alternative	\1, \2, \4	Simonrim-aligned alternative to Reliquary of Myth. Requires Thaumaturgy + Mysticism.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\3	Vanilla artifact stats.

Risks & Compatibility

- Reliquary of Myth + ArteFakes + Unique Items Tweaks touches every unique-item record. Verify the Synthesis patcher chain in → Performance doesn't re-balance the same records.
- Konahrik's Accoutrements adds new Dragon Priest encounters — check the LoTD Patches (Official) hub in → Legacy of the Dragonborn for an integration patch.
- Artifact overhauls that rebalance too aggressively can break encounter expectations.
- Unique Items Tweaks overlaps lightly with Reliquary of Myth on a small number of records — verify with a Bashed Patch.

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Clothing And Wardrobe Extensions → separator: Weapons & Armor – Clothing & Wardrobe

Clothing content packs adding new clothing, cloaks, and wearable non-armor items. More wardrobe variety without making every NPC a fashion show.

Baseline

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Armor and Clothing Extension](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/19002)	Baseline	\1, \2, \3, \4	Clothing diversity. 35K+ endorsements. Requires RUSTIC CLOTHING + SkyUI.

Alternatives

Mod	Type	Dial	Notes
[Common Clothes and Armors](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/21305)	Alternative	all	Common-cloth variety for bandit/sellsword archetypes.
[Sforzinda Imitations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/54346)	Alternative	all	Curated boutique clothing. Cut if it pulls toward boutique-fantasy wardrobe.
[Cloaks of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/6369)	Alternative	all	100+ cloaks via SPID. Highest third-person visual impact.
[Colovian Noble Clothes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/4464)	Alternative	all	Imperial-themed high-status clothing. Pairs with Beyond Skyrim.
[Knapsack Backpacks SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/3440)	Alternative	all	Carry-and-wearable utility with MCM. Cosmetic companion to Bandolier.
Discipline-first route	Alternative	\3	Vanilla clothing only.
[RMB SPCH - Cloaks of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/116030)	Alternative	all	SkyPatched version. Replaces original Cloaks of Skyrim (6369). Preferred over base.
[Cloaks Of Skyrim Retextured SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/42558)	Add-on	all	Retexture for Cloaks of Skyrim or RMB SPCH variant.
[Cloaks Of Skyrim Retextured SE Female Mesh Patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/85932)	Add-on	all	Female mesh fix for the retexture.
[Artesian Cloaks of Skyrim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/17416)	Alternative	all	Higher-detail cloak mesh/texture replacer. Alternative to Cloaks of Skyrim.
[Dynamic Artisan Cloaks](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/146438)	Alternative	all	Dynamic cloak animations via OAR. Cloak physics and movement.

[RMB SPCH - Winter is Coming Cloaks] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/116029)	Alternative	all	SkyPatched version of Winter is Coming Cloaks.
[Dynamic Armor Variants] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65963)	Alternative	all	Visual armor/clothing variants based on conditions. No stat changes.
[Dynamic Lowered Hoods] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/65964)	Alternative	all	Hoods lower dynamically when not in combat. OAR-based.

Risks & Compatibility

- Armor and Clothing Extension requires RUSTIC CLOTHING and SkyUI — verify load order keeps RUSTIC CLOTHING above ACE.
- Cloaks of Skyrim adds 100+ cloak items. If → Third-Person Gameplay adds a custom cloak-slot overhaul, verify stacking. RMB SPCH (116030) is the preferred SkyPatched variant over the original.
- Knapsack Backpacks SE (cosmetic) and Bandolier (inventory) can stack, but verify inventory UI doesn't show duplicate bag icons.
- Verify Colovian Noble Clothes for known issues before locking.

Audio and Feedback

MO2 Separators: Audio → Audio - Music, Audio - SFX & Ambience

All mods in this section belong to one of the two audio separators as noted per subsection.

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Music Overhaul Strategy → separator: Audio - Music

The soundtrack direction: how much to expand Skyrim's music while staying close to the Jeremy Soule baseline.

Baseline

Mod	Notes
[Chapter II - Jeremy Soule Inspired Music](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37792)	Darker, more emotional melancholy without breaking from Soule's shape.
[The Northerner Diaries - Immersive Edition] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/33903)	Authentic Jeremy Soule compositions: 19 exploration tracks.
[The Southerner Diaries](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/32593)	22 Soule-inspired exploration and town tracks.
[Melodies of Civilization](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/37533)	20+ town, tavern, and settlement tracks.
[Nygthfall - Dark Fantasy Music](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/39011)	7 hours, 98 dark-fantasy tracks. Evaluate after baseline is in place.
[Nordenhamr - Viking Music](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/58080)	Viking identity reinforcement.
[BA Bard Songs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/47202)	Bard song replacer. Compatible with Skyrim's Got Talent.

Alternatives

- Yggdrasil Music and SoundFX Overhaul ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/21578>)) — Harsher, more ritualistic direction. Last updated April 2021.
- Silent Combat Music ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/5148>)) — Support option if combat music becomes intrusive.
- Minimalist route — Keep vanilla soundtrack.

Installation Notes

- If combining multiple music mods, use the Synthesis music-merge plugin for deliberate playlist merging.
- Keep generated music-merge output in its own dedicated MO2 mod. Rebuild when the music stack changes.
- See → Performance for Synthesis pipeline configuration.

Risks & Compatibility

- A very large combined soundtrack can feel incoherent if tracks don't share tonal identity.
- Multiple music mods must be merged via Synthesis to avoid overlapping MUSTT records.
- Any pre-2020 music mod may lack native AE support — verify before locking.

—

Weapon, Magic, And Impact SFX → separator: Audio - SFX & Ambience

The sound-effects layer for combat, magic, items, UI, and impact. The bar: modern, weighty, clear audio readable in third-person without visual confirmation.

Mod	Notes
[Immersive Sounds - Compendium](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/523)	Weapon-and-armor SFX baseline. Broadest patch ecosystem.
[Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/12341)	Master reverb-and-attenuation layer. 27K endorsements, actively maintained (v4.1.4, April 2026).
[Airgetlam - Shouts SFX](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/33993)	Shout-audio companion. Replaces raw .wav files, no record conflicts.
Strange Runes	Magic audio layer (cross-referenced from → Magic & Perks).

Load Order

ISC and AOS both edit large numbers of sound records. Load AOS after ISC so AOS's reverb/attenuation wins over ISC's raw effect swaps. Airgetlam loads after both.

Risks & Compatibility

- ISC is one of the oldest actively used Nexus mods (first uploaded 2013). Touches so many records that any update creates unexpected conflict pressure.
- Airgetlam replaces raw audio files — should be loaded after any mod touching shout records.

—

Creature And NPC SFX → separator: Audio - SFX & Ambience

Baseline

- Minimalist route — rely on ISC + AOS for creature sounds. Add dedicated replacers only if testing reveals weak vocalisations.
- Talkative Dragons ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/26955>)) — Dragons speak during combat via reused vanilla voice lines. ESL-flagged, only overwrites one record (CreatureDialogueDragon). 15,478 endorsements.

Risks & Compatibility

- Creature sound .wav replacers are generally safe (no record conflicts). Sound descriptor editors must load after ISC and AOS.
- Talkative Dragons edits a dialogue record, not raw audio. Verify with dragon dialogue from Epic Dragon Combat REDONE.

—

Combat And Immersion Audio → separator: Audio - SFX & Ambience

Combat-specific and immersion-audio mods layering on top of the weapon/magic SFX baseline.

Mod	Notes
[Precision](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/72347)	Already locked in → Third-Person; audio impact is secondary.
[Valhalla Combat](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/64741)	Already locked; parry/stagger/timed-block audio feedback.
[Heart of the Beast - Werewolf Sound and Camera Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/13776)	Werewolf audio baseline if Growl is adopted.
[Heart of the Beast - Feral](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/165648)	Alternative werewolf sounds. Choose one variant, not both.

Risks & Compatibility

- Only one Heart of the Beast variant active at a time. Both installed = file conflicts.
- If Growl adds new werewolf forms not covered by the sound replacer, forms fall back to Growl defaults.

—

Ambient And Environmental Audio → separator: Audio - SFX & Ambience

Environmental soundscapes, creature ambient sounds, and weather audio to reinforce world immersion outside of combat.

Mod	Notes
[Wildwood Echoes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/112008)	Forest and woodland soundscape expansion.
[Blackreach Eerie Ambience](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/112114)	Blackreach-specific ambient atmosphere.
[Murder of Songbirds](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/111766)	Ambient bird audio in wilderness areas.
[Nordic Winds](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/112370)	Weather-specific wind sound effects for colder regions.
[Whispering Tomes of Apocrypha](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/113423)	Apocrypha ambient soundscape.
[Falmer 'Dialogue' Overhaul - Echolocation](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/114625)	Falmer echolocation vocalisation replacer. Creature-audio companion layer.
[Potema Revoiced](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/123877)	Revoiced Potema dialogue. Overwrites vanilla voice files rather than dialogue records.
[Whispers of the Daedric Princes](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/141931)	Ambient Daedric prince whispers in dungeons and Oblivion-related locations.

Risks & Compatibility

- All entries above are raw .wav/.xwm replacers or sound-descriptor mods - no record-level conflicts with ISC or AOS.
- Load sound-descriptor edits after ISC and AOS in left pane.
- Potema Revoiced replaces voice files only; verify compatibility with quest-expansion mods touching the Potema quest.

Survival, Difficulty, and Balance

MO2 Separators: Survival & Combat → Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality, Survival & Combat - Enemy AI, Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries

All mods in this section belong to one of the three survival/combat separators as noted per subsection.

#1 picks locked: Arena, Simply Balanced, Less Sniperlike NPCs (restrained AI route), Stress and Fear + Light the Way + Bathing patch, Know Your Enemy 2.

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Difficulty Framework → separator: Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality

Cross-load-order pressure: how quickly the world pushes back, how clearly dungeon progression reads, and whether difficulty comes from better structure instead of blunt stat inflation.

Baseline

- Arena - An Encounter Zone Overhaul [\#1, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/33487>)) — Cleanest middle ground: more progression pressure than vanilla, still readable and open-world friendly.

Alternatives

- Minimal intervention [\#3] — Leave encounter zones close to vanilla.
- Heavy world-structure [\#1] — Deleveled loot and stronger world gating (owned by → Crafting & Economy).

Risks & Compatibility

- Encounter-zone structure can overlap with loot/economy decisions if this section pretends it owns world progression.
- If Arena is combined with much harsher loot distribution, the result can overshoot from moody into over-gated.

—

Combat Lethality And Pacing → separator: Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality

Tunes encounter harshness and time-to-kill on top of the combat framework from → Third-Person, not replacing it.

Baseline

- Simply Balanced [\#1, \#2, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/15541>)) — Preferred pacing tool. Final damage/progression tuning without re-owning stamina, injury, or combat behavior.

Alternatives

- Blade and Blunt - A Combat Overhaul [\#1] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/34549>)) — Deliberate branch — it reaches far beyond simple pacing.
- Wildcat - Combat of Skyrim [\#1, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/1368>)) — Injury system, combat AI, and lethality tweaks. Legacy baseline.
- Minimalist route [\#3] — Keep lethality in the section-04 combat stack.

Candidate

- Relentless [\#1] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/114022>)) — Difficulty and pacing mod. Research before adding; evaluate how it interacts with the Section-04 combat stack and Arena encounter zones.

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Enemy AI Improvements → separator: Survival & Combat - Enemy AI

Baseline

- Restrained route — rely on Arena, the section-04 combat stack, and targeted creature/faction additions.
- Less Sniperlike NPCs [all] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34199>)) — Reduces NPC projectile accuracy. Prefer applying via Wrye Bash (70.0) to avoid an extra plugin.

Alternatives

- Skyrim Revamped - Complete Enemy Overhaul [\#1, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/14598>)) — High-commitment. Add only if ordinary testing shows enemy behavior still too flat.
- SkyTactics - Dynamic Combat Styles [\#1, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131148>)) — SkyPatcher-based NPC combat style variety.
- NPCs Take Cover - Smarter Anti-Cheese AI [all] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/111890>)) — NPCs take cover during combat instead of standing in the open. Lightweight, no new records.

—

Injury, Stamina, And Resource Pressure → separator: Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries

Attrition that lingers beyond a single swing: drained stamina, enforced downtime, the feeling that repeated bad fights accumulate a cost.

Baseline

- Stress and Fear - A Dynamic Sanity System [#1, #2, #4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim-specialedition/mods/116522>)) — Emotional/pacing consequences encouraging rest, food, inns, and quieter recovery. Design is light enough to create stories without shouting over the rest of the list.
- Light the Way - A Stress and Fear Add-On [#1, #2, #4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim-specialedition/mods/171532>)) — Light-flicker effect during high-stress moments.
- Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed - Stress and Fear patch [#1, #2, #4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrim-specialedition/mods/141564>)) — Cleanliness affects sanity. Required if both mods installed.

Alternatives

- Blade and Blunt [#1] — Overlapping alternative for harsher stamina-and-combat pressure.
- Minimalist route [#3] — Keep resource pressure inside existing combat/survival layers.

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Enemy Resistances And Knowledge Checks → separator: Survival & Combat - Enemy AI

Baseline

- Know Your Enemy 2 [\#1, \#4] ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/93258>))
 - Different creatures call for different tools; inspect system makes knowledge legible. Scope: tactical differentiation, not full enemy-ecosystem ownership.

Risks & Compatibility

- Resistance systems can feel punishing if the player doesn't have enough ways to adapt mid-run.
- For Steam 1.6.1170, the listed Backported Extended ESL Support requirement does not apply.
- If the inspect flow or resistance spread feels too noisy, the concept may be better than the lived experience.

—

Survival Systems Compatibility → separator: Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries

How difficulty and pressure choices interact with the chosen survival framework.

Baseline

- Additive route — use pressure layers that reward existing survival behaviors (eating, resting, warming up, returning to town).
- Stress and Fear naturally plugs into meals, inns, sleep, and calmer downtime.
- If Starfrost remains the baseline, this section should amplify recovery need without forcing menu babysitting.
- Cold Breath - NG [all] ([Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/174838)) (v1.8, May 2026) — Higher-fidelity fogged breath in cold environments. Mesh/particle replacer, no ESP.

Alternatives

- Navigation Restrictions - NG [1] ([Nexus](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/129086)) — Fast travel and survival restrictions. Adds survival-oriented travel pressure.

Environmental Hazards → separator: Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries

Environmental damage layers that make fire, traps, and dungeon hazards genuinely threatening.

Mod	Notes
[Fires Hurt - OIF](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/157720)	Fire sources deal damage over time when stood in. Requires OIF framework. Adds meaningful hazard pressure to dungeons and campfires.

Legacy of the Dragonborn

MO2 Separator: Legacy of the Dragonborn

All items in this section belong to the Legacy of the Dragonborn MO2 separator.

—

Core Mod Baseline → separator: Legacy of the Dragonborn

Treated as a foundational content pillar for the final list, not a late optional extra.

Mod	Type	Notes
[Legacy of the Dragonborn](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/11802) v6.10.1 (May 2026)	Baseline	Non-negotiable centerpiece.
[The Curator's Companion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/38529) v7.0.8	Baseline	In-game tracking for museum displays and collection progress.
[Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches (Official)] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/30980) v6.10.7 (June 2026)	Baseline	Required integration infrastructure.
Paintings Replacer for Legacy of the Dragonborn SSE (Nexus 13279, v1.1, Nov 2017)	Baseline	Texture replacer, low risk.
Fate Cards Remade - Legacy of The Dragonborn ([Nexus 76418](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/76418))	Baseline	130 unique card artworks, remade meshes and display assets.
Placeable Display Cases (Nexus 131107, v3.1, Jan 2025)	Baseline	Placeable museum display cases.
[Achievement Injector](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126220) + [LoTD Achievement Injector](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/130114)	Baseline	Museum achievement content.

—

Supported Content → separator: Legacy of the Dragonborn

Quest Mods With Strong LoTD Integration

- VIGILANT — Multiple display cases in Hall of Oddities.
- Unslaad — Official patch hub support.
- Glenmoril — Patch pipeline still maturing; check before locking.
- Project AHO — Full display room in Hall of Secrets.
- Carved Brink — Displays for Faceted Stones artifacts.
- The Forgotten City — Unique items and choice reward display.
- Beyond Skyrim - Bruma — Count-flation and display-base integration.
- Beyond Reach — Third-party patch.
- The Wheels of Lull — Hall of Secrets display slots.
- Moon and Star — Unique armor/weapon display.
- Wyrnstooth — Displays for unique items.
- Falskaar — Base museum count supports.
- Sirenroot - A Verdant Tale — Check patch status.
- Midwood Isle — Official patch support.
- The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal — Legendary mask display.
- The Breton Paladin — Official patch support.
- Clockwork — Unique item display slots.
- Konahrik's Accoutrements — Deep integration with dedicated display room.
- Artifacts - The Ice Blade of the Monarch — Standalone artifact with display.
- Artifacts - The Tournament of the Ten Bloods — New artifact quest with displays.
- Obscure's College of Winterhold — LoTD patch in OCW's own FOMOD. Covers private collection and unique College items.

Display Expansions And Room Mods

- LOTD Display Patch Repos — Third-party display patches not covered by official hub.
- Museum Display Room Expansion — Evaluate if base museum feels cramped.
- Hall of Forgotten Guild — Curator's Companion feature for additional collectible space.

Collectible Additions

- Stones of Barenziah Quest Markers — Dedicated display for completed crown.
- Jewels of the Reach — Additional gemstone collectible.
- Dawnguard Treasure Map — Feeds collection-driven exploration loop.
- Legacy of the Dragonborn BadGremlins Collection ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/15092>)) — Gremlin-themed collectible display items for the museum.
- Fate Cards New Style - 2023 Remaster ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/104676>)) — Alternate fate card artwork and design. Alternative to Fate Cards Remade (76418).

Artifact Enhancement

- Zim's Immersive Artifacts ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/9138>)) — 50+ vanilla artifact rebalances. If no official patch, load LoTD after ZIA so museum display conditions use LoTD records.

—

Patch Strategy → separator: Legacy of the Dragonborn

- Use LoTD Patches (Official) as default patch source.
- Add third-party patches only when official collection doesn't cover a finalized mod.
- Do not pre-install broad patch bundles for hypothetical mods.
- Re-check museum sorting behavior after each major content addition.

Mod Selection Questions

1. Does this mod have official or high-quality third-party LoTD patch support?
2. Does it add unique items that feel like they **should** be displayed?
3. Does it conflict with LoTD workspace edits?
4. Does the play order fit the museum's unlock progression?

—

Submods And Quality-Of-Life → separator: Legacy of the Dragonborn

Sorting And Inventory

- Legacy Safehouse Plus — Expanded safehouse with additional crafting stations. Check v6.10+ compatibility.
- LOTD - Explorer's Room — Explorer-themed storage/display.
- Quick Light — Not LoTD-specific but essential for museum navigation.
- Map Markers for LotD — Fast-travel marker after quest conditions met.

Museum-Specific UI

- LOTD Museum Exterior Fixes — Navmesh and door-activation fixes.
- LOTD Hall of Secrets Door Fix — Door activator fix.
- Object Manipulation Overhaul — Display arrangement without console commands.

Additional QoL

- Legacy of The Dragonborn - SMIM Chests ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/55720>)) — SMIM-quality chest meshes for the museum displays.
- LOTD - Museum Exterior Music — Low priority; evaluate after → Audio is locked.
- Dynamic Activation Key — Reduces E-key scroll-conflict with crowded displays.

Relic System

- Relic Hunter — Evaluate compatibility with LoTD v6's own relic system.
- LOTD - Explorer's League — Guild-like progression. Check overlap with Curator's Companion.
- Shovels - Dig Up Treasure — Check for conflict with LoTD dig-site expeditions.

Risks & Compatibility

- Legacy of the Dragonborn can drag the whole load order toward completionist design.
- Museum-first progression changes perceived value of loot and unique-item mods.
- Quest mods with strong LoTD integration may co-determine the quest mod stack.
- Third-party display patches for pre-2023 quest mods may not be maintained against LoTD v6.

Adult Content

MO2 Separator: Adult Content

All mods in this section belong to the Adult Content MO2 separator unless noted.

—

Framework Prerequisites → separator: Adult Content

OStim Standalone — a modern, standalone adult animation framework that does not require OSA or SexLab. The OStim Romance and Amorous Adventures patch layer depend on this.

Mod	Type	Notes
[OStim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/98163)	Baseline	Modern adult animation framework. Does not require OSA.
[OStim Community Resource](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/106519)	Baseline	Shared framework for OStim add-ons.
[Night-blooming Violets for OStim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/98276)	Baseline	Scene framework addon.
[OARE - Open Animations Romance and Erotica](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/80594)	Baseline	Recommended animation pack baseline.
[Additional Leito's Animations for Ostim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/104995)	Baseline	150 animations.
[Anub's animations for Ostim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/101918)	Baseline	685 animations.
[PPA - Procedural Penis Animations](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/172002)	Baseline	CBPC collision physics addon.
[OSmp - Automatic SMP physics toggle for OStim](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/72547)	Baseline	ESL-flagged, supports CBBE 3BA and HIMBO.
[Female Moan Voicesets For Ostim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121383)	Baseline	38 voicesets keyed to voice types.
[Ostim SA-Sound Replacer-Blowjob](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/131890)	Baseline	Sound replacer.
[Male Orgasm Sounds For Ostim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/132396)	Baseline	Sound replacer for male animations.
[OCum Ascended](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/77506)	Baseline	Cum and orgasm mechanics with visual layers.
[Clean Navigation Icons for OStim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/181886)	Baseline	62 navigation icons.
[Animation Pack Icons for OStim Standalone](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/181880)	Baseline	18 icons.
[OTooTiredToMove](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/154112)	Baseline	Temporary immobilisation after climax.

[OStim Prism](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174750)	Baseline	OStim framework visual/settings enhancement.
[OSquirt - OCum Expansion](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/167025)	Baseline	Expands OCum Ascended mechanics.
[Ostim Standalone Sound Overhaul](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/120663)	Baseline	Audio overhaul for OStim animations.

Risks & Compatibility

- OStim Standalone must not be loaded alongside legacy OSA or SexLab.
- OStim Romance and AA OStim patch must match the same OStim Standalone version.
- Keep auto-start settings conservative to avoid script load.

—

Romance Content → separator: Adult Content

Opt-in quest-driven romance content running on top of the OStim framework.

Baseline

Mod	Notes
[OStim Romance](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/107671)	Primary romance-content baseline. Active maintenance.
[OComfort - OStim Romance Fork](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/139333)	Romance fork adding comfort/affection mechanics. Alternative to OStim Romance.
[Amorous Adventures OStim Standalone - OStim Sequences](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/106773)	Ports classic Amorous Adventures to OStim with sequence scenes.
[Amorous Adventures OStim Standalone - Rewrite and MCM Patch with Fixes - Sequences Edition](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/150577)	Updated rewrite with MCM patch and fixes. Supersedes the base patch.
[Amorous Adventures MCM](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/100112)	MCM configuration for Amorous Adventures.
[Amorous Adventures - Player Dialogue Rewritten](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/38989)	Reworks player dialogue options for Amorous Adventures.
[Caught Red Handed - Quest Expansion - OStim Patch](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/69711)	OStim integration for the Caught Red Handed quest expansion.

Risks & Compatibility

- Lock the framework version first, then verify romance mod compatibility.
- Romance quests add dialogue/quest records that may conflict with → World Content or → NPCs overhauls.
- Verify load order with RDO and Serana Dialogue Add-On for overlapping NPCs.
- Amorous Adventures OStim Standalone - Rewrite (150577) is the preferred version over the base OStim Sequences patch (106773).

—

NPC Relationship Content → separator: Adult Content

NPC relationship simulation — schedules, pairings, and partner-swapping running on OStim.

Baseline

Mod	Notes
[OStim NPCs - NPC Sex Lives Improved](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/82888)	NPC relationship schedules and partner variety. Requires OStim Standalone.

Risks & Compatibility

- Verify NPC schedules don't conflict with AI Overhaul SSE or other NPC behavior mods from → NPCs.
- Heavy script load — test for Papyrus performance on longer playthroughs.

—

Pregnancy & Family → separator: Adult Content

Pregnancy, childbirth, family systems, and child NPC overhauls. These mods form an interconnected ecosystem — evaluate as a set.

Baseline

Mod	Notes
[SkyChild](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/128779)	Child NPC appearance overhaul. Replaces vanilla child models.
[Wild Side - A SkyChild Add-On](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/135462)	Adds wild/feral child variants. Companion add-on for SkyChild.

Alternatives & Tentative

Mod	Notes
[Beeing Female NG](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/168434)	Tentative — evaluate gameplay and compatibility impact. Pregnancy and female reproductive system framework.
[Beeing Female - FM - FMR - Skychild Patch] (https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/169104)	Tentative — consider alongside Beeing Female NG. Compatibility patch for Beeing Female + SkyChild.
[Seeds of Skyrim - Lore Pregnant NPCs](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialiedition/mods/55112)	Lore-friendly pregnant NPCs. Evaluate for overlap with Beeing Female pregnancy system.

Risks & Compatibility

- Pregnancy frameworks add persistent actor data and scripts — monitor save file growth.
- SkyChild replaces child NPC models; verify compatibility with any mod that adds or modifies child NPCs.
- These mods interact with each other; install patches where available.
- Evaluate all pregnancy/child mods as a set before locking any individual pick.

Main Character Voicing

MO2 Separator: Voicing

All mods in this section belong to the Voicing MO2 separator.

—

Framework Overview → separator: Voicing

Dragonborn Voice Over 2 (DBVO2) is the runtime framework that intercepts player dialogue and plays .wav/ .fuz files via an SKSE plugin. Combined with the xEdit dialogue export tool and AI voice synthesis (ElevenLabs or xVASynth), the player character speaks every dialogue line.

Baseline

Mod / Resource	Type	Notes
[Dragonborn Voice Over 2](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/84329)	Framework	SKSE plugin. Intercepts player dialogue and plays .wav/ .fuz files. Settings via SKSE Menu Framework (F1). Per-character pack switching, per-save presets.
[Bella Voice DBVO](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/89810)	Voice Pack	Most popular female pack, broadest mod coverage.
[DBVO - Allison Voice Pack](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/126843)	Voice Pack	British female alternative.
Pre-made male packs	Voice Pack	Less common pre-made options available.
Laura Bailey	Recommended Actress	ElevenLabs Voice Design target for custom female pack via → [Custom Voice Pack Pipeline](\custom-voice-pack-pipeline).
Graham McTavish (The Saint / Geralt)	Recommended Actor	ElevenLabs custom target for male pack via → [Custom Voice Pack Pipeline](\custom-voice-pack-pipeline).

Alternatives

Mod / Resource	Type	Notes
[xVASynth](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/44184)	Alternative	Free audio generation. Quality is noticeably synthetic. Used for male default (Geralt voice model).
[ElevenLabs](https://elevenlabs.io)	Alternative	Premium audio generation. Higher quality, more natural output. Used for Laura Bailey custom target.
[DBVO Dialogue Export for xEdit](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/182009)	Alternative	Replaces MCVO Generator for dialogue export. xEdit script with optional ESPFE fix patch.
[MCVO Generator](https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/86737)	Alternative	Legacy dialogue export. Still works with DBVO2 legacy mode. Last updated March 2023.

Setup Requirements

- DBVO2 requires SKSE64, Address Library for SKSE Plugins, and SKSE Menu Framework (all in → Foundations and UI stacks).
- No dialogumenu.swf patching needed — works with most UI mods without modification.
- Windows 255-char path limit can crash on startup — keep install path short.
- Pre-made packs may not cover every mod. Uncovered lines fall back to subtitles.
- xVASynth batch processing can take 2-3 hours for 50,000+ lines.

—

Two Custom Voice Packs → separator: Voicing

Two custom-generated packs (Laura Bailey female, Graham McTavish male) for character flexibility. Install as separate MO2 mods, swap via MO2 profile or DBVO2 voice pack dropdown in SKSE Menu Framework (F1).

Run → [Custom Voice Pack Pipeline](custom-voice-pack-pipeline) twice with two ElevenLabs voice IDs (Laura Bailey female, Graham McTavish male). Package as separate MO2 mods and enable one at a time.

—

Custom Voice Pack Pipeline → separator: Voicing

Unified workflow covering dialogue export → audio generation → packaging into DBVO2 format. Replaces the legacy MCVO Generator + standalone ElevenLabs sections.

Prerequisites

- Install DBVO2 and dependencies (SKSE64, Address Library, SKSE Menu Framework). DBVO2 must be enabled in MO2 before exporting.
- Build the full modlist in MO2 with final load order.
- Download [DBVO Dialogue Export for xEdit](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/182009>) — modern xEdit script that exports player dialogue lines. Replaces MCVO Generator.
- [ElevenLabs](<https://elevenlabs.io>) paid account — required for both custom targets (Laura Bailey and Graham McTavish).
- Download DBVO Voice Packer 2 V2.5.1 (Google Drive link) — packages generated audio into DBVO2 format with .fuz files and voice-pack.json manifest.

Step 1: Export Dialogue

1. Open SSEEdit/xEdit with all load-order mods active.
2. Right-click any plugin → Apply Script → select DBVO_Dialogue_Export.pas.
3. The script scans all dialogue in the load order and outputs one TopicList*.txt file per dialogue-containing mod, plus a BrokenTopicList*.txt listing lines that need manual editing.
4. Optionally create the ESPFE fix patch (trims whitespace, deduplicates lines).
5. Save the output to a working directory outside MO2's mods folder.

Step 2: Generate Audio

ElevenLabs (recommended for Laura Bailey or Graham McTavish custom pack):

1. Create an [ElevenLabs](<https://elevenlabs.io>) account. A paid subscription is required for full load orders (Creator \$22/mo. or Pro \$99/mo.).
2. Get your API key: Profile → Profile Settings → API Key → copy the key.
3. Choose a voice:
 - Voice Library — browse pre-made voices. For a Laura Bailey target, look for voices tagged with similar qualities (warm alto, American female). For Graham McTavish, look for deep, gravelly male voices (Scottish-accented where possible).
 - Voice Design — create a custom voice from scratch with fine-grained control over accent, age, gender, and style.
 - Voice Cloning — if you have a clean audio sample of the target actor, use Instant Voice Cloning.
4. Get the voice ID: every voice has a unique ID in its URL (/voice/<voice-id>) or via GET <https://api.elevenlabs.io/v1/voices>.
5. Download the DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool from the DBVO author's [Discord](<https://discord.gg/7EFNjzATvC>), tool-download channel.
6. Point the Voice Pack Creator at your exported TopicList*.txt files, enter your API key and target voice ID, then run.
7. The tool batch-generates .wav files covering every dialogue line in your load order.

Step 3: Package into DBVO2 Format

1. Run DBVO Voice Packer 2 V2.5.1.
2. Point it at your generated .wav files and the exported TopicList*.txt files.
3. The tool creates the correct DBVO2 folder structure and files:

- Sound\Voice\Dragonborn Voice Over\<pack-name>*.fuz
 - voice-pack.json manifest
4. Create an MO2 mod from the output folder. Name it descriptively (e.g., DBV0 - Laura Bailey Custom).

Step 4: Install & Activate

1. Enable the mod in MO2. Place after DBVO2 in the left pane.
2. Launch the game through SKSE.
3. Open SKSE Menu Framework (Press F1) → Dragonborn Voice Over → General.
4. Ensure Use legacy voice over is Off (V2 packs only).
5. Select your voice pack from the dropdown.
6. Test dialogue lines with any NPC – uncovered lines fall back to subtitles.

Character Quota Planning

ElevenLabs Creator plan (100,000 chars/month) covers 15,000–20,000 lines. Full 50,000+ line load order may need Pro plan (\$99/month, 500,000 chars) or multiple months. Use free tier (10,000 chars/month) for testing only.

Generating The Second Set (Male/Female)

Repeat Steps 2–4 with the other voice target and ElevenLabs voice ID (Laura Bailey → female, Graham McTavish → male). Create a separate MO2 mod with a distinct pack name. Enable one at a time via the DBVO2 dropdown in SKSE Menu Framework.

Performance and Technical Workflow

MO2 Separator: Performance

Overview

This section owns the performance budgeting, optimization discipline, generated-patch pipeline, and long-term maintenance workflow that keeps Elder Wilds stable as the load order grows. The section is split into five sub-files that each own a distinct concern:

- Performance Strategy: budgeted performance analysis, VRAM-heavy mod review, CPU-heavy script review
- Optimization & Configuration: shader impact, grass/tree/draw-call optimization, INI tuning (BethINI Pie baseline), save safety
- Tool Pipeline: xEdit/Pandora/DynDOLOD/Synthesis workflow discipline, 4K LOD baseline (xLODGen/ TexGen/DynDOLOD STEP config), optional diagnostics (Recursion Monitor, S.L.A.C.K.)
- Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration: exact Wrye Bash tweak settings, Bash Tag per plugin, full Synthesis patcher pipeline (11 stages), build order and rebuild triggers
- Testing & Maintenance: benchmark methodology and scenarios, tuning knobs, patcher revisit triggers, generator output order, change tracking, MCM recording, mod update workflow

Sub-File Index

File	Section
modlist-performance-strategy.md	Performance Strategy
modlist-performance-optimization.md	Optimization & Configuration
modlist-performance-tools.md	Tool Pipeline
modlist-performance-patches.md	Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration
modlist-performance-testing.md	Testing & Maintenance

Key Principles

- Treat performance as four separate problems: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure. A fix that targets the wrong category makes things worse.
- Use the disciplined route for all generated work: keep every output in its own dedicated MO2 mod, rebuild only when the owning category changes, and run tools in a repeatable order.
- The Bashed Patch and Synthesis pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution. A tag or patcher exists only when a specific mod in the list requires it.
- The list's long-term health depends on disciplined rebuild habits, saved MCM profiles, and a documented changelog — not on any single mod pick.

Related Sections

- `modlist-foundations.md` — engine baseline, SSE Display Tweaks config, core stability fixes
- `modlist-graphics-shaders.md` — Community Shaders visual framework (performance envelope owned by `modlist-performance-optimization.md`)
- `modlist-curation.md` — curation rules and testing methodology

Performance Strategy

MO2 Separators: Performance → Performance - Strategy

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](`modlist-performance.md`) section.

—

Performance Budgeting → separator: Performance - Strategy

How Elder Wilds measures performance, identifies bottlenecks, and keeps generated workflow sane once the list gets heavy.

Baseline

- Budgeted route — Separate GPU, VRAM, CPU/script, and draw-call problems so fixes target the real cause.
- Treat performance as four different problems that can look similar: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure.
- Keep one repeatable forest scene, one city scene, and one dungeon/interior scene for comparisons.
- Record baseline and post-change captures with PresentMon and review in CapFrameX.
- Prefer a stable frame-time target over chasing the highest uncapped number.

Alternatives

- Intuition-first route — Change settings/mods by feel.
- Average-FPS route — Judge by headline FPS even if frame pacing and bottleneck type stay unclear.

Risks & Compatibility

- A single bad scene can be CPU-bound, GPU-bound, or content-bound in different directions.
- Average FPS can improve while hitching and traversal smoothness get worse.

—

VRAM-Heavy Mod Review → separator: Performance - Strategy

Texture resolution, PBR/parallax adoption, heavy shader features, and world coverage drive VRAM pressure. Spend texture budget where visible in normal play.

Baseline

- Selective route — High resolution only for hero assets, creatures, architecture, or landscape layers dominating the screen.
- Start below maximum resolution when a visual pack offers multiple sizes; scale up only if testing proves the asset earns it.
- Treat PBR/parallax conversions as a VRAM and maintenance choice, not just a screenshot upgrade.
- If a scene stutters, verify actual memory pressure before blaming scripts or AI.

Alternatives

- Max-detail route — Broad 4K coverage, frequent material upgrades.
- Restraint-first route — Mostly 2K and below with few exceptions.

Risks & Compatibility

- High VRAM usage can look like generic stutter, but lowering unrelated gameplay mods won't fix it.
- Some landscape/architecture/material upgrades cost more in aggregate than character textures ever will.

—

CPU-Heavy Script Review → separator: Performance - Strategy

CPU and Papyrus pressure comes from layered systems, NPC density, polling scripts, and constant background updates.

Baseline

- Moderated route — Keep strong feature mods, but avoid stacking several background-heavy systems solving similar jobs.
- Treat NPC expansion, survival layers, follower frameworks, reputation systems, defeat systems, and ambient event mods as cumulative load.
- Prefer one good system per gameplay problem instead of three lighter systems all ticking in the background.
- Keep diagnostic logging off during normal play unless a bug needs it.
- Judge script health through sleeping, waiting, cell changes, combat cleanup, and long travel.

Alternatives

- Permissive route — Allow multiple overlapping always-on systems.
- Strict route — Aggressively cut scripted features even when they materially help list identity.

Risks & Compatibility

- Script delay often misdiagnosed as low FPS or “Skyrim being Skyrim.”
- Mid-save uninstalls can create save instability looking like performance decay.
- A list can feel fine in short tests and still degrade over longer sessions.

Optimization & Configuration

MO2 Separators: Performance → Performance - Optimization & Configuration

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](modlist-performance.md) section.

—

Shader Performance Impact → separator: Performance - Optimization & Configuration

Baseline

- Conservative to balanced route — Accept a few heavier depth/lighting features once the rest of the visual stack is stable.
- Remove or downgrade luxury modules before tearing apart the rest of the graphics stack.
- Skyrim Upscaler is a fallback tool from → Graphics, not the first answer to poor optimization.
- Use SSE Display Tweaks from → Foundations to enforce stable frame cap.
- Judge shader cost in motion, weather transitions, and dense foliage scenes.

Alternatives

- Conservative route — Keep CS close to the section-02 baseline.
- Luxury route — Keep piling on expensive modules, then try to recover cost elsewhere.

—

Grass, Tree, And Draw-Call Optimization → separator: Performance - Optimization & Configuration

Baseline

- Content restraint first, then low-maintenance optimization.
- Lightened Skyrim — Leading optimization branch. Almost invisible cleanup, low drama.
- eFPS - Anniversary Edition ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/58727>)) — Optional only if exterior draw-call pressure still needs help after main world stack is stable. Plan for patch coverage.
- Re-evaluate exterior optimization after major city, roadside, tree, or world-content choices.

Risks & Compatibility

- eFPS has strong upside but real compatibility/patch overhead for lists with heavy exterior edits.
- Heavy cities, outskirts, roads, trees, and landmark mods can erase optimization gains faster than tweak mods can recover them.

—

INI Tuning And Display Settings → separator: Performance - Optimization & Configuration

Baseline

- Tool-first route — Use BethINI Pie as the baseline editor.
- Keep MO2 INI path behavior simple and documented.
- After baseline is set, keep only a short list of manual overrides justified by display/shadow/frame-cap targets.
- Let SSE Display Tweaks handle display behavior and frame pacing.

BethINI Pie Configuration Baseline

Run through MO2 targeting the active profile INIs.

1. Basic: Reset to Defaults → High preset → Apply Recommended Tweaks. Window Mode: Borderless. FOV: First Person 75, Third Person 85.
2. General → Saved Games: Untick Autosaves, Save on Travel, Save on Rest, Save on Wait (survival mods handle save restrictions; manual saves are safer).
3. Gameplay: Difficulty Adept. Untick Disable Kill Cam. Tick Remove Borders. Untick Tutorials.
4. Interface: Tick Dialogue Subtitles and General Subtitles. Leave Compass and Crosshair ticked. Untick Floating Quest Markers. Leave Controller Vibration ticked.
5. Environment: Grass Density 60. Untick Reflect Sky.
6. View Distance: Leave Tree LOD Distance at High default for now. Set to 0 via INI Editor before DynDOLOD generation later.
7. Visuals: Max Particle Render Count 7500. Untick Lens Flare (CS handles post-processing).
8. Click Save and Exit, then confirm values in MO2 → Tools → INI Editor.

—

Save Safety Considerations → separator: Performance - Optimization & Configuration

Baseline

- Disposable-test route — Keep clean labeled saves for pre-LOD, post-LOD, city-performance, forest-travel, and long-session stability.
- Start new game when adding major worldspace optimization layers (eFPS mod page recommends fresh-start caution).
- Don't treat old generated outputs, removed scripted mods, or stale occlusion data as safe just because the game still loads.
- Preserve one or two mature long-session saves only for validation.

Risks & Compatibility

- Save corruption can present as performance degradation long before it looks like hard failure.
- Reusing one heavily mutated test save makes optimization conclusions far less trustworthy.

Tool Pipeline

MO2 Separators: Performance → Performance - Tool Pipeline

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](modlist-performance.md) section.

—

Tool Workflow → separator: Performance - Tool Pipeline

A heavy Skyrim list usually becomes unstable through stale output and sloppy rebuild habits before failing through any one mod choice.

Baseline — Disciplined Route

- Run xEdit conflict review after each major category change.
- Re-run Pandora when behavior, animation, or skeleton-relevant content changes.
- Re-run Synthesis whenever a chosen patcher-based system changes (including music-merge from → Audio).
- Rebuild TexGen, xLODGen, DynD0LOD, grass cache, and occlusion output when their inputs materially change.
- Keep every generated output in its own dedicated MO2 mod.

Alternatives

- Ad hoc route — Rebuild whenever something looks broken.
- Late-everything route — Postpone most generated work until the end.

—

4K LOD Tool Baseline → separator: Performance - Tool Pipeline

General Rules

- Keep tools (xLODGen, TexGen, DynDOLOD) outside game folder and outside MO2 mod folders.
- Keep output folders outside Program Files, Steam, Documents, Desktop, and MO2 instance.
- Install finished output back into MO2 as separate mods: Terrain LOD Output, TexGen Output, DynDOLOD Output.
- Generate in this order: xLODGen → TexGen → DynDOLOD.
- Use x64 versions of tools.

xLODGen 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: xLODGenx64.exe -lodgen -SSE -o:"\<output path>".
- Use xLODGen only for terrain LOD.
- Use SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm as terrain-boundary resource (from STEP xLODGen forum; Mega mirrors available). Activate it only during xLODGen generation — place it below the last worldspace ESM in the right pane, then deactivate it afterward and reactivate Terrain LOD Output.
- In MO2, ensure any landscape/tree mods that ship LOD-generation resources (e.g., Majestic Mountains, Cathedral Landscapes) are active during xLODGen.
- In the xLODGen UI: right-click the Worldspace area → Select All. Tick only Terrain LOD. Apply LOD settings per STEP recommendations.
- 4K users: double diffuse and normal sizes for LOD4/LOD8/LOD16/LOD32.
- Initial LOD4: keep Optimize Unseen off. For map/LOD32: use higher Quality (0-10) and Optimize Unseen 550.
- After generation, run ACMOS Road Generator:
 1. Navigate to the ACMOS Road Generator tool folder and open the executable.
 2. Set the roads dropdown to Path Only.
 3. Browse to your xLODGen output folder and select it.
 4. Click Generate. If prompted to overwrite, click Yes.
 5. When complete, zip the output folder (the tool offers this automatically) and install it as a new mod via MO2's Add mod from file.

TexGen 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: TexGen64.exe -SSE.
- Run after xLODGen, before DynDOLOD.
- Preset matching rendered resolution: 2160p = 4K.
- Grass options: tick Grass if no complex grass; tick HD grass if using complex grass / CS grass features.
- TexGen_SSE.ini: GrassModelHeightMultiplier=1.15, TreeMSAlphaThreshold=144, ObjectMSAlphaThreshold=96.
- ForceComplexGrass: 0 (default) or 1 (STEP complex-grass branch).
- Move output to TexGen Output mod, enable before running DynDOLOD.

DynDOLOD 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: DynDOLODx64.exe -SSE.
- DynDOLOD_SSE.ini: Expert=1, Level32=1 AllHDL0D32=1.
- Grass brightness values: 0.500 for all R/G/B Top and Bottom channels.
- DoubleSidedTextureMask=mountain,mtn, DoubleSidedMeshMask=mountain,mtn.

- Complex grass branch: `ComplexGrassBillboard=5`, matching brightness values, `ComplexGrassBacklightMask=25`.
- GUI: right-click worldspace list → `Select All`. Tick `Candles` and `FXGlow`. Load the High rules preset.
- Occlusion only on first run. Grass LOD only if generating grass LOD.
- Ultra Trees: Enable 3D tree LOD for substantially better distant tree quality. Keep tile size at or below 1024 (diminishing returns beyond this).
- Target: 4K preset with Optimal tree/catch-all rules + recommended LOD32 rules.
- Move output to `DynDOLOD Output` mod. In the right pane: place `DynDOLOD.esm` as the last ESM after all worldspace ESMs, `DynDOLOD.esp` second-to-last, and `Occlusion.esp` last (unless using `Synthesis`, which goes last).
- Apply AC MOS-required rule edits in DynDOLOD's advanced rule editor: `Tree` → LOD32 set to `Billboard(6); \` → LOD32 set to `Level0`.

4K Validation

- Benchmark before and after LOD from clean Whiterun save. Also check the Rift (`cow tamriel 40 -24`) for aspens.
- If performance is already below STEP's pre-LOD target, lower the broader graphics baseline before blaming LOD.
- If travel performance still too expensive after LOD, step DynDOLOD from High → Medium/Low, skip Grass LOD.
- Document emergency tweaks next to the MO2 executable or output mod.

—

Optional Diagnostics And Performance Tools → separator: Performance - Tool Pipeline

Neither requires ongoing configuration or conflict maintenance once installed.

Recursion Monitor

- Nexus: [Recursion Monitor](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/76867>) — Detects broken Papyrus scripts stuck in recursive loops. Requires SKSE, Address Library.
- Updated fork: [recursion-fix-updated](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/179627>) (May 2026) — Removes blocking debug popup; writes to SKSE log instead. Prefer for production list.

S.L.A.C.K. (Save And Load Accelerator For SKSE Cosaves)

- Nexus: [S.L.A.C.K.](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/163969>) — Cosaves save up to 150× faster, load up to 15× faster. Error-friendly mode catches exceptions from other SKSE plugins' cosave handlers.
- Requires: SKSE 1.6.1170, Address Library, SSE Engine Fixes (SKSE64 Preloader).
- Safe to install or uninstall at any time.
- Complements [Seamless Saving](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/173161>) (targets main save serialisation, not cosaves). Safe to run both.

Log Watcher

- Nexus: [Log Watcher - Real-time Analysis of SKSE Logs](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/163979>) — Monitors SKSE logs in real-time for errors, warnings, and crash indicators. Diagnostic aid for testing and load-order debugging.

Risks & Compatibility

- Neither mod touches worldspace records, leveled lists, or asset files.
- Recursion Monitor is read-only in normal operation. Updated fork removes the only known compatibility concern.
- S.L.A.C.K. hooks SKSE's internal save/load API; error-friendly mode catches exceptions instead of crashing.
- Both are safe to remove from an existing save.

Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration

MO2 Separators: Performance → Performance - Bashed Patch & Synthesis

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](modlist-performance.md) section.

—

Patcher Discipline → separator: Performance - Bashed Patch & Synthesis

The generic category maps only become useful when tied to the actual mods Elder Wilds ships with. This section is that binding: exact Wrye Bash tweaks, Bash Tags per plugin, and Synthesis patcher pipeline in exact order. Default is “do not touch” — add a Synthesis patcher or Bash Tag only when a specific mod in the list makes it necessary.

—

Wrye Bash (Bashed Patch) Configuration → separator: Performance - Bashed Patch & Synthesis

Tweak Settings

Enable in Wrye Bash → Bashed Patch → Tweakers only the items below.

Tweak Actors:

- Opposite Gender Anims: Female and Male — needed for CBBE 3BA, HIMBO, KS Hairdos, EVG Conditional Idles, Goetia, Leviathan II packs.

Tweak Assorted:

- All Armor Playable — required by Immersive Armors (60+ sets with non-playable flag).
- No Light Fade Value Fix — CS Light, True Light, ELFX, Relighting Skyrim, Luminosity all interact with fade values.
- No Light Flicker — RAID Weathers, Cathedral, Obsidian, Azurite III CS weather variants.
- Remove Load Screen Models — SkyParkour v3, RaySense, Ricochet add 3D geometry that can leak into load screens.
- Save Sorting Fix — real issue with this much plugin weight.
- Set Light Radii — use 100% multiplier to leave lighting radii alone.
- Set Sound Attenuation Levels: Nirnroots Only — leave default.
- Uniform Groundcover — Skoglendi, Origins of Forest, Mari's flora need matching density variance.

Tweak Names:

- Body Part Codes — drive Sort: Armor/Clothes correctly with CBBE 3BA.
- Sort: Armor/Clothes — with Immersive Armors, Bruma, Spaghetti's Cities, unsorted inventory is unreadable.
- Sort: Scrolls, Sort: Spells, Sort: Weapons/Ammunition — Apocalypse, Mysticism, Odin, Adamant, Vokrii, Ordinator, Ars Metallica all add to these lists.
- Lore Friendly Text: Dwarven -> Dwemer — PBR textures use Dwemer terminology.

Tweak Races:

- Races Have All Head Parts — KS Hairdos adds hundreds; set types code to 45.
- Playable Head Parts
- Leave Force Behavior Graph Gender off — Elder Wilds does not standardize that flag.

Tweak Settings:

- AI: Bump Reaction Delay — raise to Adult Content to mute spammy follower reactions.
- AI: Conversation Chance — leave default.
- AI: Max Active Actors — raise to 80.
- AI: Max Dead Actors — raise to 120.
- Arrow: Max Arrows Attached to NPC — raise to 20.
- Combat: Max Actors — raise to 60.
- Combat: Stealth Damage Bonus — leave default (RAID is canonical authority).
- Msg: Cannot Equip Item Fix — must be enabled (Campfire, Frostfall, SunHelm/Starfrost/Last Seed rely on it).
- Msg: No Fast Travel — leave default.
- Player: Max Draggable Weight — set to 1000.
- Player: Underwater Breath Control — leave default.
- Soul Trap: Common/Grand/Greater/Lesser Soul Level — set to vanilla values.
- Visuals: Masser/Secunda Size/Speed — set to 1.0.

- Warning: Exterior/Interior Distance To Hostiles — leave default.
- World: Cell Respawn Time / Respawn Time (Cleared) — leave default.
- World: Timescale — set to 20 and never change. Save-baking warning: this setting bakes into SSE saves.

Bash Tags

Set the following Bash Tags on the listed plugins (one file per plugin under Data\Bash Patches\):

Leveled List / Economy:

- Immersive Weapons.esp — Relev
- Immersive Armors.esp — Relev
- Immersive Armors Retexture.esp — Graphics (retexture, not content add)
- Hunterborn.esp — Invent.Add, Delev, Relev
- Simple Fishing Overhaul.esp — Invent.Add, C.MiscFlags
- Streamlined Fishing.esp — Invent.Add
- Open World Loot.esp — Delev, Relev, C.Encounter
- MorrowLoot Ultimate.esp — Delev, Relev
- Trade and Barter.esp — Stats, Invent.Change
- Ars Metallica.esp — Stats, Invent.Change
- Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered.esp — Stats, Invent.Change
- Honed Metal.esp — Invent.Change
- Apothecary.esp — Invent.Add, Stats, Keywords
- CACO.esp — Invent.Add, Stats, Keywords
- Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments.esp — Stats, Keywords

Race / Perk / Magic:

- Aetherius.esp / Morningstar.esp / Imperious.esp — R.AddSpells (whichever wins)
- Adamant.esp / Vokrii.esp / Ordinator.esp — NPC.Perks.Change, NPC.Perks.Add
- Mysticism.esp / Odin.esp / Apocalypse.esp — SpellStats, EffectStats

Lighting / Weather / Water:

- CS Light.esp / True Light.esp — C.Light, C.ImageSpace
- ELFX.esp / ELFX - Shadows.esp — C.Light, C.Fog
- Relighting Skyrim.esp / Luminosity.esp — C.Light
- RAID Weathers.esp / Raid Weathers CS.esp — C.Climate, C.Music (if pack changes music)
- Cathedral Weathers.esp / Obsidian Weathers.esp / Obsidian - CS.esp — C.Climate
- Realistic Water Two.esp — C.Water
- A Water Made For CS in mind.esp — C.Water
- Simplicity of Sea.esp — C.Water
- Enhanced Rocks and Mountains.esp / Fix and Addon.esp — Graphics, ObjectBounds

City / Worldspace:

- Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE.esp — C.Climate, C.Music, C.Light, C.Water, C.ImageSpace, C.Location, C.Regions
- Spaghetti's Cities - AI0.esp — C.Light, C.MiscFlags
- The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE.esp / Dawn of Skyrim (Director's Cut) SE.esp / JK's Skyrim.esp — C.Light, C.MiscFlags

NPC / Dialogue / Audio:

- RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION.esp / RUSTIC CLOTHING.esp — Names, Stats
- High Poly Project.esp — Graphics, ObjectBounds
- KS Hairdos SSE.esp — Graphics, Names
- High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul.esp — Graphics, Names, Actors.Stats

- RD0.esp — Actors.AIPackages, Actors.Spells
- Amorous Adventures.esp (clean) — Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd, Actors.SpellsForceAdd, Invent.Add
- Marriage Mod - To Have And To Hold.esp — Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd, Actors.Factions
- Serana Dialogue Add-On.esp — Actors.AIPackages, Actors.Spells
- Pilgrim.esp / Trua.esp / Wintersun.esp — Actors.Spells (whichever wins)
- Book of Shadows.esp — Actors.Spells
- Skyrim Reputation.esp — Actors.Factions, Relations.Add
- Suspicious City Guards.esp — Actors.AIPackages
- Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE.esp — Sound
- Immersive Sounds - Compendium.esp — Sound
- Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE.esp — Sound, C.Acoustic

Survival / Follower:

- Campfire.esp — C.MiscFlags, Invent.Add
- Frostfall.esp — C.Climate, C.ImageSpace
- Starfrost.esp / SunHelm.esp / Last Seed.esp — Stats, Keywords, Invent.Add (whichever wins)
- Nether's Follower Framework.esp / EFF.esp / Amazing Follower Tweaks SE.esp — Actors.Factions, Invent.Add

No Tags: TrueHUD.esp, Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer.esp

—

Synthesis Configuration → separator: Performance - Bashed Patch & Synthesis

The Synthesis patcher pipeline runs as a single batch via Run Mutagen in MO2, output to Patches\Synthesis Patch.esp. Patchers listed in run order — do not reorder.

Stage 1 — NPC, AI, And Facegen

- KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer
- High Poly Head Vampire Fix
- HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART
- FacegenBaseline — after all NPC overhauls installed; fallback to zEdit FaceGen patcher if needed.
- NPCStatRescaler
- AIOverhaulPatcher / ICAIO AI for Mods
- AI Stealth Overhaul — with RAID.
- Followers-are-Sneaky
- FollowerFavorCarryLimitPatcher
- NpcProtector — flags essential quest NPCs.
- RaceCompatibilityDialogue
- RacialHeights / HarmonizedRaceHeights-Patcher
- SynBanditWarForwarder
- SynOppositeGenderAnimsTweak — do not enable (Bashed Patch handles this).

Stage 2 — Encounter Zones

- EZLeveler — configure to unleveled-band target for OWL/MLU.
- EnemyReleveler — delevel Bruma/Falskaar/Wyrmstooth enemies within new band.
- No More Easy Enemies
- EncounterZoneNames / CellEncounterLevelsInName
- MissingEncounterZonesPatcher
- TrueUnleveledSkyrim — only if dropping OWL and MLU.

Stage 3 — Leveled Lists And Loot

- OWLLeveledListAddition — adds IA/IW to OWL lists.
- OWLPatcher
- Skyrim-LeveledLoot
- HalgarisConsistentRPGLOot
- Container and Loot Patcher
- LootableCrates, MakeFirewoodPilesIntoContainers, Lootable Things & Training Dummies Patcher
- GeneralStoresIngredientsPatcher
- ImmersiveMusicPatcher / MusicTypePatcher-Revised-2024
- leveledlistresolver — after OWL and MLU.
- Feminized Leveled Lists / Masculinized Leveled Lists

Stage 4 — Items, Crafting, Alchemy

- ApothecaryAutoPatcher — pair with CACO Patcher if CACO in stack.
- BreakdownRecipeGenerator / CreateTemper
- HonedMetalAdditionalIngredients
- Heim Recipe Patcher
- ReProccer Evolved

- Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/149027>)) — Elder Wilds config: Damage Floor 4, Ceiling 22, Weight/Value Scale 1.0, Speed/Reach Normalization ON. Ignore List: Reliquary of Myth, ArteFakes, Unique Items Tweaks, Konahrik's Accoutrements. Run after OWLLeveledListAddition, SpeedandReachFixes, AmmoTweaks.
- SpeedandReachFixes
- WeaponSpeedEffectsFix
- SynFixShieldData / SynFixWeaponAttackSpeed
- SynGlovesAddFirstsPerk
- ItemWeightCustomizer / SynPotionWeight
- SlotsSlotsSlots
- AmmoTweaks
- SynCGOStaves — only if CGO staves in stack.

Stage 5 — Magic, Spells, Enchanting

- Engarde_Synthesis
- DisenchantEverything / SmartDisenchantEverything
- Passive Enchanting Experience
- Spell Research Synthesizer — only if Spell Research added.
- StaffGenerator / StaffDuplicator
- SorcererPatcher
- ReadingIsGoodLegacy
- AllBooksHavePerks
- SpellTomePriceFixPatcher / SynSpellTomeNameExtender / DisplaySpellTomeLevelPatcher-local / spelltome_yeeter — pick one.
- SynESLify — must be last in this stage.

Stage 6 — Snow, Weather, Region

- BDSPatcher — required. Use BDSPatcher entry (not Northpoint variant). Run with both BetterDynamicSnow and BetterDynamicAsh keywords active.
- SSBGPatcher
- Nights Adjuster / Darker Weather Nights — pick one.
- SkyVRaan Weather Patcher — only if installed.
- Unique Region Names / Unique Region Names Patcher
- RealisticWaterTwoPatcher
- Synthesis-BlendedShorelinesUniversal
- LandscapePatcher — only enable if landscape texture stack replaced.
- DestructibleSkyrimPatcher

Stage 7 — Trees, Flora, Mesh

- Pine Tree Rescaler
- Tree Scaler, Tree 3D Editor, TreeWindEditor
- FloraFixer
- ImmersiveEquipmentMeshGen / AllGUDMeshGen
- Harvest Those Mammoth Tusks

Stage 8 — Visuals And Lighting

- ELE Patcher — skip (CS-only stack).
- NoShadowsPatch
- Radial Blur Remover

- Remove Edge Glow
- RemoveInteriorFogPatcher — disable if AOS/Sounds of Skyrim present.
- RemoveLandscapeVertexColor

Stage 9 — Audio

- AOSISCSoundPatcher — required. AOS and ISC both must be active when run.
- TUDMFootstepPatcher
- Sounds of Seasons
- SFCOPaintingRemover

Stage 10 — Performance And Cleanup

- Grass FPS
- Configurable Grass Remover — enable only if dense forest-floor route adopted.
- NavmeshCollector-Updated — do not enable if Bruma or Falskaar in stack.
- Generic Synthesis Patcher — keep ruleset empty until specific conflict identified.

Stage 11 — Utility, Compatibility, ESLification

- Patchifier — generates SkyPatcher/INI patches.
- SynEDIDFixer
- SynStringMerger — disable unless shipping translation layer.
- CellEditorIDFixer — required (Bruma, Falskaar, Wyrmostooth, Beyond Reach).
- SynPEXPatcher
- SynPerkCOBJPatcher / SynESLify — keep at end, ESLify output.

—

Build Order And Rebuild Triggers

The full rebuild order for the generated pipeline. Stages after SSEEdit can be skipped if their inputs have not changed — rebuild only the affected stages when their triggers fire.

1. SSEEdit — quick-conflict mode after every new plugin.
2. Bashed Patch — triggers: any plugin with Bash Tag change, any tweak setting change, any new tagged plugin. A Bash Tag change also triggers Synthesis (stage 3) — both must rebuild.
3. Synthesis — triggers: any patcher list change, any upstream mod change, any Bash Tag change.
4. Pandora — triggers: behavior/animation/skeleton change. Independent of patcher and LOD stages — can be run separately at any point.
5. BodySlide — triggers: body/skin/armor mesh change. Independent of patcher and LOD stages.
6. xLODGen — triggers: landscape/terrain/heightmap change (does not need TexGen).
7. TexGen — triggers: object/tree/building texture or mesh change producing LOD billboards. Requires xLODGen output when both are rebuilt together.
8. Grass Cache — triggers: grass mod change, worldspace change (Grass SSEEdit Script), or grass density INI tweak. Run after final worldspace load order is established.
9. DynDOLOD — triggers: worldspace/tree/object change, Bashed Patch or Synthesis change (form IDs affect reference records), or any xLODGen/TexGen output change. Includes Occlusion generation. Run twice: Medium to verify, final preset.
10. SSE Display Tweaks + BethINI Pie — final review after lighting/weather/graphics stack change.

Dependency note: DynDOLOD reads the final load order including Bashed Patch and Synthesis. If Synthesis changes form IDs or ESL flags, DynDOLOD must be rebuilt. Pandora and BodySlide do not affect LOD or patchers and can be run independently at any point without cascading into later stages.

Patcher Load Order

- Bashed Patch and Synthesis both write into same load-order range. Place Synthesis patch last unless a known conflict needs Bashed Patch to win.
- SynESLify must be last in its stage.
- World: Timescale = 20 bakes into saves — never change on a long-running test save.
- Skyrim-LeveledList and OWL overlap: run OWLLeveledListAddition first.
- AOSISCSoundPatcher requires both AOS and ISC active.
- HP_NPC_WIGS_T0_HEADPART before KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer.
- NavmeshCollector-Updated dangerous with Bruma and Falskaar.
- Record Bashed Patch CRC after every rebuild. Verify by disabling source mods and confirming patch shrinks.

Key Principles

- The patch pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution.
- A patcher or tag exists because a specific mod in the list requires it — never pre-install speculative coverage.
- The rebuild order is designed so a category change only triggers the affected stages.

Testing & Maintenance

MO2 Separators: Performance → Performance - Testing & Maintenance

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](modlist-performance.md) section.

—

Performance Testing And Tuning → separator: Performance - Testing & Maintenance

The goal is consistent frametimes — not just a high average FPS — across the scenarios you actually play.

Tools

Tool	Purpose
NVIDIA FrameView	Lightweight overlay/logging: FPS, frametime, GPU power, thermals. No CPU per-core but lower overhead.
MSI Afterburner + RivaTuner	Full overlay/logging: FPS, frametime, GPU usage, CPU per-core, VRAM, draw calls, temps.
GPU-Z	Sensor logging for GPU clock, voltage, thermals, power limits.
Community Shaders debug overlay	Press F11 for render-time breakdown, draw-call count, VRAM usage.
SSE Display Tweaks OSD	Set ShowOSD=true in SSEDisplayTweaks.ini for basic overlay.
Skyrim console tools	showstats for real-time overlay; sg _{tm} 0.3 slows to 30% for inspecting stutter; t _{fc} 1 freezes camera.
Cathedral Assets Optimizer	Downscale uncompressed/oversized textures for VRAM relief.

Benchmark Methodology

1. Create a stable reference save with fixed weather (fw 10a240), fixed time (set gamehour to 12), t_{fc} 1 for reproducible screenshots. Save as benchmark_ref.ess.
2. Use fixed routes — same save, same path for 60 seconds.
3. Log everything via MSI Afterburner or NVIDIA FrameView CSV.
4. Test one change at a time.

Benchmark Scenarios

Scenario	Location	Teleport	What It Tests
Open world	Whiterun plains west	cow WhiterunWorld -10 0	GPU/CPU balance, grass density, LOD load
Dense forest	Falkreath woods	cow FalkreathWorld -30 -20	Tree rendering, shadow complexity
Pine/marsh transition	Morthal swamp edge	cow HjaalmarchWorld -15 -10	Wetland shaders, mist, mixed flora
City centre (canals)	Riften marketplace	cow RiftenWorld 0 0	NPC count, water reflections, transitions
City centre (castles)	Solitude exterior	cow SolitudeWorld 0 0	Draw calls, shadow cascades, occlusion
Snowy tundra	Dawnstar coast	cow WinterholdWorld 10 5	Snow shaders, volumetric fog
Waterfall coast	Coast near Solitude	cow Tamriel -22 -4	Water displacement, foam, coastal LOD
Large interior	Blackreach	cow Blackreach 0 0	Particle lights, mesh density, alpha sorting

Large combat	Fort Neugrad assault	cow WhiterunWorld 15 -5 then run	AI packages, magic FX, simultaneous actors
Dragon encounter	Open world	player.placeatme 000FEA9F	Skeleton, shout VFX, cell transition
Magic VFX stress	Dense combat + spells	cow WhiterunWorld 0 0 then spawn dragon + 3 fire mages	Simultaneous particles, glow shaders, shadows
Heavy weather	Solstheim ash storm	cow SolstheimWorld 0 0 with fw 10A1E8	Particles, alpha-heavy weather, fog

Record Per Scenario

- Average FPS
- Frametime 99th percentile (stutter floor — >50ms means visible hitches)
- GPU usage % (below 90% = CPU bottleneck)
- VRAM usage (within 500MB of card total = stutter risk)
- Draw calls (above 10,000 = CPU struggling)

Tuning Knobs (Ordered By Impact)

Stop once worst-case scenario is playable.

1. Grass density (BethINI > Environment > Grass Density). 40-60 range.
2. Grass render distance (BethINI > View Distance > Grass LOD Fade). Drop to 50-70 for forest gains.
3. Shadow resolution (BethINI > Visuals > Shadow Resolution). 2048 is sweet spot.
4. Particle count (BethINI > Visuals > Max Particle Render Count). 7500 baseline; drop to 5000 if fire/frost causes framedrops.
5. Tree LOD distance — keep fTreeLoadDistance=0 (DynDOLOD manages).
6. Object LOD fade — drop fMeshLODLevel2FadeTreeDistance to 6144, fMeshLODLevel1FadeTreeDistance to 8192.
7. VSync / framerate cap — use SSE Display Tweaks LockFrameRate=60, VSync=0.
8. Skyrim Upscaler — if GPU is bottleneck, enable with Quality preset.

When To Accept

- Occasional microstutter on cell border crossing is normal (Engine Fixes already mitigates).
- Combat in tight spaces with 6+ actors + magic VFX: if avg FPS >40 with no hitch >100ms, call it stable.
- If a specific mod cuts FPS 30%+ vs its branch alternative, consider swapping.

Benchmark Reports

Export to CSV (NVIDIA FrameView Save CSV, MSI Afterburner History > Log to file). Keep a benchmark-sheet.md:

Pass	Scenario	Avg FPS	1% Low	GPU%	VRAM	Hitch Max	Delta vs Prev
1	Whiterun	58	42	92%	6.1G	48ms	—

Every tuning attempt recorded in git alongside modlist changes.

—

Maintenance And Rebuild Epilogue → separator: Performance - Testing & Maintenance

Patcher Revisit Triggers

Patcher	Trigger	Settings Worth Tweaking
LOOT	Every meaningful load-order change	No custom tweaks
Synthesis	Patcher list change, upstream mod added/removed/updated, Bash Tag change on any plugin	Weapon Stat Synth: raise/lower Damage Ceiling; add to Ignore List for new artifact mods
Wrye Bash	Bash Tag change on any plugin, tweak setting change, new tagged plugin, or leveled-list-heavy mod added/removed	No per-run settings unless Bashed Patch imports unintended items
Pandora	Animation mod added/removed/reordered; skeleton or behavior change	Direct output to Pandora Output
BodySlide	Body preset/skin texture/armor mod change	No per-run settings beyond chosen preset
Grass Cache	Grass/tree/landscape texture/worldspace change; density INI tweak	Rebuild from scratch
xLODGen	Landscape texture/heightmap/worldspace change; terrain LOD mod change	Quality slider per-run for coastline artefacts
TexGen	Object/tree/building texture changes producing LOD billboards; tree mod swaps	Revisit GrassModelHeightMultiplier and TreeMSAlphaThreshold
DynDOLOD	Worldspace/tree/large-reference/LOD resource change; TexGen output change; Bashed Patch or Synthesis change (form IDs affect reference records)	Brightness/Contrast for LOD32; DoubleSidedTextureMask for new mountain types

Generator Output Order (First-Time Build)

Run in this sequence when generating outputs for the first time. Independent outputs (Pandora, BodySlide) are generated earlier here than in the canonical → [rebuild order](modlist-performance-patches.md) because they can be iterated on while patchers are still in flux. The final LOD sequence (xLODGen → TexGen → Grass Cache → DynDOLOD) matches the rebuild order exactly.

1. SSEEdit — quick-conflict check after every major mod addition
2. Pandora — after animation stack stabilizes
3. BodySlide — after body/armor changes stabilize
4. Bashed Patch — after load order is stable enough for tagging
5. Synthesis — patchers the final stack actually uses
6. xLODGen — terrain LOD first
7. TexGen — before DynDOLOD
8. Grass Cache — after grass/landscape/worldspace choices stabilize
9. DynDOLOD — last major output (includes Occlusion generation)
10. SSE Display Tweaks + BethINI Pie — final review after graphics baseline is set

After generation, verify: DynDOLOD.esm at end of ESM block, DynDOLOD.esp near end, Occlusion.esp after, Synthesis.esp/Bashed Patch per tool guidance.

Change Tracking

Keep changelog.txt or build-notes.md in Output separator recording: date/scope of each re-run, settings differing from baseline, branch choices changed, manual INI tweaks, reference-save used.

MCM Settings Recording

1. Screenshot each MCM page; store in MCM-Reference under Output separator.
2. Use MCM Recorder ([Nexus](<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/24113>)) — record/replay via JSON profiles.
3. Cross-check on rebuild.

Mod Update Workflow

1. Read the mod's changelog before updating.
2. Minor version with no record/script changes: replace in-place, re-run LOOT.
3. Records, scripts, or dependencies change: treat as new install — disable old, install new, run LOOT, check xEdit conflicts, re-run affected patchers.
4. Never update DynDOLOD/TexGen/xLODGen mid-playthrough without verifying output is functionally identical. Start new game after LOD regeneration when in doubt.

Playing Forward

Two installations of Elder Wilds can look quite different while following the same guide. The rule: whatever you changed, note it, and re-run only the patchers whose upstream input changed.

Modlist Separators

Flat separator names sorted by MO2 left-pane load order. Parent categories anchor the hue; sub-separators step up in lightness for visible differentiation.

Foundations (blue) -#1a3a6b Foundations- -#255792 Foundations – SKSE & Scripts- -#3173b8 Foundations – Core Libraries- -#4a8fd4 Foundations – Mesh & Texture Fixes- -#6aaae8 Foundations – Targeted Bugfixes-

Graphics (green) -#0d4a0d Graphics- -#196a19 Graphics – PGPatchers- -#268a26 Graphics – Community Shaders- -#35a835 Graphics – Textures & Meshes- -#46c446 Graphics – Lighting- -#59d859 Graphics – Weather & Water- -#70e870 Graphics – Terrain & Flora- -#88f088 Graphics – Characters & Creatures- -#a2f5a2 Graphics – LOD & Distant Detail-

UI (cyan/teal) -#1b5a68 UI- -#2a7c8c UI – Framework & HUD- -#3e9eb0 UI – Inventory & Items- -#5cbcc9 UI – Map, Dialogue, Menus-

Animations (red-orange) -#7a1a0a Animations- -#962d18 Animations – Framework- -#b44328 Animations – Movement & Idles- -#d05c3a Animations – Combat- -#e47850 Animations – Interactions & Traversal- -#ea9870 Animations – Creatures-

Third-Person (amber/gold) -#7a5010 Third-Person- -#926a20 Third-Person – Camera & Movement- -#aa8430 Third-Person – Combat & Targeting- -#c4a044 Third-Person – Mounted-

Expanded Systems (purple) -#3a1070 Expanded Systems- -#52258a Expanded Systems – Character & Progression- -#6c3aa6 Expanded Systems – Magic & Perks- -#8759bf Expanded Systems – Survival & Needs- -#a27cd4 Expanded Systems – Crafting & Economy- -#bba0e6 Expanded Systems – Followers & Reputation-

World Feel (brown/amber) -#6b3a10 World Feel- -#875020 World Feel – Timescale & Travel- -#a56830 World Feel – Soundscapes- -#c08448 World Feel – Nights & Wildlife- -#d4a264 World Feel – Cities & Landmarks-
World Content (olive green) -#4a6b18 World Content- -#608722 World Content – Overhauls- -#78a530 World Content – Quests- -#90ba48 World Content – Homes & Bases- -#aacf6a World Content – Underwater-
NPCs (rose) -#7a1a3a NPCs- -#9D385B NPCs – Appearance- -#C0567C NPCs – Population- -#E3759D NPCs – Followers-
Enemies & Creatures (bronze) -#8B5E3C Enemies & Creatures-
Audio (royal blue) -#1e2a8a Audio- -#3a4abc Audio – Music- -#5a70d4 Audio – SFX & Ambience-
Survival & Combat (red) -#6b1010 Survival & Combat- -#8a1e1e Survival & Combat – Difficulty & Lethality- -#a82e2e Survival & Combat – Enemy AI- -#c25050 Survival & Combat – Resources & Injuries-
Weapons & Armor (steel) -#5A6B7A Weapons & Armor- -#6E8294 Weapons & Armor – Weapons- -#8299AC Weapons & Armor – Armor- -#96AFC2 Weapons & Armor – Artifacts- -#AAC5D8 Weapons & Armor – Clothing & Wardrobe-
Standalone separators -#C49A31 Legacy of the Dragonborn- -#808080 Testing & Curation- -#2F937A Performance- -#3DAD8F Performance – Strategy- -#4DC7A3 Performance – Optimization & Configuration- -#5FDFB6 Performance – Tool Pipeline- -#74F4C9 Performance – Bashed Patch & Synthesis- -#8CFFD9 Performance – Testing & Maintenance- -#A52786 Adult Content- -#49389F Voicing-
-#6B6B6B Patches- -#474747 Output-